SRE / sysreseval Documentation

IUT d'Orsay, Université Paris-Saclay

UTILISATION

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CHAPTER

ONE

OVERVIEW

SysResEval (or **SRE**, for *Système Réseaux Évaluation*) is a software suite for managing exercise sessions and evaluations in network and system administration courses. It is built on top of the Kathara framework, using Docker containers and VDE networking.[1]

It was developed at **IUT d'Orsay, Université Paris-Saclay** (France).

SysResEval can be used by students autonomously, in supervised exercise sessions, or in time-limited evaluations.

Students interact only with a GUI, `sysreseval`, which calls the `sre` CLI on their behalf through the small `sre-wrapper` setuid helper The instructor can also use the CLI to set up an exam, start a project for a student, connect to a machine, launch an eval, etc…

1.1 Student Workflow

The student starts the **sysreseval** GUI, then chooses and opens a *lab*.[2] Each lab presents several tabs:

- **Schema** — the network topology. By default, machines that disallow connection are drawn in red, but every lab can override colors and shapes for machines and networks. Some machines may be hidden from the diagram entirely.
- **Informations** — general background and instructions, written in Markdown.
- **Questions** — a list of items the student must complete. Each question is one of:
  - a Markdown text describing a task to perform on the machines (e.g. *configure the network on m1*),
  - a form whose fields capture specific facts (e.g. *what is the MTU of `eth0` on m1?*); fields may be free-text validated by a regexp (e.g. an IPv4 address), a multi-line text area, a dropdown, or a checkbox,
  - a free-form multi-line text answer.
- **Terminals** — an embedded shell for each machine the student is allowed to connect to. A lab may expose these as plain root shells or, for example, as a `login` prompt that restricts students to a particular user account.
- **Machines** — a status table for each machine: state, NAT network, exposed ports. The students can use it to launch separate terminals sessions to a machine (useful when several terminal sessions are needed on one machine)

[1] A first version was made with Marionnet and then rebuilt from scratch on Kathara / Docker.
[2] The word *lab* comes from Kathara (and Netkit). We use *lab* and *project* interchangeably in this documentation.

- **Networks** — the networks of the lab with their type: hub, switch or manageable switch. A manageable switch has VLANs and a console, which the students may open from this tab when the lab allows it (see *Hubs, switches and VLANs*).
- **Evaluations** — lets the student trigger an automated evaluation of their work and view the resulting grade table.
- **Apply Configuration** — lets the student put the project into a predefined state, for example a partial correction.

The **Questions**, **Evaluations**, and **Apply Configuration** tabs are optional and are shown only when the lab defines them.

Multiple labs can be open at once, letting a course be structured by topic instead of by session.

1.2 Monitoring of a session

During an exercices session, an instructor with the `sre watch` tool can monitor a whole class:

- consult the last evaluation result of any student (evaluations run periodically — the interval is a per-project parameter, typically one minute — even when the student does not trigger a self-evaluation).
- be alerted about any error during evaluations or by the lack of a recent evaluation
- display a list of all "grade elements" and the max, min and average grade of the students

The grade elements shown to the instructor can differ from those the student sees during a self-evaluation. For example, on a static routing exercise, the instructor may see detailed items (IPv4 address, default route, indirect route toward network A, etc.) while the student only sees a single "Configuration of machine m1".

1.3 Running exams

sysreseval manages time-limited exams. The instructor configures the exam and sysreseval starts each student's project — either immediately or at a scheduled time — displays a countdown, runs periodic evaluations (by default every 60 seconds), and shows a banner when the allotted time is up.

The instructor can change the duration during the exam, or even after it ends — the virtual machines are not stopped at the end (in practice, it is often easier to set a single duration for the whole class with a `dsh` call, then adjust it individually for students with special accommodations)

The student's final mark is the best overall grade across their evaluations.

1.4 Post-exam workflow

Each evaluation produces an archive file containing all of its data, readable via `sre cat`. If a student questions their score, the instructor can give a full explanation — for example, for a question about routing, by showing the output of `ip route` on m1 to reveal which routes were in place at the time. During exams, all terminal sessions are also recorded as asciinema files.

After the exam, the instructor can re-run the evaluation script — for instance to adjust the relative weight of items, or to fix a bug in the script — and then generate a per-student PDF with a detailed item-by-item breakdown, plus a recap ODS spreadsheet.

1.5 Web server (remote use)

The students can also work from a **browser**, without the `sysreseval` GUI and without a remote desktop: a web site, `sre-web`, authenticates them (an LDAP directory, or anonymous users) and shows the same tabs as the GUI — the schema, the informations, the questions, the terminals (through WebSockets), the evaluations, the configurations to apply. The projects run on a **pool of Docker hosts** (typically the workstations of the classrooms), each driven by an agent, `sre-agent`, which runs the `sre` CLI on behalf of the web users exactly as the GUI does; a new project goes to the least loaded host, and sleeping hosts can be woken up when the pool fills up.

The instructors get a **Watch page**, the web counterpart of `sre watch`, can **open the project of a student** to help them (both see and type in the same terminals), and can **present** a project, their own or a student's, on the browsers of the whole class or of chosen students: what they do on their own page is shown at once on the students' browsers.

Exams are not run on the web: a host in exam mode leaves the pool. See *Web server (remote use)*.

CHAPTER

TWO

EXAM ADMINISTRATION

2.1 Lifecycle at a glance

The model is **declarative**: the instructor writes a single file, `/var/lib/sre/exam.json`, and the GUI on each student PC does the rest. Two invariants make this work:

- **`exam.json` is the trigger.** Its presence puts the GUI in exam mode; its contents determine the current phase, the countdowns, and what to fire next. The instructor's only job is to create, edit, or delete this file — via `sre set-exam` and `sre del-exam`. The GUI polls it once per second and fires `pre-start-exam`, `start-exam`, `eval-exam`, and `end-exam` at the appropriate moments.
- **Every exam command is idempotent.** Each one can be re-run safely, which is what lets the GUI recover from transient failures and react to mid-exam edits. The instructor can extend the duration, add or remove a lab, or push back the end time at any point by editing `exam.json` (via `sre set-exam`); the change propagates within one second.

```
[Instructor]                          [GUI on each student PC, polling exam.json @ 1 Hz]
     |                                          |
     |  sre set-exam --labs tp1 \               |
     |    --start-after 09:00 \                 |  ← exam.json appears
     |    --end-before  11:00 \                 |
     |    --duration    120                     |
     |    --eval-interval 60                    |
     |                                          |
     |                              Phase: WAITING
     |                              • shows logo + countdown to 09:00
     |                              • ~60 s before start_after, sysreseval GUI fires
     |                                sre pre-start-exam (pulls images,
     |                                starts containers, writes pre_start_date)
     |                                          |
     +-- 09:00 ------------------------------->|
     |                              Phase: ACTIVE
     |                              • once projects are up, sysreseval GUI fires
     |                                sre start-exam (stamps started_at)
     |                              • shows remaining-time countdown
     |                              • fires sre eval-exam every 60 s
     |                              • student works, may self-grade
     |                                          |
     +-- 11:00 (or started_at + 120 min) ---->|
     |                              Phase: ENDED
```

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```
    |                              • sysreseval GUI fires sre end-exam once
    |                                (final concurrent eval + stamps ended_at)
    |                              • shows "That's All Folks"
    |                                        |
    |  sre del-exam                          |
    |  (removes exam.json, wipes projects)   |
    |  sre sheet / outline / re-eval         |  ← post-exam grading
```

2.2 Setting up an exam — `sre set-exam`

```
# Minimal - one lab, hard end time. No start time means "open immediately".
sre set-exam --labs s4/tp_ssh --end-before 11:00

# With some more options example
sre set-exam \
  --labs s4/tp_ssh s4/tp_dhcp:hard \
  --start-after  2026-06-15T09:00 \
  --end-before   2026-06-15T11:00 \
  --duration     90 \
  --eval-interval 30
```

In this case, each student gets 90 minutes, but every exam ends at 11:00 — even for students who start after 9:30.

Behaviour:

- **Incremental updates.** Only the options provided on the command line are written; everything else is preserved. `sre set-exam --duration 150` extends an in-progress exam without touching `labs` or `start_after`.
- **First-time requirements.** If `exam.json` does not yet exist, `--labs` is required, and so is at least one of `--end-before` / `--duration` (otherwise the exam would never end).
- **Date formats.** Both `--start-after` and `--end-before` accept full datetimes (`2026-06-01T09:00`, `2026-06-01 09:00`, `2026-06-01T09:00:00`) and time-only (`09:00`, `09:00:00`) — time-only is combined with today's date.
- **Lab validation.** Each lab name is checked against `sre list` (`get_lab_list(include_exam_only_labs=True)`); absolute paths must lie under `params.authorized_src_dir` (`/opt/sre/lab/` or `/home/admin1/`, etc..).
- **Resetting `start_after` resets state.** Changing `--start-after` clears `pre_start_date` and `started_at` so the GUI re-triggers `pre-start-exam` and `start-exam` for the new run.
- **Mis-exam edits.** Anything in `exam.json` may be changed while the exam is running; the GUI picks up changes within 1 s.
- **relative duration change**. During an exam, `--duration +X` or `--duration -X` add or substract X minutes.
-

Option	Effect
`--labs <lab[:fl ...>`	Authorised labs; `:flavor` selects a named `Flavor` preset (e.g. `tp1:hard`). Required when creating.
`--start- <dt>`	Exam opens after this moment. If omitted, the exam is considered open immediately.
`--end-be <dt>`	Exam closes after this moment, regardless of `started_at`.
`--durati <min>`	Hard cap on duration; the exam ends at `started_at + duration` *or* `end_before`, whichever fires first. Only effective once `started_at` is set. When updating an existing `exam.json` that already has a `duration` field, prefix the value with `+` or `-` to adjust the current duration (e.g. `--duration +30` adds 30 min, `--duration -15` subtracts 15 min).
`--eval-i <sec>`	Automatic-eval period (default 60).
`--record <bool>`	Record terminal sessions (`true`/`false`/`0`/`no`). Default `true`.

See *Exam Reference* for how the GUI drives the exam (phase computation and per-phase actions).

2.3 Monitoring an exam

Once each student machine mirrors its archives into a shared directory subtree on the instructor's machine (see the Installation chapter), `sre watch <directory>` provides a live dashboard of the exam:

- **Remaining time and latest grade** per student.
- **Inactivity alerts** when no new archive has appeared for a student in the last X seconds — usually a sign that `sysreseval` crashed or the machine was shut down.
- **Evaluation-error alerts** flagging any error raised by the last eval. A well-written lab should never produce errors; if a command is legitimately allowed to fail, pass `allow_error=True` to `Grade.cmd()` so the failure is not reported.

The dashboard shows **one row per running project instance** (hostname, lab and start time), so a student who opened the same lab twice gets two rows, each with its own grade and alerts, instead of one row whose grade jumps between the two. A lab that was stopped and started again also keeps its old row, with an inactivity alert, until you dismiss it (`P` key) or hide it (`S` key). To see a single row per student and lab, the most recently started instance, run `sre watch -L <directory>` or press `L` in the dashboard. See *CLI Reference* for the other options and keys.

2.3.1 Clean up after an exam

```
sre del-exam
```

Removes `exam.json` and wipes every running project. Archive directories are preserved.

Note: in exam mode, quitting the GUI does not stop the Docker containers (unlike normal mode), so the instructor can keep them running afterwards — for instance to re-run a corrected version of the project if a bug surfaces during the exam.

2.4 Exam-only labs

Lab names containing any substring from `params.exam_only_affix = ["_EXAM_", "_OLD_", "_DRAFT_", "_TESTS_"]` are hidden from `sysreseval`'s lab picker. This is how you keep an exam lab invisible until it appears in `exam.json`:

- `/opt/sre/lab/s4/ssh_EXAM_final.py` — hidden from listings, but allowed in `--labs`.
- `/opt/sre/lab/_DRAFT_/work_in_progress.py` — hidden in any subdirectory whose name contains a flagged affix.

`sre set-exam --labs ...` and all the commands from privileged users (`sre start...`) accept hidden labs of course.

2.5 Post-exam workflow

2.5.1 Inspect a single archive

```
sre cat --grades --answers /var/lib/sre/archives/20260615110000_*.zst
```

Field option	Shows
`--grades`	Per-element grades, total grade, max
`--answers`	Student answers (incl. login, hostname, fullname, email, exam timing)
`--errors`	Errors raised during grading
`--tests`	Raw test results per machine (large)
`--data`	Serialized `Data` instance for the lab
`--files` / `--extract-files`	List or extract files saved into the archive
`--json`	One JSON dict per file on stdout (script-friendly)

2.5.2 Re-grade with a corrected project file

If a grading bug surfaces during the exam, fix-it and re-grade every archive:

```
sre re-eval -s /opt/sre/lab/_EXAM_/ssh_corrected.py \
            -p corrected \
            -d /tmp/regraded \
            -r /home/a/results/
```

Output archives appear in `/tmp/regraded/` with the `corrected` prefix. Use `sre check-eval -s ...` first to preview the diff without writing any file.

On a site with the web front-end, add `--update-web` (as root, on a pool host, on the archives under their original names) so that the Archives page of the portal shows the corrected results too: see *Re-evaluated archives*.

This only works if the corrected project file does not require any **new** command to be run on the virtual machines: re-evaluation replays the grading logic against the test output already stored in the archive, so a command that was never executed during the exam (say, `ip route` on `m1`) cannot be recovered after the fact. Within that limit, fixing a grading bug post-exam is straightforward.

To preview the impact of the correction on a single archive without writing anything, use:

```
sre check-eval --srelab corrected_project.py archive_file
```

which prints the diff between the stored grades and the re-graded ones.

The overall grade is computed by the `Grade0.mark_exo_eval()` method, which can be overridden to rescale or cap the final mark. For example, to multiply every mark by 1.1 and round up to the next 0.1, override `mark_exo_eval()` in the lab's `Grade` class:

```
def mark_exo_eval(self):
    if not self._grade_list or self._total_max == 0:
        return None
    import math
    return min(
        self._maximum_mark,
        math.ceil(10 * 1.1 * self._maximum_mark * self._total_grade / self._total_max) /␣
↪10,
    )
```

2.5.3 Per-student PDF reports + summary spreadsheet

To create per-student PDF reports and a grade spreadsheet:

```
sre outline \
  -o /tmp/summary.ods \
  -d /tmp/reports \
  -r /var/lib/sre/archives/
```

Useful options:

- `--users-file <file>` — auxiliary `LOGIN NAME EMAIL` file (whitespace- or CSV-separated, `#` for comments) that supersedes the names and emails embedded in the archives. Handy when student logins are pseudonyms.
- `--remaining-time` — include each student's remaining exam time (from `exam_time_remaining` in the archive) in the summary.
- `--no-timeline` - omit the evaluation history table from PDF reports
- `--no-parts` - do not group PDF grade rows by GradePart (flat list, no subtotals)
- `--separate-instances` - one PDF report and one ODS row per running project instance instead of one per student. By default a student who opened the same lab several times gets a single report: the best grade is taken across all instances and the evaluation history shows one table per instance, headed by its start time. With this option each instance gets its own report (the PDF name ends with the instance start timestamp) and its own row in the summary, with a `project_start` column.

2.5.4 Export to a spreadsheet

To get a full sheet of all grades elements of all evaluations with per-question summary:

```
sre sheet -o /tmp/exam-results.ods -r /var/lib/sre/archives/
```

Each archive is one row of the lab's sheet, with a `project_start` column identifying the running project instance it comes from; rows are sorted by login, hostname, project start and evaluation date. The `Sessions` sheet keeps the best score per student; add `--separate-instances` to get one line per running project instance instead, for a student who opened the same lab several times.

CHAPTER

THREE

WEB SERVER (REMOTE USE)

The web site lets the students work on the labs from a browser, without the Qt interface and without a remote desktop: the projects run on a **pool of Docker hosts**, every tab of the graphical interface (Schema, Informations, Machines, Networks, Questions, Evaluation, Terminals, Apply Configuration, Log) is rendered in the browser and the terminals go through WebSockets. The users log in with an LDAP directory (the portal binds to it, or an Apache reverse proxy in front authenticates them), or everybody is anonymous.

Nothing of a lab ever reaches the browser but what a student sees today: the content of `info.json` (resolved to the user's language, the instructor texts stripped), the outputs of the `sre --user` commands (the schema, the grades of a self-evaluation, the console of a machine). The lab files, `data.json`, the hidden machines and the archives stay on the pool hosts.

The instructors get, on top of what a student sees (*Instructors* below):

- a **Watch page**, the web counterpart of `sre watch`: every running project of the pool, one row per project with its owner, its lab, the grade and mark of its last evaluation, its age and its errors, the number of self-evaluations the student has run, refreshed every few seconds;
- an **Archives page**: every evaluation of the pool hosts, the closed projects included, kept in a database (the results, never the answers), searched by student, group, lab, host and period, with the detail of an evaluation and the summary matrix of a lab;
- the **projects of the students**, open to them to help: every tab of the project, and the student's terminals joined when the Terminals tab opens, so that the instructor and the student see the same shell and both type in it (a private terminal, unseen by the student, is offered too);
- **presentations**: a project, the instructor's own or a student's, duplicated read-only on the browsers of the whole class or of chosen students and groups to demonstrate something. What the instructor does on their own page (changing tabs, typing in a terminal, selecting a question, changing the drawing of the schema, …) is shown at once on the students' browsers;
- the **focus** on one student: while helping a student on their project, the instructor brings the student's browser to that project and keeps the two pages on the same tab, the same terminal and the same question, whichever of the two changes it;
- the **web conference**: an instructor opens a BigBlueButton room for chosen students or groups (or the whole class) and talks to them, camera and screen if they wish, in a window over the pages of the site while everybody goes on working (*Web conference* below).

3.1 Architecture

```
browser --HTTPS--> sre-web (the portal) --HTTP + token--> sre-agent (one per pool host)␣
↪--> sre --user …
```

- **sre-web**, the portal, is the web site the browsers talk to. It authenticates the users, keeps a signed session cookie, knows the pool of hosts and relays every request about a project to the agent of the host running it. It runs as an unprivileged user, needs neither Docker, Kathara nor the labs, and may run anywhere on the network (the Debian package `sysreseval-web` installs alone).
- **sre-agent** runs on every pool host, as root, next to `sre`. It drives the `sre` CLI in user mode on behalf of the web users exactly as `sre-wrapper` + `sudo` do for the students of a workstation (`sre --user <cmd>` with `SUDO_USER=<login>`), owns the terminals (a pseudo-terminal per `sre connect`), writes the answers file with the user's identity (atomically and under the advisory lock on the `answers/` directory the Qt GUI takes too, the owner of a file the Qt GUI of the same student created kept, so that the GUI goes on writing it; what that GUI writes is pushed to the open pages, which show the same answers), merges the cheat answers of the states, tails the operations log and schedules what the Qt GUI used to schedule: the periodic evaluations of a lab (`eval_interval_without_exam_mode`), the evaluation before a project is closed (`eval_before_exit`), and an idle reaper closing the projects nobody touched for the configured time. For an exam project of the web site (*Exams* below) it applies the rules of the Qt GUI's exam mode to that project alone: the evaluations at the period of the exam, the final one at its end, the owner cut off then.
- **sre-web-tool** is the command line next to the portal: `sre-web-tool …` lists and changes the pool of the running portal through its administration API (*The pool* below).
- The pool hosts share the lab tree as today (NFS, rsync or the Debian package) and, if the instructor wants `sre watch` / `sre sheet` / `sre outline` across the pool, an `archive_dirs` entry on a shared directory. The `hostname` of the archives is the pool host. The Watch page of the instructors needs none of that: each agent reads the archives of its own host (`params.archive_dirs`) on demand.
- Placement: a new project goes to the host where its user has a local login session (the workstation they sit at, `follow_local_sessions`), else to the reachable host with the lowest `projects / max_projects` (then the lowest load); a host in exam mode is never used, a host with `instructors_only = true` never for a student (an instructor may also name the host on the Open page); the whole rule is under *Placement* in *A pool of workstations*. A classroom workstation holds about thirty projects (210 containers in 3.4 GB).
- The lab list of the Open page comes from one host, the one a new project of the user would go to (every host of a pool serves the same lab tree; the next candidate is asked when it fails), and is kept `labs_cache_ttl` seconds (`60`) per role, since the reserved hosts are the instructors' only: opening the page costs one `sre list` per minute whatever the size of the pool.

The agent enforces what the `sre` CLI does not check: the exact running lab name (the CLI resolves substrings) and its owner (a user only reaches their own projects, an instructor every project; the CLI's own check, `params.check_project_owner`, lets a `--user` caller reach their own projects and root's only, which is why an instructor is served by privileged calls; the `wipe`, `stop-all`, `exec` and host-wide exam commands have no endpoint: an exam of the web site is a `POST /v1/projects` with an `exam` object, adjusted with `PUT` / `DELETE …/exam`), `allow_connection` of the devices, `allow_self_grade`, the user-allowed states, the `export_schema_pdf` flag of the lab (the *Export Schema to PDF* button). Save, restore and the Kathara export are not offered on the web. An instructor acting on somebody else's project is served by a **privileged** `sre` (no `--user`, their own login: `sre eval` without cooldown nor counter, `sre connect` to every listed device, `sre state`), never by a command run as the student; the owner, instructor or not, follows the student path.

3.2 Installation

3.2.1 From a checkout

`make venv` installs the Python dependencies (`aiohttp`, `jinja2`, `aiohttp-jinja2`, `ldap3`, and `pymysql` for the optional database of the connection log); `make xterm` and `make novnc` (run by `make install`) download

the terminal library and the VNC viewer of the browser into `web/static/vendor/` (checksum-pinned, not committed). `scripts/install.sh` offers to install the systemd units `sre-agent.service` and `sre-web.service` (disabled) and the example configuration files `agent.toml` and `web.toml` in `/etc/sreweb/` (`params.agent_config_file` / `params.web_config_file`; `--config` names another file).

On every pool host: write `/etc/sreweb/agent.toml` (root, mode 0600) with a long random token (the example file listens on every interface, `0.0.0.0:8451`: `allowed_clients` and the mutual TLS below keep the port to the portal), then `systemctl enable --now sre-agent`. The unit starts the agent only when that file exists and `/etc/sreweb/DO_NOT_START_AGENT` does not (`ConditionPathExists=`: one image for a whole classroom may ship the unit enabled, the hosts without a configuration file, or with the marker, skip it without any failure; checked at boot and on `systemctl start` / `restart`), and it does not restart the agent after a configuration error (exit status 78, `EX_CONFIG`: a bad `agent.toml`, a missing certificate; the message is in the journal, fix the file then `systemctl restart sre-agent`); five failed starts within five minutes leave it stopped until the next boot or `systemctl reset-failed`. For the Display tab (below), install `tigervnc-standalone-server` and `openbox`, create the `sreweb-x11` system user (`scripts/install.sh` offers it) and set `[display] enabled = true`. For a whole classroom, `scripts/make-web-hosts.sh` (see *A whole site at once* below) writes the tokens, the certificates and the `[[hosts]]` entries from a list of machines.

On the portal host: create the `sre-web` system user (`adduser --system --group --no-create-home --shell /usr/sbin/nologin sre-web`), write `/etc/sreweb/web.toml` (root:sre-web, mode 0640: it holds the cookie secret and the agent tokens; the files it imports likewise), then `systemctl enable --now sre-web`. Put a reverse proxy doing TLS in front (`scripts/etc/sre-web-nginx.conf` is an nginx example, `sre-web-apache.conf` an Apache one that also authenticates the users: the proxy mode below), or give the portal its own certificate (`tls_cert` / `tls_key`).

3.2.2 Debian packages

`sysreseval-agent` on every pool host (it depends on `sysreseval` and `sysreseval-web`, whose code it shares), `sysreseval-web` on the portal host (it depends on nothing of SysResEval). The units are `sysreseval-agent.service` and `sysreseval-web.service`, disabled by default (the agent's with the conditions and restart rules above, on `/etc/sysreseval/agent.toml` and `/etc/sysreseval/DO_NOT_START_AGENT`); the configuration files are `/etc/sysreseval/agent.toml` and `/etc/sysreseval/web.toml` (examples in `/usr/share/doc/sysreseval-*/examples/`); the postinst of `sysreseval-web` creates the `sre-web` user and protects `web.toml` and `web.d/*.toml` when they exist.

The postinst of `sysreseval-agent` creates the `sreweb-x11` user of the virtual X desktops; `tigervnc-standalone-server` and `openbox` are its Recommends (the Display tab is off until `[display] enabled = true`).

3.3 Configuration

3.3.1 agent.toml

Key	Default	Meaning
listen	127.0.0.1:8451	the address the portal reaches: 0.0.0.0:8451 in the example file (every interface, the Docker bridge the students' containers reach included: set allowed_clients and tls_ca), or a management interface the students do not reach
token	required	the shared secret of this host, repeated in the portal's [[hosts]] entry (32+ characters)
sre_exe	the installation's sre	the command run for the users
poll_in	1	seconds between two scans of the projects directory (the Qt GUI polls every second too)
max_idl	24h	default idle timeout of a project (the portal gives its own per user); 0 = never
termina termina	16, 4	caps on the open terminals (every Connect opens a new terminal on the machine); at a cap, the idle terminal that has waited longest gives way
termina	120m	how long a terminal whose last browser left (the page closed or reloaded, another project opened, the network cut) is kept for the browser to come back to it; 0 = it ends at once; the × of a terminal ends it at once in any case
max_con max_con	2, 2	concurrent sre start / sre eval on the host
lab_lis	60	seconds the output of sre list is cached
state_d	/var/lib/sre/web-agent	the idle clocks of the projects, kept across restarts
tls_cer tls_key	none	the certificate and key of this agent (TLS to the portal)
tls_ca	none	the CA a **client certificate** must be signed by: only the portal gets past the handshake (mutual TLS)
allowed	[] (any)	the addresses or networks the agent answers, e.g. ["10.0.0.1", "10.0.1.0/24"]
occupie	both	when the host reports itself *occupied* (no new project, never powered off): sessions (a local login session: loginctl, or who), projects (projects of the Qt GUI on the host), both, never
close_p	shutdown	what the agent does with the projects it manages when its unit stops: shutdown closes them (last evaluation, sre stop) only when the system is going down, always, never; within shutdown_timeout (240 s, the unit's TimeoutStopSec is 300)
allow_p	false	the portal may power the host off (POST /v1/power/off, refused when occupied or with any project) with power_off_command (systemctl poweroff)
restart	none	how the agent restarts itself on sre-web-tool restart (POST /v1/restart): by default systemctl restart of its own unit, read from /proc/self/cgroup; a command for an agent run otherwise (refused, 409, when neither applies)
[timeou	start = 900, eval = 600, state = 600, stop = 300, list = 30, report = 600	seconds, per sre command (report: the spreadsheet / PDF reports of the Archives page, built by sre report on this host; export, the timeout of the former Kathara export, is still accepted)
[displa	enabled = false	one virtual X desktop per project whose lab has an x11_host machine, shown in the Display tab (see *The Display tab* below): user (sreweb-x11, the unprivileged account the X processes run as), xvnc_command (Xvnc, TigerVNC), window_manager_command (openbox, "" = none), geometry (1280x800), depth (24), frame_rate (30), first_display / last_display (10 / 99: display :N listens on TCP port 6000+N for the containers), runtime_dir (/run/sre-agent;

Durations are written as `90`, `"90s"`, `"30m"`, `"2h"` or `"1d"`. An unknown key is refused. `import` (a path or a list of paths relative to `agent.toml`: a directory, a glob or a file) merges other files into this one, as for `web.toml` below.

3.3.2 web.toml

Key	Default	Meaning
list	127.0.0.1:84	behind a reverse proxy: the loopback
publ	none	the URL the users type (the Origin of the WebSockets is checked against it)
secr	required	signs the session cookies (32+ random characters)
trus	[]	proxy mode: the addresses or networks of the reverse proxy, the only peers whose identity headers are trusted (the TCP peer address, never X-Forwarded-For); required in that mode. In every mode, the connection log takes the client address from the X-Forwarded-For header of these peers
lang	["en" "fr"	the languages offered at login, the first one by default
tls_ tls_	none	own TLS instead of a proxy
[aut mode	anon	anonymous: a pseudonym guest-xxxxxxxx per browser (the user may type a display name); ldap: the directory account; proxy: the identity the reverse proxy passes in headers (below)
[aut admi	[]	the logins of the administrators: instructors who may read the connection log on the History page (*Administrators* below); a login that is not an instructor gets nothing. By group: administrator_groups / administrator_group_filter of [auth.ldap], administrator_groups of [auth.proxy]
[aut ldap		uri, then either bind_dn_template = "uid={login},ou=people,…" (bind as the user) or search_base + search_filter (+ bind_dn / bind_password of a service account) to find the user first; attr_fullname (cn), attr_mail (mail), attr_group (none; the attribute holding the student group, e.g. departmentNumber, its first value: the Group column and filter of the Watch page); the instructor tests (below): instructor_groups (DNs; memberOf, or group_filter = "(member={dn})"), instructor_filter ("(gidNumber=2000)", "" = none), group_search_base (none = no membership test) + instructor_group_filter ("(&(objectClass=posixGroup)(gidNumber=2000)(memberUid={login}))"); the administrator tests (*Administrators* below): administrator_groups (DNs, tested like instructor_groups) and administrator_group_filter (a group search under group_search_base, none by default); the connection: ldaps:// or ldap:// + start_tls, the server certificate always verified against the system CA store or tls_ca (the absolute path of a PEM file: a CA bundle, or the self-signed certificate of the server itself) and the host of the uri against the names of the certificate (subjectAltName, else the CN: name the server as its certificate does, not by address); a plain ldap:// without start_tls is refused at startup unless allow_cleartext = true (the passwords in LDAP mode, the roles, groups and administrators in every mode would travel unprotected); timeout. The login attribute: attr_login (none = the attribute of a search_filter of the form (attribute={login}), else the RDN attribute of bind_dn_template); in LDAP mode the identity carries its stored value, whatever case the user typed (the directory matches Bob for bob: one user, not two), and the Groups page (*User groups* below) lists the people by it, in every mode, with groups_filter ("(objectClass=posixGroup)": the groups listed under group_search_base; "" = none), attr_group_name (cn), attr_group_members (memberUid; a value may be the login, the uid or the DN of a person). Also read in proxy mode with ldap_roles / ldap_groups
[aut prox		header_login (X-Remote-User), header_fullname (X-Remote-Name), header_email (X-Remote-Email), header_groups (X-Remote-Groups): the headers set by the proxy; groups_separator (;); header_group (none; the header holding the student group, e.g. X-Remote-Group from departmentNumber, its first value); instructor_groups: the values of the groups header giving the instructor role; instructor_header / instructor_values (e.g. X-Remote-Gid and ["2000"]): a second header test; administrator_groups: the values of the groups header making an instructor an administrator; ldap_roles (false): the portal runs the tests of [auth.ldap] itself for the login the proxy gives, and reads its

`import = ["web.d"]` splits the configuration into `/etc/sysreseval/web.toml` and the `*.toml` files of `/etc/sysreseval/web.d/`, read by name after it: a file per pool host, the secrets apart. Nothing is silently overridden: a key given twice is an error naming both files, and an error found after the merge names `web.toml`. The imported files hold the same secrets as `web.toml` and need the same owner and mode (root:sre-web, 0640).

The full name and the e-mail of an LDAP account (`attr_fullname`, `attr_mail`) go into the answers file of the projects like the GECOS fields do on a workstation, so `sre outline` and `sre sheet` show them; an anonymous user is identified by the pseudonym and the display name. The student group (`attr_group` in LDAP mode, `header_group` or `ldap_roles` / `ldap_groups` + `attr_group` in proxy mode; `departmentNumber` typically, its first value, capped at 64 characters) goes there too under the key `group` (hence into the archives): the Watch page shows it and filters on it. With a directory the portal can read (`attr_group` in LDAP mode, `ldap_roles` or `ldap_groups` in proxy mode), the Watch page also looks up the group of the owners the agents know none for, first of all the projects started on the Qt GUI, whose answers file never carries one, and shows for the projects of the Qt GUI the full name of the directory (`attr_fullname`) rather than the GECOS name of the account their answers file carries (lower case on some sites): one cached lookup per login. The agent writes that metadata as soon as a project is created, before any answer, and again when the owner opens the project page and the file lacks it or holds other values (so a project created by an older agent, or on the Qt GUI, gets its name and group then); a request whose identity carries no full name or no group (a header the proxy did not set) never erases the stored values.

3.3.3 Authentication by the reverse proxy

With `[auth] mode = "proxy"` the portal has no login page: the reverse proxy in front authenticates the users itself and names them in request headers, which the portal reads on every request (pages, API calls, the NDJSON streams of the starts, the WebSockets of the terminals). Nothing is stored in a cookie: the proxy's session is the session, and a request that does not come from a peer of `trusted_proxies` has no identity whatever its headers. `scripts/etc/sre-web-apache.conf` is the Apache 2.4 example (`mod_authnz_ldap` + `mod_proxy`):

```
<Location "/">
    AuthType Basic
    AuthName "SRE"
    AuthBasicProvider ldap
    AuthLDAPURL
↪"ldaps://ldap.example.org/ou=people,dc=example,dc=org?uid,cn,mail,memberOf,gidNumber,departmentNumber
    AuthLDAPRemoteUserAttribute uid
    Require valid-user
    RequestHeader set X-Remote-User "expr=%{REMOTE_USER}"
    RequestHeader unset X-Remote-Name
    RequestHeader set X-Remote-Name "%{AUTHENTICATE_CN}e" env=AUTHENTICATE_CN
    RequestHeader unset X-Remote-Email
    RequestHeader set X-Remote-Email "%{AUTHENTICATE_MAIL}e" env=AUTHENTICATE_MAIL
    RequestHeader unset X-Remote-Groups
    RequestHeader set X-Remote-Groups "%{AUTHENTICATE_MEMBEROF}e"␣
↪env=AUTHENTICATE_MEMBEROF
    RequestHeader unset X-Remote-Gid
    RequestHeader set X-Remote-Gid "%{AUTHENTICATE_GIDNUMBER}e"␣
↪env=AUTHENTICATE_GIDNUMBER
    RequestHeader unset X-Remote-Group
    RequestHeader set X-Remote-Group "%{AUTHENTICATE_DEPARTMENTNUMBER}e"␣
↪env=AUTHENTICATE_DEPARTMENTNUMBER
    RequestHeader unset Authorization
</Location>
```

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```
# Logout: a location that knows no user, so the browser forgets the credentials it cached
ProxyPass "/apache-logout" !
<Location "/apache-logout">
    AuthBasicProvider file
    AuthUserFile /dev/null
    Require valid-user
    ErrorDocument 401 "<!DOCTYPE html>... You are logged out. <a href='/'>Log in␣
↪again</a> ..."
</Location>
ProxyPreserveHost On
ProxyPass        "/" "http://127.0.0.1:8450/" upgrade=websocket timeout=3600
ProxyPassReverse "/" "http://127.0.0.1:8450/"
```

`AuthLDAPRemoteUserAttribute` is not optional: it makes `REMOTE_USER`, hence the login header, the value the directory stores in the login attribute. Without it Apache passes what the user typed, and since the directory matches `Bob` for `bob` (`uid` is caseIgnoreMatch) one account would become two users of the portal (separate projects, out of the exam audiences and custom groups naming `bob`, split Watch and Archives rows). The attribute must be the one the agents and the exam audiences know the users by (`uid` for the Unix login of the workstations, see *A pool of workstations*). In LDAP mode the portal does this itself: the identity carries the stored value of the login attribute (`attr_login`, else the attribute of the `search_filter` or of the `bind_dn_template`), whatever case the user typed.

The rules that keep this safe:

- The portal listens on the loopback (or on an address only the proxy reaches) and `trusted_proxies` holds the proxy's address as the portal sees it (`127.0.0.1` and `::1` for a proxy on the same host); the portal takes the TCP peer address, never `X-Forwarded-For` (the connection log alone reads that header, from these peers only, for the client address).
- The proxy sets the four headers on **every** request, replacing whatever the browser sent (`RequestHeader set` does; never pass a client header through), after the authentication (not `early`). An optional header is removed when the attribute is missing, or `mod_headers` writes the literal `(null)`, which the portal treats as empty.
- The attributes exported by `mod_authnz_ldap` (`AUTHENTICATE_CN…`) are those listed in the `AuthLDAPURL`; a multi-valued one is joined with `;` (hence `groups_separator = ";"`). The groups header may carry any attribute, `memberOf` DNs or `eduPersonAffiliation` values: `instructor_groups` lists the values giving the instructor role; `instructor_header` / `instructor_values` test a second attribute the same way (`gidNumber` above, the primary group); `header_group` names the header carrying the student group (`departmentNumber` above). A group membership the proxy cannot export (a `posixGroup` listing its `memberUid`, without the memberof overlay) is tested by the portal itself with `ldap_roles = true` and the `[auth.ldap]` settings (see *Who is an instructor*). A long list of groups can exceed Apache's `LimitRequestFieldSize` (8190 bytes): raise it or export fewer attributes.
- `public_url` must be the `https://` URL the users type (the `Secure` flag of the language cookie, the `Origin` check of the WebSockets together with `ProxyPreserveHost On`).
- An HTTP Basic authentication has no session to end, but the browser forgets the credentials it cached as soon as the server refuses them: the `/apache-logout` location of the example knows no user (`mod_authn_file` on `/dev/null`, the realm inherited from the main location), so every request gets a 401 and the browser shows its password dialog once more; cancelling it displays the "logged out" page of the `ErrorDocument` (a password typed there is refused and the dialog comes back). `logout_url = "/apache-logout"` makes the Logout button appear; the button is hidden without it. A `mod_auth_form` login (sketched at the end of the example) has a real logout handler at the same URL.
- `sre-web-tool …` talks to the loopback port directly, never through the proxy (the Basic authentication

would refuse its bearer token).

3.3.4 The connection log

`[access_log]` of `web.toml` makes the portal keep a log of its use: who connected from where and for how long, which projects were opened, started, evaluated, closed. One `key=value` line per event (a value with spaces or quotes is JSON-quoted, so a user agent or a display name cannot forge a line), in the file named by `file` (rotated at midnight, `keep` days of `access.log.YYYY-MM-DD` files kept; `keep = 0` leaves the rotation to logrotate, the file is reopened when it moves) and, with `journal = true` (the default, and the whole log when no file is set), in the portal's own log on stderr: the journal under systemd, `docker logs` in a container. The unit creates `/var/log/sre-web` (`LogsDirectory=`); a container mounts a directory for the file or writes it under `/var/lib/sre-web`. The lines of the file start with a timestamp (`2026-10-26T09:12:03+0100`):

```
event=login login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 mode=ldap role=student anon=0 name="Alice Test"␣
↪group=INFO1
event=session_open login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 role=student anon=0 name="Alice Test"␣
↪group=INFO1 ua="Mozilla/5.0 …"
event=start login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 lab=sre/dhcp.py instructor=0 debug=0 host=a01␣
↪placement=load result=created rln=1761466323@@@dhcp@@@alice status=200 duration=12.4
event=project_open login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 host=a01 rln=1761466323@@@dhcp@@@alice
event=terminal_open login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 host=a01 rln=1761466323@@@dhcp@@@alice␣
↪device=m1 join=- private=0
event=terminal_close login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 host=a01 rln=1761466323@@@dhcp@@@alice␣
↪device=m1 join=- private=0 duration=612.3 code=1000
event=eval login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 host=a01 rln=1761466323@@@dhcp@@@alice status=200␣
↪duration=8.1
event=project_close login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 host=a01 rln=1761466323@@@dhcp@@@alice␣
↪duration=1803.6 code=1001
event=stop login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 host=a01 rln=1761466323@@@dhcp@@@alice status=200␣
↪duration=3.0
event=logout login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 status=200 duration=0.0
event=session_close login=alice addr=10.0.1.7 role=student name="Alice Test" group=INFO1␣
↪reason=logout since=2026-10-26T09:11:50+0100 duration=1850 requests=14␣
↪projects=1761466323@@@dhcp@@@alice
```

A **session** is the requests of one login from one client address (`addr`): it opens at the first request (`session_open`: role, pseudonym or not, name, student group, user agent) and closes (`session_close`) at a logout, after `session_timeout` without a request (`reason=idle`; the duration then ends at the last request, not at the expiry) or when the portal stops (`shutdown`); a session whose project page, terminal or desktop is still open never expires. The closing line repeats the role, the name and the group (the student group of the directory or of the proxy, `attr_group` / `header_group`, `-` without one; the last non-empty value seen during the session, since a directory lookup may fail on the first request) and gives the start, the duration in seconds, the number of requests (the polls of the pages and the keep-alive of a project are not counted) and the projects used: the *Sessions* view of the History page (*Administrators* below) is built from that line alone. In proxy mode there is no login: the first request of a user opens the session and the request following a logout opens another one. The other events:

- `login` (`mode`: `anonymous` or `ldap`) and `login_failed` (`reason`: `password`, `rate_limited`, `directory` when the directory does not answer, `proxy_mode`);
- `start`: the lab, the host chosen and `placement`, why that host (`load`: the least loaded, `session`: the user is logged in at its keyboard, `named`: the instructor named it), whether the instructor mode or the debug mode was asked (`instructor`, `debug`), `result` (`created`, `flavor_form`, `flavor_error`, `error`) and `rln`, the running lab name of the new project;
- `project_open` / `project_close`: the project page, open as long as its events WebSocket is (`duration`

in seconds, `code`: the WebSocket close code; `view=instructor` for the instructor view); `terminal_open` / `terminal_close` (`device`, `join`: the session joined, `private`) and `display_open` / `display_close` likewise; a socket refused before it opens (401, 403, 404) gives a close line with `status` instead of `code`;

- `eval`, `state` (`state`), `stop`, `display_start`: the HTTP status and the duration;
- `denied`: a call answered 401, 403 or 429 (`method`, `path`), `login=-` when nobody was logged in; `admin`: a call of `sre-web-tool` changing the pool, or an action of the Pool page of an instructor (their `login`); `history`: an administrator read the log on the History page (*Administrators* below; the filters asked come as `login_filter`, `addr_filter`, `event_filter`, `host_filter`, `rln_filter`, `lab_filter`, `group_filter` (the key of the group, `kind:name`), `since_filter`, `until_filter`, `before_filter`; `view=sessions` for the Sessions view, `view=statistics` for the Statistics view with the period resolved in `since_filter` / `until_filter`);
- the presentations (*Instructors* below): `present_start` (the instructor's `login`, `host`, `rln`, `audience`: the number of logins and groups chosen), `present_audience` (the audience changed), `present_stop`, and `present_open` (a student opened the presented page: their `login`, the `presenter`); the project calls a spectator makes keep their own events, their close lines carrying `spectator=1`. The presence socket every page keeps open, the view the presenter publishes and the pointer frames of their presentation socket are not logged;
- the focus on a student (*Instructors* below): `focus_start` (the instructor's `login`, `host`, `rln`, the `student`) and `focus_stop` (the `instructor` of the focus, the `student`); the view the two pages share and their sockets are not logged;
- the web conferences (*Web conference* below): `webconf_start` (the instructor's `login`, `webconf` = the id of the room, its `name`, `audience` = the number of logins and groups), `webconf_audience` (the audience changed, the `owner` of the room), `webconf_attend` (an instructor joining a room), `webconf_stop`, and `webconf_join` (a join URL served to a participant: their `login`, `webconf`, `role`, status 302); the listing of the rooms is a keepalive, the page the client comes back to after *Leave meeting* is not logged;
- the private conversations (*Private conversations* below): `webconf_invite` (the instructor's `login`, the `student` asked, the `host` and `rln` of the project they asked from, the `invitation`; status 409 when the student is not connected or busy), `webconf_accept` (the student's `login`, the `invitation`, the `instructor`, `webconf` = the room made; 410 when the invitation was over, 502 / 503 as the server answered), `webconf_decline`, `webconf_cancel` (the invitation taken back by an instructor, the `student`) and `webconf_leave` (one of the two ending the conversation: `webconf`, `owner`); an invitation nobody answers expires without a line.

The client address is the last entry of `X-Forwarded-For` when the TCP peer is one of `trusted_proxies` (the Apache and nginx examples set that header), the peer address otherwise: set `trusted_proxies` in every mode to log the real addresses behind a proxy. The login rate limit (`[limits] login_per_minute`) counts per logged address too. The log holds personal data (names, addresses, what was done when): `keep` is its retention, and the file is readable by `sre-web` and root only (`/var/log/sre-web` is mode 0750).

In a database. `[access_log.database]` sends the same events to a MariaDB / MySQL table through PyMySQL (`python3-pymysql`, suggested by the Debian package rather than installed with it since the feature is off by default, or `pip install pymysql` in the venv; the file and the journal stay what they are), where the History page of the administrators (*Administrators* below) reads them:

```
[access_log.database]
host = "db.example.org"          # or unix_socket = "/run/mysqld/mysqld.sock"
user = "sre_web"
name = "sre"                     # the database; password = "…" in an imported secrets␣
↪file
keep = 400                       # days of rows kept (purged daily); 0 = forever
```

One row per line: the time (`ts`, UTC, millisecond precision), the event, the login (empty when nobody was

logged in), the client address, the host, the project (`rln`), the lab, the status and the duration in columns, the other fields of the line as JSON in `details` (`SELECT login, COUNT(*) FROM access_log WHERE event = 'start' GROUP BY login` works as expected). The table (`table`, `access_log` by default) is created when it is missing, so the account needs `CREATE` for the first start; or create it by hand and grant `SELECT, INSERT, DELETE` only (`DELETE` for the purge of `keep`):

```
CREATE DATABASE sre CHARACTER SET utf8mb4;
CREATE USER 'sre_web'@'%' IDENTIFIED BY '…';
GRANT SELECT, INSERT, DELETE ON sre.* TO 'sre_web'@'%';
CREATE TABLE sre.access_log (
  id       BIGINT UNSIGNED NOT NULL AUTO_INCREMENT,
  ts       DATETIME(3)     NOT NULL,
  event    VARCHAR(32)     NOT NULL,
  login    VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  addr     VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  host     VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  rln      VARCHAR(255)    NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  lab      VARCHAR(255)    NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  status   VARCHAR(16)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  duration DOUBLE          NULL,
  details  TEXT            NOT NULL,
  PRIMARY KEY (id), KEY ts (ts), KEY login_ts (login, ts), KEY addr_ts (addr, ts), KEY␣
↪event_ts (event, ts)
) ENGINE=InnoDB DEFAULT CHARSET=utf8mb4 COLLATE=utf8mb4_unicode_ci;
```

The rows are written by a thread of the portal, in batches, and a request never waits for the server: while it does not answer, the rows wait in memory (`queue` of them at most, the oldest dropped beyond; one warning in the portal's log, one line when the writing resumes; the History page says it too) and the portal goes on; a batch the server refuses is written row by row and a refused row is dropped with a warning; the rows still waiting when the portal stops get one last attempt. The rows older than `keep` days are deleted once a day (`DELETE … LIMIT`: a replicated server needs a row-based binlog). Every consultation of the History page is a `history` line, in the file and in the table alike. The table holds the same personal data as the file: `keep` is its retention, and the account of the portal should be the only one reading it. In the production container the driver must be in the image (or the venv) and the server reachable from it (a local MariaDB over the host network, or its socket bind-mounted).

Retention. The portal keeps `keep` days of each store while it runs: the rotated files beyond `keep` go at the next rotation, the rows older than `keep` days once a day. `scripts/web-purge-log.py` applies a retention of its own, for a cron job or a timer of the host (run with the Python of the portal, PyMySQL included; it reads `web.toml`): `--days` (365 by default), `--dry-run`, `--optimize` (the table rebuilt after the deletion, so that the deleted rows no longer occupy its file; a short lock), `--files-only` / `--database-only`, `--archives-days N` (the archives of the evaluations too, below; left alone otherwise); the current file is never touched, a rotated file goes by its modification time. For instance in `/etc/cron.d/sre-web`:

```
15 4 * * * root /opt/sre/venv/bin/python3 /opt/sre/scripts/web-purge-log.py --days 365
```

3.3.5 The archives of the evaluations

Every `sre eval` writes an archive on the host that ran it (`params.archive_dirs`, `/var/lib/sre/archives`: the student's self-evaluations, the periodic evaluations of the web agent, an instructor's, the final one of a project closed with `eval_before_exit`, those of the Qt GUI), and the Watch page reads the newest archive of each *running* project. With `[access_log.database]` configured, the portal also collects **every archive of every pool host into a second table of that database** (`[archives]` of `web.toml`: `table`, `archives` by default; `keep`, `0` = the rows are kept forever; `poll_interval`, `30s`), and the **Archives** page of the instructors

(*Instructors* below) reads it: the results of a project survive its closing, the history of its evaluations is kept, and the results of a student or of a class group can be searched across the labs and the hosts.

The portal pulls, as it does for everything else: every `poll_interval` the collector asks each reachable agent for the archives of its host it has not taken yet (`GET /v1/archives?after=<file name>&limit=50`, the token alone: the archives whose name is greater than the last one taken, in the order of the names, which start with the evaluation time; up to ten calls per host and round, so that a host with a backlog of thousands of archives, the first run on a site that already evaluated for months, is imported at about a thousand archives per minute), and queues one row per archive. The agent decodes the archives and sends what the page needs: the project, the lab, the evaluation time, the student's login, full name, group, e-mail, the host that evaluated, the exam flag and fields, the exo-eval and self-eval totals and marks, the errors and warnings, and every element of the grade list with its title and description as the lab wrote them (in every language of the lab: the browser shows the viewer's), its grade, maximum, letter, part and bonus flag. **The answers of the students are not sent and not stored.** The group and the full name an archive lacks (the projects of the Qt GUI) are completed from the directory when the portal reads one (`attr_group`, `ldap_roles` / `ldap_groups`), as on the Watch page.

The **reports** an instructor downloads from the page (the spreadsheet of `sre sheet`, the PDF reports of `sre outline` or their summary spreadsheet alone: *Instructors* below) are built from these rows, not from the archive files of the hosts, which may be asleep or reinstalled: a row holds everything the two commands read from an archive (the student, the time, the totals, the grade elements with their titles and parts, the number of errors; never the tests nor the answers). The portal turns the rows back into the records the agents had sent and hands them to **one** agent of the pool, chosen as the lab list is (an enabled, reachable host, up and little loaded first; the next one when it does not answer), which runs `sre report` (an internal command: the records on stdin, the file on stdout, one report at a time per host, `[timeouts] report` of `agent.toml`, `600` seconds) and answers the download the portal streams to the browser. The files are therefore those `sre sheet` / `sre outline` would give on the same archives, in the language of the instructor, but for one thing: a student is a login whatever the host of the pool the project ran on, where the two commands tell a login on two hosts apart (*Reports*, under *Instructors* below); the elements of an evaluation whose details were too big for the table (over 1 MB) are missing from them. The PDF reports and their summary read the grade elements of one evaluation per student only, the best one (the highest total, the earliest of them): when every evaluation of the selected projects is asked, the portal sends the others as *light* records (the student, the time, the totals, the error counts: about 300 bytes instead of several kilobytes), read without their details from the database, so that such a request may cover 150 000 evaluations (hundreds of projects evaluated every minute for hours) where the spreadsheet of `sre sheet`, which shows the elements of every evaluation, stops at 5000. Every download is a `report` line of the connection log (the kind, the rows ticked, the options, the evaluations and projects sent, `full` = the evaluations sent with their details, the host that built the file).

One cursor per host, the greatest archive name taken, lives in the portal's memory and is read from the table itself at the first round after a start (`SELECT host, MAX(archive) … GROUP BY host`): nothing is collected while the database does not answer, and a restart never imports a host again. The name of an archive is unique in the table (`UNIQUE (archive)`, `INSERT IGNORE`), so a host whose archive directory is shared with another one, or rows still queued when the portal stopped, only cost a harmless re-insert. An archive rewritten in place (`sre re-eval -p '' -d <archive dir>`) or named below the cursor (a host whose clock was set back) is not taken again, as `sre watch` would not see it either: the results of a re-evaluation reach the table through `sre re-eval --update-web` (*Re-evaluated archives* below). An agent not yet updated answers 404 and is skipped with one warning until it is.

The table is created like `access_log` when it is missing (the `CREATE` privilege, once); or create it by hand and grant `SELECT, INSERT, DELETE` on it (the same grant as the log's: the account needs no `UPDATE`):

```
CREATE TABLE sre.archives (
  id              BIGINT UNSIGNED NOT NULL AUTO_INCREMENT,
  ts              DATETIME(3)     NOT NULL,           -- the evaluation time, UTC
```

(continues on next page)

(continued from previous page)

```
  host            VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '', -- the pool host (the name of␣
↪[[hosts]])
  archive         VARCHAR(300)    NOT NULL,            -- the file name: unique
  rln             VARCHAR(255)    NOT NULL DEFAULT '', -- the running lab name
  lab             VARCHAR(255)    NOT NULL DEFAULT '', -- sre/dhcp.py: the path the␣
↪student started
  canonical_lab   VARCHAR(255)    NOT NULL DEFAULT '', -- the file really run, symlinks␣
↪resolved (sre/dhcp.py for s3/r306/dhcp.py -> ../../sre/dhcp.py)
  login           VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  fullname        VARCHAR(255)    NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  grp             VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '', -- the student group
  hostname        VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '', -- the host the archive names
  grade           DOUBLE          NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,  -- exo-eval scope
  max_grade       DOUBLE          NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,
  mark            DOUBLE          NULL,
  maximum_mark    DOUBLE          NULL,
  errors          INT             NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,
  warnings        INT             NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,
  exam            TINYINT         NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,
  auto_eval_count INT             NULL,                -- the self-evaluations of the␣
↪student so far
  details         MEDIUMTEXT      NOT NULL,            -- JSON: elements, parts, errors,␣
↪self-eval totals, metadata
  PRIMARY KEY (id), UNIQUE KEY archive (archive), KEY ts (ts), KEY login_lab_id (login,␣
↪lab, id),
  KEY login_canonical_id (login, canonical_lab, id), KEY rln_id (rln, id), KEY lab_ts␣
↪(lab, ts),
  KEY canonical_lab_ts (canonical_lab, ts), KEY grp_ts (grp, ts), KEY host_archive (host,
↪ archive)
) ENGINE=InnoDB DEFAULT CHARSET=utf8mb4 COLLATE=utf8mb4_unicode_ci;
```

Upgrading a table created before `canonical_lab` (releases up to 0.15.0): the portal probes the columns when it connects and, while one is missing, keeps the rows in memory and warns once (`archives database: the table archives lacks a column the rows need …`) instead of refusing them; add the column and its keys from the root console before the portal restarts with the new code, then give the old rows their own path as the file run, and run that `UPDATE` once more after the restart: the rows the old code inserted meanwhile have an empty value (the account of the portal has neither `ALTER` nor `UPDATE`):

```
ALTER TABLE sre.archives ADD COLUMN canonical_lab VARCHAR(255) NOT NULL DEFAULT '' AFTER␣
↪lab,
  ADD KEY login_canonical_id (login, canonical_lab, id), ADD KEY canonical_lab_ts␣
↪(canonical_lab, ts);
UPDATE sre.archives SET canonical_lab = lab WHERE canonical_lab = '';
-- to merge the old rows of a symbolic link with their lab, by hand:
-- UPDATE sre.archives SET canonical_lab = 'sre/dns1.py' WHERE lab = 's3/r306/dns1.py';
```

The new rows carry the file really run as soon as the agents run the new code (an older agent sends none and the row gets its path). The rows go through the same kind of writer as the log's (batches, the rows waiting in memory while the server does not answer, a refused row dropped with a warning, a last attempt at shutdown) and are purged daily beyond `keep` days when set; `web-purge-log.py --archives-days N` applies a retention from a cron job. Expect about thirty rows per project and hour of auto-evaluation (`eval_interval_without_exam_mode`), a few kilobytes each. The table holds personal data (names, groups, results): the account of the portal should be the only one reading it, and the page is open to the instructors

only. Every consultation of the Archives page is an `archives` line of the connection log, with the filters asked.

3.3.6 Re-evaluated archives

A grading bug found after the evaluations is fixed in the lab file and the archives are graded again with *sre re-eval*, which replays the lab on the test results each archive holds. The table of the portal was filled when the evaluations ran and does not follow by itself; **`sre re-eval --update-web`** makes it follow:

```
# as root, on the pool host whose /var/lib/sre/archives holds the archives
sudo sre re-eval -s /opt/sre/lab/s3/r306/dns1.py -p corrected -d /root/regraded \
                 --update-web /var/lib/sre/archives/*@@@s3@r306@dns1.py@@@*
```

The command writes the re-graded archives as usual (`-p`, `-d`) and, for each of them, queues the new results on the host: one file per archive in `/var/lib/sre/web-updates/` (mode `0700`, the files `0600`, owned by `sre`: they name students and grades), holding what the agent sends for an archive — never the answers — under **the name of the original archive**, which is how the portal knows the evaluation. A later re-evaluation of the same archive replaces the one still waiting. Nothing else is to be configured: no address of the portal, no token, no privilege of the database account.

The portal takes them as it takes the archives. The answer of `GET /v1/archives` says how many re-evaluations wait on the host (`updates`); when there are some, the collector reads them in pages (`GET /v1/archives/updates?after=&limit=`, the token alone), writes each row again in one transaction per page, and tells the agent which ones are settled (`POST /v1/archives/updates`), which removes them from the host. A row is written with `REPLACE` under its own `id` — the `INSERT` and `DELETE` privileges the account already has; no `UPDATE` — so it keeps its place on the Archives page and the links to it. Of the stored row it also keeps what only the first collection knew:

Kept from the stored row	Taken from the re-evaluation
`id`, `ts` (the time of the evaluation), `host`	`grade`, `max_grade`, `mark`, `maximum_mark`
`canonical_lab` (the lab file as it resolved then)	`errors`, `warnings` and the error list
`fullname`, `grp` (the directory's, at the time)	the elements and the parts of the grade list
the `managed` detail	the self-eval totals, `re_eval_date`

The reports downloaded from the page are built from the rows, so they show the new results at once. The Watch page reads the archive files of the running projects, not the table.

- **Only the evaluations the table holds are updated; none is added.** A re-evaluation whose evaluation is not there yet (collected at the next round, or the database did not answer) stays on the host and is tried again at every round; the agent gives it up, with a line of its log, after a day. Give the archives under their original names: the output of an earlier `re-eval` and a renamed archive are not queued.
- **Run it where an agent runs.** The queue is read by the agent of the same host. With an archive directory shared by the pool (`archive_dirs`), one run on any pool host updates the evaluations of every host: a row is found by the name of its archive, whichever host it came from. On a host without `agent.toml` the command warns that nothing will hand the updates over.
- **Applied at least once.** The portal acknowledges after its transaction is committed; a round interrupted in between writes the same row again at the next one, which changes nothing. A database or an agent failing here is warned about once in the portal's log (`archives: <host> (re-evaluations): …`) and never stops the collection of the archives.
- The portal logs `archives: <host>: N evaluation(s) replaced by their re-evaluation`; the Archives page's database status counts them (`collector.updated`). A re-evaluation of an archive whose row belongs to another project is dropped with a warning.

- An agent older than this feature never announces the queue and a portal older than it, or one without `[access_log.database]`, never asks for it: the files wait on the host. Whatever waited for more than a day is dropped when the queue is next read by the agent or written by `sre re-eval --update-web`, which then warns that the portal never took them.

3.3.7 User groups

The **Groups** page of the instructors (`/groups`, the link in the header) lists the groups of users the portal knows, of three kinds, each with its members (login, name, department):

- **departments**: the values of `attr_group` of `[auth.ldap]` (`departmentNumber`) over every person of `search_base`, the student group the portal has always carried per user (the Group column of the Watch page), listed as groups;
- **directory groups**: the entries of `group_search_base` matching `groups_filter` (`posixGroup` by default), named by `attr_group_name` (`cn`), their members the values of `attr_group_members` (`memberUid`): each value is looked up among the people as their login, their `uid` or their DN (a `groupOfNames` with `member` DNs works with `attr_group_members = "member"`); a value matching nobody but shaped like a login counts as that login, the DN of a nested group is dropped;
- **custom groups**: the groups the instructors create on the page (a name of at most 64 characters without `:` nor `/`, which may not be that of a department or of a directory group, a description), fill (logins typed or picked among the people of the directory, which refuses an unknown login; or every member of another group of any kind at once), empty (one member at a time, or at once every member who also belongs to another group of any kind) and delete. Any instructor may change any custom group; the creator and the dates are shown. A user may belong to several groups.

The directory is read whole, with the service account (or anonymously) of `[auth.ldap]`: two paged searches of `PAGE = 500` entries (the people base of a site exceeds the default size limit of a server), kept `directory_ttl` and read again on demand (the *Refresh* button, at most once per `refresh_interval`: the clicks arriving during a read get that reading, the next ones within the interval the reading just made, so that a row of clicks never dumps the directory once per click). The listing needs `uri`, `search_base` and the login attribute of the people: `attr_login`, or the attribute of a `search_filter` of the form `(attribute={login})` (`(supannAliasLogin={login})`); the departments need `attr_group`, the directory groups `group_search_base`. It works in every authentication mode, proxy mode included. The page says what is not configured, and shows the error of a directory read that failed (the previous reading stays until the next attempt, one minute later).

The custom groups live in two tables of the database of `[access_log.database]` (`[groups] table`, `user_groups` by default, and `<table>_members`), on iff that section is set. The tables are created when they are missing (the `CREATE` privilege, once), or create them by hand; the account needs `SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE` on these two tables (`UPDATE`: a renamed group or a changed description; the other tables keep `SELECT, INSERT, DELETE`):

```
CREATE TABLE sre.user_groups (
  id          BIGINT UNSIGNED NOT NULL AUTO_INCREMENT,
  name        VARCHAR(64)     CHARACTER SET utf8mb4 COLLATE utf8mb4_bin NOT NULL,
  description VARCHAR(255)    NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  created_by  VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  created_at  DATETIME(3)     NOT NULL,
  PRIMARY KEY (id),
  UNIQUE KEY name (name)
) ENGINE=InnoDB DEFAULT CHARSET=utf8mb4 COLLATE=utf8mb4_unicode_ci;
CREATE TABLE sre.user_groups_members (
  group_id    BIGINT UNSIGNED NOT NULL,
  login       VARCHAR(64)     CHARACTER SET utf8mb4 COLLATE utf8mb4_bin NOT NULL,
```

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```
  added_by    VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  added_at    DATETIME(3)     NOT NULL,
  PRIMARY KEY (group_id, login),
  KEY login (login)
) ENGINE=InnoDB DEFAULT CHARSET=utf8mb4 COLLATE=utf8mb4_unicode_ci;
GRANT SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE ON sre.user_groups TO 'sre_web'@'%';
GRANT SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE ON sre.user_groups_members TO 'sre_web'@'%';
```

The `name` and `login` columns are binary-collated: the names and logins are exact and case-sensitive, like the logins everywhere else (a table created with the default collation would find `INFO1` for `info1`). The members of a deleted group are deleted with it, in one transaction; the rows are never purged.

Every group is named by a key `kind:name` (`department:1A`, `directory:etudiants`, `custom:TP lundi`; a bare name is a department: the links and audiences made before the kinds keep working). The groups of every kind are offered by the group select of the Watch page (the column still shows the department) and by the audience dialog of a presentation: a student is in the audience when one of their groups is chosen, the department by the group of their identity, the others by the memberships the portal knows, read again every 30 s and after every change made on the page (a student added to a presented group is told at once, one removed loses the presentation). Every reading of the page is a `groups` line of the connection log, every change a `group_edit` line (`action` = `create` / `update` / `delete` / `add` / `remove`, `group`, and `member` (the one member removed), `source` (the group whose members were added or removed), `count` (the logins given to an add, the members a removal by source took out) or `new_name`).

3.3.8 Exams

The **Exams** page of the instructors (`/exams`, the link in the header) programs the exams of the web site. An exam is a title, an **audience** (logins and/or groups of any kind of the Groups page: a department, a directory group, a custom group), the **labs** to do (the exam-only labs, whose names hold `_EXAM_`, `_OLD_`, `_DRAFT_` or `_TESTS_`, are offered here and nowhere else; each lab may name a preset of its `Flavor` class, as `sre set-exam --labs lab:preset` does), a **duration** and/or a **window** (`start_after`, `end_before`; no start time = the exam starts when created, for each student as soon as they log in), two delays before the start — the **lead** (the other projects of the students are hidden and a countdown appears) and the **pre-start** (their exam projects are started in the background) —, the **networks** the students' browsers must come from (none = anywhere; the address is the client's, through `trusted_proxies`) and the **evaluation interval** of the agents during the exam. The defaults of the delays and of the interval are those of `[exams]`.

Unlike the exam mode of the Qt GUI (`sre set-exam`, `exam.json`, which locks a whole workstation and keeps a pool host out of the pool), an exam of the web site binds **its students only**, wherever their projects run: the portal computes the phase of each student and enforces it on every request, the agents apply the exam rules to the exam projects alone. Instructors are never bound, even when listed in the audience.

What a student sees, in order:

- **scheduled**: nothing changes before the lead window.
- **waiting** (the lead window, 10 min by default): a bar on every page counts down to the start; their other projects are hidden and refused (the Open page too); from the pre-start (5 min before) their Projects page starts the exam projects in the background, one at a time (the start slot and the placement of a normal start; a lab asking a flavor form shows it), and shows them without an Open link.
- **starting**: the start passed (or the exam has no start time), the exam projects are being started; the clock of the student starts when every lab of theirs has a running project.
- **active**: the countdown to their end; the Projects page lists the exam projects alone (a single one is opened by itself at the start); the project page has no Close button, no Evaluation tab nor Apply Configuration tab (as in the Qt GUI); the agent evaluates the project every `eval_interval` of the

exam. Each student has an individual clock: their end is `min(started + duration, end_before)` plus the minutes an instructor adds to them; an *End now* ends everybody's exam, or a selection's, at once.

- **ended**: the end banner (*That's all folks*) until the student presses *Continue*; the agent has cut the terminals and the X desktop, run the final evaluation and refuses every change (the answers included). After *Continue* the usual pages are back; the exam projects stay hidden from the student (and refused) until they are closed: `close_after` after the end by the agent (the idle timeout of an exam project counts from its end), or by the instructor (*Close projects* on the page, or the Watch page; the page stops them in the background, eight at a time, and shows the progress under the title of the exam; a second click while a close runs changes nothing).
- A student connecting from an address outside the networks of their exam gets the bar in red naming their address, and no project at all (neither the exam's nor the others) while the exam binds them.

A student in several exams at once follows the one started first. The phases are pushed to the open pages through the presence socket (`{"t": "exam", "id", "phase"}`: the pages read `GET /api/exam` then) and the countdowns use the portal's time.

On the page the instructor sees, per exam, every student the portal can name (the logins, the members of the groups it knows, those it has seen), connected or not, with their address, their phase, their clock, their extra minutes and their running exam projects (a link to each: the instructor's view of the student's project, the Evaluation tab included), and can, for everybody or for a selection (the checked rows): add or take minutes (for everybody the duration and the end time move together and an *End now* is lifted; for a selection their extra minutes, cumulative), *End now*, change the labs (the browsers start the new ones; the projects of a lab dropped stay as plain projects), *Close projects*, *Start now* (the start time set to now), *Edit* (every field; the students keep their clocks and adjustments) and *Delete* (the projects become plain projects, or are closed with the checkbox). The listing shows the scheduled, the running and the past exams.

The exams live in two tables of the database of `[access_log.database]` (`[exams] table`, `exams` by default, and `<table>_members`), on iff that section is set (the page says so otherwise): an exam survives a restart of the portal, the clocks of the students included, and the agents are told again what they missed. The tables are created when they are missing (the `CREATE` privilege, once), or create them by hand; the account needs `SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE` on the exams table (an edited exam) and `SELECT, INSERT, DELETE` on the members one (its rows are replaced):

```
CREATE TABLE sre.exams (
  id          BIGINT UNSIGNED NOT NULL AUTO_INCREMENT,
  title       VARCHAR(200)    NOT NULL,
  created_by  VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  created_at  DATETIME(3)     NOT NULL,
  updated_at  DATETIME(3)     NOT NULL,
  start_after DATETIME(3)     NULL,
  end_before  DATETIME(3)     NULL,
  duration    INT             NULL,
  ended_at    DATETIME(3)     NULL,
  details     MEDIUMTEXT      NOT NULL,
  PRIMARY KEY (id),
  KEY start_after (start_after),
  KEY created_at (created_at)
) ENGINE=InnoDB DEFAULT CHARSET=utf8mb4 COLLATE=utf8mb4_unicode_ci;
CREATE TABLE sre.exams_members (
  exam_id       BIGINT UNSIGNED NOT NULL,
  login         VARCHAR(64)     CHARACTER SET utf8mb4 COLLATE utf8mb4_bin NOT NULL,
  first_seen    DATETIME(3)     NULL,
  started_at    DATETIME(3)     NULL,
```

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```
  ended_at      DATETIME(3)     NULL,
  dismissed_at  DATETIME(3)     NULL,
  extra_minutes INT             NOT NULL DEFAULT 0,
  address       VARCHAR(64)     NOT NULL DEFAULT '',
  details       TEXT            NOT NULL,
  updated_at    DATETIME(3)     NOT NULL,
  PRIMARY KEY (exam_id, login)
) ENGINE=InnoDB DEFAULT CHARSET=utf8mb4 COLLATE=utf8mb4_unicode_ci;
GRANT SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE ON sre.exams TO 'sre_web'@'%';
GRANT SELECT, INSERT, DELETE ON sre.exams_members TO 'sre_web'@'%';
```

`duration` is in seconds; `details` holds the audience, the labs, the delays, the networks and the interval (JSON), the members' `details` their labs and their exam projects. The times are UTC, truncated to the millisecond like the rows of the connection log. The past exams are kept `keep` days (`0` = forever), their members with them.

The agents: an exam project is started by the portal with an `exam` object (`POST /v1/projects`: the id and title of the exam, the start and end of the student's clock once known, the evaluation interval) and a privileged `sre start` run under the student's login (`LOGNAME`), which accepts the exam-only labs and the flavor presets (`--set-flavor-name`); the agent keeps the object in the project's state file and in the rows of its listings (`exam`), evaluates the project at the interval of the exam once its clock runs, never reaps it before the end, refuses the owner's self-evaluation, states and close during the exam and every change after the end, and at the end cuts the terminals and the display, runs the final evaluation (`sre --user eval`: the exo-eval scope, like `sre end-exam`) and tells the open pages (`{"t": "exam", "ended": true}` on the events socket). The portal updates the object with `PUT /v1/projects/{rln}/exam` when the clock starts or the instructor adjusts the student (every 5 s until the agent has it), and drops it with `DELETE …/exam` when the exam is deleted or the lab is no longer the student's. The answers metadata of an exam project carry the exam fields of the Qt GUI's exam mode (`exam_mode`, `exam_started_at`, `exam_duration`, `exam_time_remaining`), so the archives carry the exam flag and the Archives page filters on it. The exam-only labs of the pool are listed by `GET /v1/labs?all=1` (instructors), a privileged `sre list --with-titles --include-exam-only`.

Connection log: every change of an exam is an `exam_edit` line (`action` = `create` / `update` / `delete` / `end` / `adjust` / `labs` / `close`, `exam`, `count` of students, `minutes`), a student dismissing the end banner an `exam_dismiss` line, and the `start` lines of the exam projects carry `exam`; the polls of the page and of the student's exam are keepalives.

Limitations: the session records (`record_sessions`) are not archived by the agents (the lab's attribute decides whether `records/` exists, `sre stop` deletes it); the archives of a web exam hold no `exam_json` document (the `exam` flag comes from the answers); anonymous mode has no stable logins to schedule; a page loaded before the portal was updated has no exam script until it is reloaded (the server still refuses what it must).

3.3.9 Web conference (BigBlueButton)

An instructor talks to a student, a group or the whole class without leaving the site: the portal opens **rooms** on a BigBlueButton (BBB) server and shows its client to the participants in an iframe over the pages of the site, while everybody goes on working on their projects. Nothing is installed on the pool hosts; the portal needs the API of the server, the browsers the server itself.

```
[bbb]
url = "https://bbb.example.org/"     # the server (its bigbluebutton/ or␣
↪bigbluebutton/api/ path works too)
secret = "..."                        # the shared secret of its API: bbb-conf --secret
# checksum = "sha1"                   # sha1 (default), sha256 or sha512:␣
```

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```
↪supportedChecksumAlgorithms of the server
# welcome = { fr = "Bienvenue", en = "Welcome" }   # the welcome message of the client␣
↪(the server's by default)
# record = false
# mute_on_start = false
# duration = 0                          # "2h": the server ends a meeting after that; 0 =␣
↪unlimited
# max_participants = 0
# poll_interval = "10s"                 # the participants and the ended meetings are read␣
↪that often
# private_rooms = true                  # Talk privately on a student's project (Private␣
↪conversations below)
# [bbb.userdata]                        # the client settings of every join␣
↪(userdata-bbb_*, the BBB API reference)
# bbb_skip_check_audio = true
# [bbb.private_userdata]                # the client settings of the joins of a private␣
↪conversation, over the others
# bbb_listen_only_mode = true
```

The instructors: the *Webconf* button of the site bar opens the dialog of the rooms: those open on the portal, with their owner, the size of their audience, who is connected to the site and who is in the room (read from the server every `poll_interval`), each with *Join* (this browser shows the room, as a moderator: any instructor may join any room), *Audience…* and *End* (any instructor); and a *New room* form: a name (the instructor's by default) and an audience chosen as for a presentation (the connected users one by one; the groups: departments, directory groups, custom groups; a member of a group connecting later is put in the room too). Unlike that of a presentation, the audience of a room may be empty (*None* then *Choose*): the room is then one of the instructors alone. A student is in at most one room at a time (the newest one including them); an instructor sees the room they created or joined last.

The participants: the client appears in a floating window over the page (dragged by its title bar, resized by its corner), with buttons to minimize it to its title bar, to dock it into the **Webconf** tab of the project page, to show it full page (a bar above it comes back), to pop it out to a separate browser window, and to leave (×). How it is shown and where the window is are remembered by the browser: the next page shows the conference the same way (in a window where there is no project tab). A participant who left, or whose client is in a separate window, keeps a pill in the site bar to rejoin or to bring it back; the *Leave meeting* of the client itself leads to that pill. Every page of the site loads the client again (a new join of the same room: a few seconds, the audio to join again), which a site of several pages cannot avoid: the separate window does. Two tabs of the same user never join twice: one holds the client, the others show a pill to bring it there.

The server: the meeting is created when the room is (a server that refuses or does not answer leaves no room: the dialog says so); a join is a URL signed for the user (`fullName` = their name, `userID` = their login, the role by their instructor flag: a moderator for an instructor, a viewer otherwise, the `bbb.userdata` settings), served by the portal as a redirect (`GET /api/webconfs/{id}/join`, the `src` of the iframe): the secret never leaves the portal. A meeting nobody joined expires on the server after a few minutes (`meetingExpireIfNoUserJoinedInMinutes`): the portal creates it again at the next join. A meeting everybody left expires about a minute later (`meetingExpireWhenLastUserLeftInMinutes`), like one a moderator ended from the client: the room ends on the portal at its next poll, every participant told. *End* in the dialog ends the meeting on the server. The rooms live in memory: a portal restart forgets them (the meetings expire on their own, the clients already in them stay until then).

Prerequisites: the portal reached over HTTPS, with `public_url` set (the `logoutURL` of the meetings, where the client comes back after *Leave meeting*, is built from it: `/webconf/left`); the server reachable from the portal (its API) and from the browsers (the client, over HTTPS); the nginx of the server must not forbid framing by the portal's origin (an `X-Frame-Options` header or a `frame-ancestors` directive on the client

would leave the frame empty: the separate window is the fallback); the pages of the portal allow the server's origin in the `frame-src` of their `Content-Security-Policy`, nothing else. BBB 2.4 at least (the `role` of the join; the passwords are still passed for older servers). Safari may refuse the camera in a cross-origin frame: pop the client out.

Private conversations

An instructor who opened a student's project (the helper view) may talk with that student alone, voice and text. BigBlueButton has no private audio inside a meeting (one audio bridge per meeting; its breakout rooms are made by hand in the client and open in another browser tab), so a private conversation is a **second meeting of the two**, which both browsers show *in place of* the class conference for as long as it lasts: nobody is ever in two meetings at once.

- **Talk privately**, in the bar of the project after *Focus student on project* (shown with `[bbb]` unless `private_rooms = false`), invites the owner of the project. Nothing else happens yet: both stay in the class conference, no meeting is created. The button reads *Calling… (cancel)* and takes the invitation back; an invitation nobody answers expires after a minute. The student must be connected to the site, and neither invited by somebody else nor in a private conversation already (the instructor is told so).
- **The student** gets a banner across the top of every page of the site they have open (above a presentation, inside an open dialog), with a short chime and a mark in the title of the page: the name of the instructor, *would like to talk with you*, and two buttons, *Join* and *Not now*. *Not now* tells the instructor; nothing opens a microphone before *Join*.
- **Join** creates the meeting and sends both browsers to it: the window of the conference (at the place and in the mode of the class conference: window, tab or full page) now shows the private room, titled *Private* — and the name of the other one, its title bar in its own colour. The joins go straight to the microphone, without the echo test or the choice of *Listen only* (`bbb_auto_join_audio`, `bbb_listen_only_mode = false`, `bbb_skip_check_audio`, `bbb_hide_presentation_on_join`; `[bbb.private_userdata]` overrides them, e.g. `bbb_listen_only_mode = true` to get the choice back); the meeting is never recorded and starts nobody muted, whatever `[bbb]` says for the rooms. The chat of that meeting is the text channel.
- **Only the tab where the user clicked** — *Talk privately* for the instructor, *Join* for the student — loads the client: the other tabs, and any other browser the same user is logged in from, leave the class conference and show the pill (*Bring here* moves the conversation). A browser left open somewhere never opens its microphone by itself.
- **The end**: the × of the window, *End conversation* in the bar of the project, or the *Leave meeting* of the client, by either of the two — leaving a conversation of two ends it; *End* in the Webconf dialog, by any instructor (the dialog lists the conversation, nobody else may join it or see its audience); and the server itself, a minute after the instructor is gone (a closed browser: `endWhenNoModerator`). Both browsers then show the class conference again, in the mode and at the place it had; an instructor comes back to the room they were in.
- An instructor already talking with a student may invite another one: the first conversation ends when the second one is accepted, and the instructor goes from one to the other. Joining another room from the Webconf dialog ends the instructor's conversation.

Limits: each switch reloads the client (a few seconds, twice per conversation), and both are out of the class conference meanwhile — the other students cannot reach the instructor there. A class conference popped out to a separate window is closed when the conversation starts (by the tab that opened it) and comes back in a window of the page; when that tab was closed since, the site cannot close the separate window: the user is then in both meetings until they close it. The invitations live in memory like the rooms.

The connection log gets the `webconf_*` events (*The connection log* above). Tests: `tests/test_bbb_client.py`, `tests/test_web_webconf.py` (the registry on a fake client, the portal in front of the fake server of

tests/fake_bbb.py), tests/test_web_webconf_browser.py (headless Chrome: the rooms, then the private conversations — the banner, the switch and the return of two pages, two tabs of one user holding one client).

3.3.10 Securing the pool (mutual TLS)

The portal and the agents can authenticate each other with certificates of one private CA, on top of the token: the agent serves TLS and requires a client certificate of that CA, the portal verifies the agents against the same CA and presents its client certificate. scripts/web-tls.sh makes the files with openssl:

```
scripts/web-tls.sh init-ca /root/sre-tls                          # ca.key, ca.crt (10 years)
scripts/web-tls.sh agent /root/sre-tls a01 IP:10.0.0.11 DNS:a01.example.org   # a01.key,␣
↪a01.crt
scripts/web-tls.sh portal /root/sre-tls                           # portal.key, portal.crt
```

On each pool host, agent.toml gets its own certificate and the CA (tls_cert = ".../a01.crt", tls_key = ".../a01.key", tls_ca = ".../ca.crt", files readable by root only) and, as a second fence, allowed_clients = ["<address of the portal>"]. On the portal host, web.toml gets [pool] ca = "../ca.crt", client_cert = ".../portal.crt", client_key = ".../portal.key" (readable by sre-web), and every [[hosts]] URL becomes https://<name or address in the certificate's SANs>:8451. The portal then logs TLS to the agents: CA …, client certificate … and each host as reachable; an agent without the right certificate, or a client without one, fails at the handshake, before any request.

3.3.11 A whole site at once (scripts/make-web-hosts.sh)

scripts/make-web-hosts.sh writes everything the previous section asks for, for every pool host of a site, from a list of its machines:

```
IP_MAC_FILE=ip_mac.txt OUT_DIR=/root/sre-pool REGEXP='^([a-z])[0-9]+$' ROOMS="a h"␣
↪DISABLED_ROOMS=h \
    scripts/make-web-hosts.sh
```

The list has one mac;ip;name line per machine (e4:54:e8:d1:6c:1c;10.0.128.1;a01: the MAC address for Wake-on-LAN, the IPv4 address the portal reaches its agent at, the name). A machine gets an agent when its lower-cased name matches REGEXP; the first group of the expression, when there is one, is its room, so that ROOMS selects the rooms joining the pool (empty: every qualified machine) and DISABLED_ROOMS those whose hosts start with enabled = false (polled, no project placed there until sre-web-tool enable). These five variables are required and have no default; AGENT_PORT (8451), MAX_PROJECTS (25), POWER (power = true in the entries and allow_power_off = true on the agents), DOMAIN (a DNS:<name>.<domain> SAN too), PORTAL_ADDRESS (allowed_clients of the agents), INSTRUCTOR_ROOMS (the rooms whose hosts get instructors_only = true) and INSTRUCTOR_MACHINES (the names of the hosts that get it on their own, whatever their room), TLS_DIR_ON_HOSTS (/etc/sreweb/tls, the paths written in the files) and CA_KEY / CA_CRT (both set: an existing CA copied into OUT_DIR instead of a new one, so that the hosts of a new OUT_DIR are signed by the CA the portal already knows; refused when OUT_DIR holds another CA) are optional.

In OUT_DIR (private keys and tokens: outside any repository) it writes, through web-tls.sh, the CA and the portal's client certificate once, then per host a key and a certificate (SANs IP:<ip> and DNS:<name>), a token in <name>.token, and:

- hosts.toml: the [[hosts]] entries, one room after the other, with the three [pool] TLS lines of web.toml in its header; a file of web.d/ (import = ["web.d"]) or pasted at the end of web.toml;
- agent-<name>.toml: the host-specific lines of that host's agent.toml (listen = "<ip>:8451", token, tls_*, and allowed_clients / allow_power_off when asked), to complete with the example file, whose own listen and token lines are then removed (a key given twice is refused).

Copy `<name>.crt`, `<name>.key` and `ca.crt` to `TLS_DIR_ON_HOSTS` of each host, and `ca.crt`, `portal.crt`, `portal.key` to the portal's. Every run computes `hosts.toml` and the agent files from the variables of the moment, so the rooms, the disabled or reserved hosts may change at any time, and compares them with the previous run: a file whose content did not change is left as it is, the others are replaced, what changed is printed per host (`enabled`, `instructors_only`, `allow_power_off`…) with the new hosts and those no longer selected, and the last line says whether `hosts.toml` and which agent files are to deploy again; the CA and the portal's certificate are made once. The hosts' keys, certificates and tokens are made anew on every run, to deploy again, unless the script is run with `--keep`: the files already there are kept and only those of the new hosts are made (a kept certificate that no longer names the address of its host is reported), so a room is added, or a host disabled or reserved, without touching the hosts already deployed.

3.3.12 A pool of workstations

The pool hosts are typically classroom workstations: off when nobody needs them (a nightly cron shuts them down), woken by Wake-on-LAN, and sometimes used at the keyboard by a student. The portal gives each host a **state** from the status of its agent, and `sre-web-tool list` (or the *Pool* page of the instructors) shows it:

State	Meaning	New projects
`off`	the agent does not answer	no
`waki`	a wake was sent less than `wake_timeout` ago	no, but a start answers "a host is starting" (503, retried by the Open page)
`up`	the agent answers, the host is free	yes
`occu`	the agent answers, the host is used locally (`occupied_check`)	only the new projects of the users logged in there (`follow_local_sessions`); the web projects already running there go on
`exam`	the agent answers, `exam.json` is on the host	no
`drai`	the portal asked the host to power off, or `sre-web-tool drain`	no; powered off once it is empty
`disa`	`sre-web-tool disable`, or `enabled = false`	no; the projects already running there go on (listed, usable, evaluated and closed as usual), the host stays polled and is never powered off by the portal — `drain` is the way to empty a host and shut it down

Placement. A new project (`POST /api/projects`) goes to one host, chosen by the portal from the last status poll of every agent (`poll_interval`) without asking them again. The candidates are the hosts `up` (plus, for a user logged in at the keyboard of an `occupied` host, that host: *Occupied hosts* below), below their `max_projects`, not reserved for the instructors when the caller is a student, and whose agent has no restart pending (`sre-web-tool restart`: the agent refuses new projects until it is back). Among them: the host of the user's own session first, then the lowest `projects / max_projects`, then the lowest one-minute load, then the name, so that equal hosts are always settled the same way. The project count of the chosen host is raised at once and a *reservation* is kept until the start is over and a status poll sent after its end has answered: a burst of simultaneous starts is spread over the pool instead of piling onto the host the last poll showed emptiest, and `sre-web-tool list` may count a project one poll before the agent does. Without any candidate the start is refused with 503 and a `retry_after` the Open page obeys: "a host is starting" (30 s) when a host the caller may use is `waking` or restarting, "no host available for a new project" (60 s) otherwise. An instructor naming a host on the Open page skips the ranking: the host must exist (404), be open to them (403 for a student), be available to them (503 "not available") and have room (503 "full").

The `start` line of the connection log says why the host was chosen: `placement=load`, `session` or `named`.

Waking. A host with a `mac` gets a magic packet (UDP port 9 to `wol_broadcast`: the portal must be on the hosts' network, or the routers must forward the directed broadcast); a host with a `wake_command` gets that command instead (`ssh relay wakeonlan {mac}`, an IPMI or VM call…). The portal wakes one sleeping host, in configuration order, whenever the free project slots of the hosts up (plus the capacity of those waking) drop below `spare_projects`, and keeps `min_hosts_up` hosts awake during `active_hours`: the floor is re-established in the morning and not fought at night after the cron. A host still silent after `wake_timeout` is retried after 1, 2, 4… up to 30 minutes, so a machine that is really down is not hammered. The agent must be an enabled systemd unit on every host (boot → agent up → the portal sees it).

Occupied hosts. The agent reports `occupied` when a local login session exists (`loginctl`, `who` as a fallback) or when projects of the Qt GUI run on the host; the portal places nothing there and never powers it off. The web projects already running there continue. One exception, `follow_local_sessions` (`true` by default): the user logged in at the keyboard of a pool host gets their new projects on that host, whatever its load, so that a student working at a classroom workstation uses their own machine through the web too. The agent names the sessions in its status (`session:<login>`, the OCCUPIED column of `sre-web-tool list`; its `occupied_check` must include the sessions) and the portal matches them against the login of the identity, which must therefore be the Unix login of the workstation (the directory `uid`: `AuthLDAPRemoteUserAttribute uid` in the Apache example; a `guest-…` pseudonym never matches). The rule overrides the load and the occupation only: when the host is full (`max_projects`), in exam mode, disabled, draining or reserved for the instructors, the normal placement applies, and an instructor naming a host on the Open page is obeyed (they may name the host of their own session). The `start` line of the connection log says `placement=session`. `follow_local_sessions = false` restores the strict rule: nothing goes to an occupied host.

Reserved hosts. A host with `instructors_only = true` never takes a student's project: an instructor's goes there when they name it on the Open page (the *Host* select lists the reserved hosts with their state and their projects) or by the automatic placement when it is the least loaded host they may use. It is outside the elastic pool: its free slots count neither as spare capacity nor towards `min_hosts_up`, the portal never wakes it by itself (`sre-web-tool wake`, or its own boot; an instructor finds it greyed while it is off) and powers it off when idle like any host with `power = true`, whatever the floor and the spare. `list` shows `(instructors)` after its state. A student logged in at the keyboard of a reserved host is still placed elsewhere: `follow_local_sessions` never overrides the reservation.

Going down. When the agent's unit stops because the system halts (the nightly cron, a `poweroff`), the agent closes the projects it manages as a Close would (the last evaluation, then `sre stop`), concurrently, within `TimeoutStopSec`; the browsers see "project closed". With `power = true` on the host and `allow_power_off = true` in its `agent.toml`, the portal powers off an idle host itself: `idle_host_timeout` (0 by default: only the cron does it), above `min_hosts_up` and as long as the spare capacity stays, or at once with `sre-web-tool poweroff`.

Pre-loading the images. A project whose Docker images are not on its host yet waits for their download at its start, and a room of workstations pulling them at the same time takes the whole bandwidth of the site; the boot unit `sre-preload-images.service` (see *Installation*) only spreads the pulls over a random delay. On the pool, the agents pull and the portal lets **a few hosts at a time** do it:

- a host *asks*: its agent starts with `[preload] at_start = true` in `agent.toml` (the boot of the host, a restart of the agent), or `sre-web-tool preload NAME | --all | --failed` or the *Preload images* button of the Pool page ask for it by hand (after new labs or a new image version). The agent then says `pending` in its status and pulls nothing;
- the portal *gives turns*: at every poll, as many waiting hosts as `[pool] max_preloads` (2) leaves free get `POST /v1/preload/start`, the one that waited longest first; the agent then runs `sre preload-images --progress` on its lab directories (`[preload] paths`) and reports the image it pulls. A request by hand goes through the same queue: the number of hosts downloading never exceeds `max_preloads`, whoever asked;

- every host that asks takes a turn, even with every image already there: its `docker pull`s only check the registry, a few seconds, and an image pushed again under the same tag is fetched.

`sre-web-tool list` shows `(preload queued)`, `(preload 2/5)` or `(preload failed)` after the state, the Pool page the same as flags (the image being pulled, or the error, as tooltip), and `sre-web-tool status` the count of each. A preload that fails (`failed`: an image that does not exist, the registry unreachable; the error names the images) is not tried again by itself: `sre-web-tool preload --failed` asks again. A disabled or occupied host is served like the others — its local users start labs too —; a host is not given a turn while projects of an exam of the web site run on it, while it is draining or its agent restarting, and an idle host waiting for its turn is not powered off by `idle_host_timeout`. A stop or a restart of the agent stops the preload in progress (Docker keeps the layers already there): with `at_start` the agent started next asks again, a request made by hand is forgotten. Nothing is preloaded without the portal (the hosts stay `pending`; the images are then pulled by the first start that needs them, as without any preload) nor with `max_preloads = 0`; the agents older than this feature are left alone. On a host whose agent has `at_start`, leave `sre-preload-images.service` disabled: both would pull.

Nothing asks again on a timer. A host that boots every day checks at each boot; one that stays up does not notice new labs or a new image version until its agent restarts (`sre-web-tool restart --all` after a sync makes every `at_start` agent ask again) or a preload is asked by hand, and a failed one stays failed. A cron job on the portal's host makes the check periodic, through the same queue (`max_preloads` hosts at a time):

```
0 3 * * *  sre-web-tool preload --all
```

Restarting the agents. After an update of the tree the agents run the old Python code until their unit is restarted: `sre-web-tool restart NAME`, or `restart --all` for every reachable host (whatever its state), tells each agent to restart itself (`POST /v1/restart`). The agent answers at once, lets its running `sre` commands end (a start, an evaluation; no new project is accepted meanwhile), then runs `systemctl reset-failed` and `systemctl --no-block restart` on its own unit (`sre-agent` or `sysreseval-agent`, read from `/proc/self/cgroup`; `restart_command` in `agent.toml` replaces that for an agent run otherwise). The projects stay (`close_projects_on_stop = "shutdown"`: a restart is not a shutdown; with `always` they are closed), the open terminals and virtual desktops are lost, the project pages reconnect by themselves. The stop is quick: the agent closes the project pages' WebSockets itself (aiohttp would otherwise wait a minute for them) and `KillMode=mixed` ends what is left. `list` shows `(restart)` after the state until the portal sees the agent's uptime reset (or gives up after two minutes with a warning in its journal); the host takes no project meanwhile and keeps its drain. `--wait` makes the tool wait for the agents to be back (`--timeout`, 180 s by default), so a deployment script can chain it after the sync. A `DO_NOT_START_AGENT` marker written since the start is honoured (that agent stops); code that no longer starts leaves the unit failed after five attempts (`journalctl -u sre-agent`, then `systemctl reset-failed`). The portal itself is restarted by hand (`systemctl restart sre-web`; *Restarting the portal* below).

By hand. `sre-web-tool …` (`sbin/sre-web-tool` of a checkout, `/usr/sbin/sre-web-tool` of the `sysreseval-web` package; `python3 -m sreweb.tool` from the sources) talks to the running portal through its administration API (`[admin] token`, loopback only by default; `--config`, `--url`, `--token` override the configuration):

```
sre-web-tool list                # one line per host: state, projects/max, load, terminals, occupied by, uptime
sre-web-tool status              # spare capacity, hosts awake vs the floor, active hours, hosts waking, the state file
sre-web-tool add a03 --url https://10.0.0.13:8451 --token … [--mac … | --wake-command …] [--max-projects 25] [--power] [--instructors-only]
sre-web-tool remove a03 [--force] # refused while the host has projects (--force leaves them to the agent's idle reaper)
sre-web-tool disable a03 | enable a03   # disable: no new project on the host, the running ones go on until their users close them
```

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```
sre-web-tool wake a03 | poweroff a03 | drain a03   # drain: no new project, powered off␣
↪once the last project is closed
sre-web-tool restart a03 | --all [--wait] [--timeout 180]   # the agents restart␣
↪themselves (new code), the projects stay
sre-web-tool preload a03 | --all | --failed   # the hosts pull the Docker images of the␣
↪labs, max_preloads of them at a time
```

`list` shows `config` or `added` per host; a config host removed by hand comes back, enabled, with `enable`. `--json` gives the raw rows. The instructors have the same actions on the **Pool** page of the portal (`/pool`, see *Instructors* below), except `add` and `remove`, which stay with the token.

Restarting the portal. What is changed by hand, with the tool or on the Pool page, is kept in `[admin] state_file` (`pool.json`, written at every change through a temporary file renamed over it) and merged with the `[[hosts]]` of `web.toml` at every start, so that a restart of the portal leaves the pool as it was:

Kept	How
the hosts added and removed by hand	`added` (the whole entry, its token included: the file is `0600`), `removed`
a host enabled or disabled by hand	`enabled` / `disabled`: the hosts whose flag differs from the `enabled` of their `[[hosts]]` entry, in both directions (a host of `DISABLED_ROOMS` enabled for a class stays enabled)
a drain	`drain`, with the time it was asked; over when the host is gone, or was booted again while the portal was stopped
a wake in progress, the pause after failed wakes or after a power off, a power off or a restart sent	`clocks` (written within one poll and when the portal stops); each is dropped at the start when too old to mean anything

The file only holds what differs from the configuration, and **an edit of the configuration wins**: a flag set by hand holds for as long as the `enabled` of that host in `web.toml` is what it was then. Once the file says the same (the room taken out of `DISABLED_ROOMS`, for instance) the entry is dropped at the next start, and a later edit of `web.toml` is followed again; so is the entry of a host that is no longer in the pool (one line of the journal each). The start logs `pool state read from …: 0 removed, 0 added, 21 enabled and 1 disabled by hand, 0 draining`.

A state file that cannot be written (a read-only directory, a container without its volume) would lose all of this at the next restart: the portal says so in its journal at the start and at every failed write (`pool state NOT saved in …`), `sre-web-tool status` prints `pool state: NOT SAVED in …` instead of the path, and the Pool page shows it in red above its table. In a container, `/var/lib/sre-web` must be a mounted directory the `sre-web` user may write; the systemd units provide it (`StateDirectory`). A file the portal cannot read (edited as another user, or no longer a JSON object) is not written over: it is renamed `pool.json.unreadable`, said in the journal, and the pool starts from the configuration; edit the file with the portal stopped and leave it to the `sre-web` user.

Not kept: the idle clock of `idle_host_timeout` (it counts again from the start), and what is listed under *Limitations* (the presentations, the focuses, the open sockets: the pages reconnect by themselves, a terminal with its Reconnect button). The exams, the custom groups, the connection log and the archives are in the database; the sessions are in the browsers' cookies (`secret`).

3.4 What the users see

- **Header**: the SRE logo and, with `[site]` in `web.toml`, the institution's logo and name next to it, on every page.
- **Login**: the directory account, or (anonymous mode) a display name and a language; in proxy mode the web server in front has already asked, there is no login page.
- **Projects**: the user's running projects on the whole pool (Open, Close), "Open a lab" (the lab tree with its titles, in the order the `titles.json` of each directory sets, by file name, by title in the language of the page or by hand, the sub-directories first, the same tree as the Qt GUI's; the Flavor form when the lab has one; the progress of the pulls and deploys); with no running project the page shows the SRE logo in large, as the Qt GUI does when no project is open. An instructor's cards say the mode of each project (Standard / Instructor mode / Debug mode, the words of the Open page), the two non-standard modes also as a coloured suffix after the title. Logout asks what to do with the running projects: close them (each as a Close does: the last evaluation when the lab asks for it, then `sre stop`; the dialog waits for every answer) or leave them running; with no running project the button logs out at once.
- **A project**: the tabs of the Qt GUI. The schema is drawn by the agent (graphviz) with the same options (lines, spacing, order, icons); the questions and the forms are the same; the evaluation table has the same parts, subtotals, bonuses and colours; the terminals are `xterm.js` terminals on `sre connect`: every Connect button of the Machines and Networks tabs opens a new one on its device in a **floating window** over the page (like the external xterm of the Qt GUI: `gw`, `gw (2)`, …; the window stays while the tabs change, is dragged by its title bar, resized by its bottom-right corner and closed by its ×, and takes the font size and the colour scheme of the Terminals tab), the two selects of the Terminals tab open one on any device (the machines open to the students and the managed switches) as a sub-tab or in a window, the of a sub-tab moves its terminal into a window and the dock button of a window brings it back as a sub-tab (the same shell goes on), the × of a sub-tab or of a window closes it, `terminals_per_device` caps them; the Log tab appears for debug projects. *Export Schema to PDF* downloads the drawing of the Schema tab with its current options (never the hidden machines), rendered by the agent as the GUI's File → Export Schema to PDF does, unless the lab sets `export_schema_pdf = False`; the icons need `rsvg-convert` (`librsvg2-bin`) on the pool host, graphviz shapes otherwise. The Kathara export is not offered on the web. A terminal is a session shared by its viewers: the live sessions of the project that are not on the page are listed under the bar with a Join button (the same shell for everybody, the last 64 KiB of output replayed to the newcomer, the pty sized to the smallest window), a sub-tab or a window shows how many viewers its session has, and a session ends when the shell exits or when its last viewer closes it with its ×. A viewer that just goes away (the page closed, reloaded or cut, another project opened) leaves the session running for `terminals_linger` of the agent (120 minutes by default), listed *idle* meanwhile, and the page coming back to the project finds the user's own terminals again, sub-tabs and windows where they were on that browser, with the last 64 KiB of output (a page the browser kept in its back/forward cache, brought back by the Back button, joins its sessions again by itself); after a disconnection, Reconnect joins the same session again.
- **A presentation**: when an instructor presents a project to the class (*Present* below), the page of every chosen student is covered by that project, read-only: every tab is there but nothing can be done on it, and the tab shown, the terminals open (the instructor's shells, in their exact size, at the largest font that fits; the instructor's floating windows float on the student's page too, at the same relative place and size), the question selected, the drawing options of the schema, the instructor texts and the virtual desktop (view-only) follow what the instructor does; so does the position inside the tab: the scroll of the text, of the question (its description and the list of titles), of the tables and of the log (the line at the top of the instructor's pane is at the top of the student's, whatever the size of their window or their font size), and the pan and zoom of the schema. The instructor's mouse pointer is drawn on the student's page too, an arrow carrying the instructor's name, and what the instructor selects — in the texts, the question, the tables, the log, the schema, or in a terminal — is highlighted there (in a

terminal: selected in the student's read-only terminal, in lavender); both are placed on the element, the word or the terminal cell the instructor's mouse is on, never at the same pixel, so that a student with another window size, font size or word wrap sees the pointer on the same word. The Evaluation tab shows the table of the instructor's page as it is (the letters of their own self-evaluation included), again after each evaluation. The title bar of the presented project is coloured (lavender) and names the instructor presenting it. The student's own page is untouched underneath, terminals included: when the presentation ends it is back as it was.

3.4.1 Instructors

Who is an instructor is decided by the directory, the role being the OR of the tests configured in `web.toml` (a test whose key is empty is skipped):

- `instructor_groups`: the user is a member of one of these groups (DNs), through the `memberOf` attribute of their entry or, with `group_filter = "(member={dn})"`, a search of the groups under `group_search_base` (`search_base` without it);
- `instructor_filter`: the user's own entry matches this LDAP filter (a BASE search on their DN), `"(gidNumber=2000)"` by default — the primary group; a site with the memberof overlay may write `"(memberOf=cn=teachers,ou=groups,dc=example,dc=org)"`; `""` disables the test;
- `group_search_base` + `instructor_group_filter`: a group found under that base names the user (`{login}` and `{dn}` are substituted, filter-escaped), by default a `posixGroup` of gid 2000 listing the login in `memberUid` (the group search that needs no overlay; a `groupOfNames` site writes `"(&(cn=teachers)(member={dn}))"`); setting `group_search_base` enables the test.

In LDAP mode the portal runs them when the user logs in (the role is kept in the session cookie: a change applies at the next login). In proxy mode the reverse proxy authenticates and the tests are run on the request headers (`instructor_groups` on the groups header, `instructor_values` on `instructor_header`: any attribute `mod_authnz_ldap` exports) and, with `ldap_roles = true`, by the portal itself with the `[auth.ldap]` settings for the login the proxy gives (the service account or an anonymous search finds the entry, then the same three tests; the entry's `attr_group` is read at the same time, so with that key set the lookup runs for the users the headers already made instructors too, who keep the role whatever the directory says), the result being cached per login for `ldap_roles_ttl`; a directory failure makes the login a student without group for a minute (logged once) rather than the site unavailable. `ldap_groups = true` does the group part alone: the directory gives the group of a user whose header carries none, the roles stay those of the headers (the production case: `gidNumber` exported by Apache, `departmentNumber` read by the portal for the owners of the Qt GUI projects on the Watch page).

What an instructor gets:

- **Watch** (the link in the header, `/watch`): every running project of every reachable host, one row per project with its host, owner (the login), name (the full name of the answers metadata, or the directory's for a project of the Qt GUI when the portal reads it, above), the owner's student group when the site configures one (`attr_group` / `header_group`), lab, start time, the age of its last archived evaluation, its grade and mark (exo-eval scope, as `sre watch` shows them), its errors and warnings, the number of self-evaluations the student has run (the agent counts the lines of the project's `.private/auto_eval.log`, one per `sre eval --auto-eval` of the student: live, whereas the `auto_eval_count` of an archive, the AUTO-EVAL column of `sre watch` and the Self-evaluations column of the Archives page, is the count before that evaluation), its open terminals and whether the web or the Qt GUI runs it; sortable by any column, filtered by text (host, owner, group, lab) and, with a group source, by the select listing the groups by kind (the departments of the rows, the directory groups and the custom groups of the Groups page, *User groups* above; every group, one group, or *No group*: the projects whose owner has no department, those started on the Qt GUI carrying none unless the portal reads the directory, above), the chosen group kept in the URL (`?group=kind:name`, a bookmark per class group) and remembered by the browser (`localStorage`): the page comes back with the group chosen last, through the *Watch* link of the header or in a new tab, until another group or *All groups* is chosen, a link with `?group=`

winning and becoming the remembered one; refreshed every 5 s; a row whose last evaluation had errors is red, one without an evaluation younger than 15 minutes (or twice the lab's evaluation interval) is amber. Open goes to the project, Close stops it. The agents read the archives of their own host (`params.archive_dirs`) on demand, nothing is scanned while nobody watches. As in `sre watch`, the page also shows the details: a **click on a row** opens a dialog with the last archived evaluation of the project (the owner, the lab and the host in the title, the date of the evaluation, the table of its grade elements with the parts, the subtotals, the bonuses, the total and the mark, then the errors and the warnings of the run; *Open the project* goes to its page; Esc or *Close* goes back), and a **click on the lab cell** of a row opens the summary of that lab for the rows shown (the text filter and the group select apply, so a class group alone when wanted; the lab is the file really run, so the projects started through a course directory's symbolic link to a lab and through the lab's own path are one lab): a matrix with one row per project and one column per grade element (numbered, the element as the tooltip of the number, the parts as a header row; a cell is the grade, or the OK / MEH / FAIL letter, coloured like the evaluation table; Total and Mark last; a project never evaluated says so), the rows *Max*, *Average* and *Success* (how many of the evaluated projects got the full grade) below it, then the table of the elements with their maximum, minimum, average and distribution of the grades (`1.5(2) 3(7)`), a subtotal row per part, as the lab summary of `sre watch`. The elements of the projects are matched by their title, whatever the language of each student. A **click on the group cell** of a row (when it holds a group) opens the same summary for that lab restricted to the whole group: every project of the lab on the pool whose owner has that group, whatever the text filter (the lab cell keeps the rows shown; an empty group cell opens the last evaluation like the other cells). Both dialogs follow the polls: a new evaluation of the project, or of one of the projects of the lab, reloads the content, a project closed is said so. Reading the results of a student this way never counts as their activity (their project's idle clock is left alone).

- **Archives** (the link in the header, `/archives`): the evaluations collected into the database (*The archives of the evaluations* above; without `[access_log.database]` the page says so), the closed projects included. The **Evaluations** view lists them newest first, one row per evaluation with its time, the student (login, name, group when a group source is configured), the lab, the pool host, the start of the project, the grade and the mark (exo-eval scope), the errors / warnings counts, how many self-evaluations the student had run and whether it was an exam; a row whose evaluation had errors is red. The form searches by *Student* (the beginning of a login, or a part of a name), *Group* (a group of the table, with suggestions), *Lab* (a part of its name, with suggestions), *Host*, a *From* / *To* window on the evaluation time and the exam flag, and chooses what to *Show*: **the last evaluation of each project** (the default: the final result of every project, among the evaluations matching the window, the host and the exam flag), **the last evaluation of each student** (one row per student and lab) or **every evaluation** (the progression of a project). *Rows* and the *Older* / *Newer* buttons page through the result; a click on a login, group, lab or host cell filters on that value; the filters and the view are kept in the URL (a search can be bookmarked or shared; `?open=<id>` opens one evaluation: a link to a result). A **click on a row** opens the evaluation as the Watch page's dialog does (the student, the lab and the host in the title, the time of the evaluation and of the start of the project, the table of its grade elements with the parts, the subtotals, the bonuses, the total and the mark, laid out by the browser from the stored elements exactly as the agent lays out the evaluation of a running project, then the errors and the warnings of the run). The **Summary** view (the second button of the toolbar; a lab is required: without one the view lists the labs of the archives, a click on one loads its summary; the search starts on the last evaluation of each student) is the lab summary of the Watch page for the evaluations found: one block per lab matched (the lab file really run, as on the Watch page: the evaluations of the projects started through a symbolic link to a lab are in the lab's block, and the lab filter matches the path started as well as the file), with the matrix of the students and the grade elements (Total and Mark last, the rows *Max* / *Average* / *Success* below) and the table of the elements with their statistics; a click on a row of the matrix opens the evaluation. The summary is computed on the 500 newest evaluations found at most (the page says so: narrow the filters). Searching the results of a class group is `Group` + `Lab` + *Summary*; the results of one student across the labs, `Student` alone. **Reports.** A checkbox at the left of each row selects evaluations (the header checkbox takes the rows shown; the selection is kept

while paging and searching, the bar says how many are selected and how many are not on the page), and the bar under the filters downloads a **Spreadsheet** (what `sre sheet` gives: per lab, the table of every evaluation, the *Questions* statistics and the *Sessions* best grades), the **PDF reports** (what `sre outline` gives: a zip holding one PDF per student and lab, `<login>__<lab>.pdf`, and `outline.ods`, the summary) or the **Summary spreadsheet** (what `sre outline -o` gives: that `outline.ods` alone, one row per student and lab with the best evaluation, its time and the mark) of the selected evaluations. **A student is a login here, whatever the host**: the portal places each project on any host of the pool, so the instances of a lab a student opened several times are merged into one row, one PDF and one *Sessions* row even when they ran on different hosts (the two commands, run by hand on the archives of a host, keep one per login *and* hostname: the hostname is the student's workstation there, and tells apart the users of a shared account); the `hostname` of a merged row, and of the header of its PDF, is the host of the best evaluation, and each history table of the PDF is headed by the start time and the host of its instance. A selected evaluation stands for its whole project: every stored evaluation of the same projects goes into the reports (the history table of a PDF, every row of the spreadsheet, the best evaluation of the summary), as `sre sheet archives/` would do on a host; the *Options* disclosure unticks that (**Every evaluation of the selected projects**: the ticked rows alone then) and gives the flags of the two commands: **One report / row per project instance** (`--separate-instances`: a student who opened a lab twice gets two reports, or two summary rows, instead of one with two history tables), **"Bonus" before the label** (`--bonus-in-prefix`), **Evaluation history**, **Remaining time column** (exams) and **Group by part** (the PDF only: the two spreadsheets ignore them). At most 1000 rows may be ticked; the PDF reports and the summary spreadsheet may cover 150 000 evaluations (300 projects of 300 evaluations give their PDFs in about a minute), the spreadsheet 5000 (the page says so: narrow the selection or untick the option). The file is named after the lab when the selection is of one lab (`evaluations_dhcp_20261109-1430.ods`, `reports_dhcp_20261109-1430.zip`, `summary_dhcp_20261109-1430.ods`), is built by one agent of the pool from the stored rows (*The archives of the evaluations* above) in the language of the page, and is saved by the browser; the buttons read *Generating…* meanwhile, a few seconds for a class.

- **Pool** (the link in the header, `/pool`): every host of the pool, one row per host with its state as `sre-web-tool list` shows it (the seconds and the failed attempts of a wake), its projects and terminals, its load, who occupies it, its uptime, its flags (reserved for instructors, power, drain, power off sent, restart sent, and where the preload of the Docker images is: *preload queued*, *preloading 2/5* with the image as tooltip, *preload failed* with the error), the agent's version and its last error, the line of `sre-web-tool status` above the table (in red, with the reason, when the state file of the pool cannot be written: a restart of the portal would undo what is changed on the page); the state cell is green (up), amber (waking, occupied, exam, draining), red (off: the agent does not answer) or grey (disabled, muted text); sortable by any column, filtered by host name (one or several words: the hosts whose name contains any of them, `a01 a02 h` for those two and every `h…` host), refreshed every 5 s. The buttons of a row are the commands of the tool: *Enable* (green) / *Disable* (red), *Wake* (light green; a host with a `mac` or a `wake_command`, while it is off), *Drain*, *Power off* (asked to confirm; allowed by the agent's `allow_power_off`, refused while the host has a project or a local session), each disabled with the reason as its tooltip when it does not apply. A checkbox per row (the one of the header ticks the hosts shown by the filter) selects hosts for the bar above the table: the count of the selected hosts (and how many the filter hides), the same five buttons and *Preload images* (the bar only: the selected hosts wait for their turn to pull the Docker images of the labs, see *Pre-loading the images* above), each acting on every selected host its action applies to, one call per host run together (the tooltip says how many, the button is disabled when none; *Power off* asks once with the names; the failures come in one message, the selection stays). Adding and removing hosts, and restarting the agents (`restart`, shown as the flag *restart sent* while it lasts), stay with `sre-web-tool`. Every action, of a row or of the bar, is an `admin` line of the connection log with the instructor's login.
- **Projects** stays the instructor's own projects (Watch holds the others).
- **A student's project**: the student named in the project bar after the lab title (full name and login, from the answers metadata; the login alone when the file has no name); every tab, the devices all open

(the privileged `sre connect`), the answers editable (what the instructor types goes into the student's answers file, whose metadata stays the student's: the Watch page and the archives still name the student; every save of either page is pushed to the open pages of the project, so the student's page shows the instructor's text within a second and the instructor's page the student's); the top of the page (the site bar and the project bar) takes the **helper colour** (teal) on the instructor's browser only, a reminder that the project is not theirs (the student's page stays grey; the presentation colour replaces it while the project is presented); the Terminals tab **joins the student's live terminals** when it opens (the instructor sees the student's shell and may type in it, the student sees the same; a closed sub-tab is not joined again), and the selects offer a **private terminal** (the student does not see it in their list; what the instructor types there stays with them) or a shared one, the Connect buttons a private one in a window; a terminal on a device the student cannot open themself (a closed machine or switch, a hidden machine) is **always private**, whatever the choice: the shared kind is greyed for it and the agent makes the session private anyway; the Evaluation tab opens on the **last archived evaluation** of the project (date, errors in the tooltip), shows each new one by itself (the periodic evaluations of the lab, the student's own, another instructor's: the agent tells the open pages) and *Start evaluation* runs a privileged `sre eval` (no cooldown, nothing counted on the student's side, the exo-eval marks); the states apply through the privileged path too. All this is for somebody else's project: on their own, an instructor is the student (see *Instructor mode* below).

- **Focus student on project**: the toggle button of a student's project page (off by default) brings the student to what the instructor is looking at. While it is on, every page of the student that does not show the project goes to it (now, and any page they open later: the student stays on the project until the button is turned off), the top of both pages (the site bar and the project bar) takes the **focus colour** (a deeper teal than the helper colour, which comes back on the instructor's page when the mode is off), the student's page names the instructor following them, and the two pages share the **tab** shown, the **terminal** last gone to, sub-tab or floating window (a terminal the student may see: their own sessions and the shared ones, joined by both: a terminal one page shows is joined by the other, as a sub-tab, when it has not got it; a private terminal of the instructor is never shown nor named to the student, whose page keeps its sub-tab while the instructor is on one; a page brought to the Terminals tab by the focus opens no terminal of its own, as it does when its user clicks the tab for the first time) and the **question** selected, in both directions: whichever page changes one of them, the other follows, the last change winning. The student's page also shows the instructor's **mouse pointer** (an arrow with their name) and what the instructor **selects**, as the pages of a presentation show the presenter's: on the same paragraph, table cell or tab button, on the same row and column of a terminal both pages have, whatever the sizes of the two windows (nothing is drawn while the student is on another tab). A selected text is highlighted without touching the student's own selection; a selection in a terminal becomes the selection of the student's terminal. One way only: the instructor does not see the student's mouse. Nothing is sent of a private terminal of the instructor, nor of a place in a text the instructor reads with the instructor fragments shown (the *Instructor mode* button on the Informations, Questions and Apply Configuration tabs: the student's page has not got the same text). Unlike a presentation, the student keeps every control: they type in the terminals, change tab, open terminals, answer questions (and the instructor may write in the answers too, both pages showing the same text). The button's tooltip says whether the student's page follows. A reloaded instructor's page goes on focusing; closing it for a minute, closing the project, or turning the button off releases the student (their page stays where it is, grey again). Any instructor may end a focus; a student is in one focus at a time (the newest wins, an older one still running comes back when it ends).
- **Instructor mode** on the Open page: the instructor's own project started with `sre start --instructor-mode` (the instructor texts kept in `info.json`, every state listed, the states logged): the *Instructor mode* button of the project page then shows the `instructor()` texts of the Informations and Questions tabs, every state and the Log tab, as in the Qt GUI. A student's project holds no instructor text (the CLI strips them), so the button does not appear there. The Evaluation tab of the instructor's own project is the student's one, as in the Qt GUI: *Start evaluation* runs the self-evaluation (`sre --user eval --auto-eval`, the cooldown of the lab, the letters OK / MEH / FAIL when the lab hides the marks with `no_mark_on_self_grade`) and the table it gives stays; the last

archived evaluation is shown on somebody else's project only (an archive holds the numbers).

- **Debug mode** on the Open page: the third of the *Project mode* radios of the instructors (*Standard*, *Instructor mode*, *Debug mode*). The instructor's own project is started with `sre start --debug-web-project`: the debug project of `sre start --debug-project` (see *Lab Authoring*) with the lab given by its name, so that it keeps the lab name of the catalog and is grouped with the lab's other projects on the Watch and Archives pages. While *Debug mode* is chosen the lab tree lists every lab of the host, the exam-only and draft ones included (`GET /api/labs?all=1`, as the Exams page does; the selection is kept when the lab is still listed). The project page then shows what the Qt GUI shows for a debug project: every machine, the hidden ones in red, each with a Connect button, the *Full Schema* tab (the hidden machines drawn while the *Instructor mode* button is on), every state, the Log tab with the states and the evaluations, the evaluation table with both scopes, no self-evaluation cooldown. `POST /api/projects` takes `instructor_mode` or `debug_project` (both together is accepted); a student sending either gets 403. Presenting a debug project shows its hidden machines to the spectators, who see the presenter's page.
- **Groups** (the link in the header, `/groups`): the user groups of the site by kind (the departments, the groups of the directory, the custom groups), their members, and the editing of the custom groups (*User groups* above).
- **Exams** (the link in the header, `/exams`): the exams of the web site, programmed for an audience of logins and/or groups, followed and adjusted while they run (*Exams* above).
- **The host of a project**: the *Host* select of the Open page (shown when the pool has a host reserved for instructors, `instructors_only = true` in `[[hosts]]`) names one of them, with its state and its projects (greyed when off or full), or leaves the automatic placement: the least loaded host the instructor may use, reserved or shared. `POST /api/projects` takes the optional `host`; a student sending one gets 403.
- **Present**: the *Present* button of a project page (the instructor's own project, or a student's) opens the list of the users connected to the site (a text filter, the groups of every kind with the number of their members connected: the departments, the directory groups and the custom groups of the Groups page, *Select all*): the chosen students, one by one and by group (a group takes its members connected now and those connecting later), see the project read-only on their own browsers (above). The top of the page (the site bar, the project bar and the bar under it) then takes the presentation colour (lavender), a reminder that the students are watching, and that bar tells how many students are in the audience and how many are watching; *Edit audience* changes the list, *Stop presenting* ends it (so does closing the project) and the bars are grey again. The spectators follow the instructor's page: the tab, the terminals the instructor opens (joined read-only: the students see the same shell, cannot type, and do not change its size), the question, the schema options, the *Instructor mode* texts, the Display tab view-only, the scroll of the tab shown and the pan and zoom of the schema (followed as the instructor scrolls, a few times a second), the instructor's mouse pointer (an arrow with their name, sent on the presentation socket about 25 times a second while it moves over the panes, the tab bar or a terminal; nothing is shown while it is elsewhere) and the text the instructor selects (in the page, highlighted without touching the student's own selection; in a terminal, selected in the student's read-only terminal), and the Evaluation tab shows them the table of the instructor's page as it is, sent through the portal after each evaluation, in the instructor's language (the archive of the project holds numbers only, while the instructor's own self-evaluation may be letters). A reloaded page goes on presenting; a page closed for a minute ends the presentation. A student is in one presentation at a time (the newest that includes them), and falls back to the previous one when it ends.
- **Webconf**: the button of the site bar (when `[bbb]` of `web.toml` names a BigBlueButton server, *Web conference* above) opens the rooms: start one for chosen students and groups, join a colleague's as a moderator, change its audience, end it. The students put in a room get the client in a window over their page.
- **Talk privately**: on a student's project, next to *Focus student on project*: the student is invited to a

conversation of the two alone, voice and text (a banner, *Join* / *Not now*); once they join, both browsers show a private room instead of the class conference, and come back to it when the conversation ends (*Private conversations* above).

3.4.2 Administrators

An administrator is an instructor who may read the connection log on the **History** page (the link in the header, `/history`). Who is one is decided in `web.toml`, by login or by group, and a user who is not an instructor never gets the rights whatever the lists say:

- `[auth] administrators`: a list of logins, in every mode;
- in LDAP mode, `administrator_groups` of `[auth.ldap]` (DNs, tested like `instructor_groups`: the `memberOf` attribute, or the `group_filter` search) and `administrator_group_filter` (a group found under `group_search_base` naming the user, like `instructor_group_filter`; no default), run at login for the users the instructor tests accepted (the flag is kept in the session cookie, like the role);
- in proxy mode, `administrator_groups` of `[auth.proxy]` on the groups header and, with `ldap_roles` or `ldap_groups` (a directory is configured either way), the two `[auth.ldap]` tests above, run by the portal for the instructors nothing else made administrators (cached per login like the roles; the flag is lost while the directory is down, like the role of `ldap_roles`).

The History page needs `[access_log.database]` (*The connection log* above; without it the page says so) and has three views, chosen by the *Sessions* / *Events* / *Statistics* buttons of its toolbar.

The page opens on the **Sessions** view: the log as one row per session (*The connection log* above: one login from one client address, from its first request to the logout, the idle timeout or the shutdown): the sessions still open first, in green, from the portal's memory (listed even without a database), then the closed ones, newest first, each built from its `session_close` line: login, name, student group (the column is shown when a group source is configured, `attr_group` or `header_group`, like the Group column of the Watch page), address, start, end (the last request: an idle session ends there, not at its expiry), duration, number of requests, the labs of the projects used (the running lab names as a tooltip) and what closed it (*Logout*, *Idle*, *Shutdown*; *Still open* with the number of pages, terminals and desktops connected). A click on a header sorts the rows by that column, a second click reverses the order (the default is the end time, newest first, an open session counting as not ended yet, hence first); the sort applies to the rows shown, the page, not to the whole log: widen the page with *Rows* or narrow the filters. Only the login and address prefixes and the time window apply; the window bounds the time a session was **closed** (`session_timeout` after the last request for an idle one; an open session is listed when it was active in the window); the other filters are hidden. The *show* cell of a row opens the events view on that session: its login and address, from the minute of its start to the minute after its closing line. The sessions closed before the name, role and group were logged on the closing line show an empty name and group.

The **Events** view (`?view=events` in the URL) lists the events newest first, one row per event with its time (the local time of the browser), event, login, client address, host, project, lab, status, duration and the other fields of the line as `key=value`; a `denied` or `login_failed` line, a status of 400 or more and a failed start are red. The headers sort the rows shown the same way (the time, newest first, by default). The form filters by login and address (prefixes: `10.0.1.` is a subnet), event (every event name; in proxy mode without `login` and `login_failed`, which never occur there), host (exact), project and lab (substrings; the lab is only on the `start` lines) and a time window.

The **Statistics** view (`?view=statistics`) says who connected over a period and for how long. The period is the *From* / *To* window of the form: switching to the view with an empty *From* fills it with the time 24 hours ago, and an empty *To* is now (the default period is the last 24 hours; the login and address prefixes apply, an address prefix being a room). A session counts when it was active during the period and only its part inside the period is counted; the time of a user is the union of their sessions (two devices at once are not counted twice); the sessions still open count up to their last request, the administrator's own among them. A user whose role is not *instructor* is a student (the sessions closed before the role was logged on the closing line count as students). The page shows the **totals** (users, students, instructors, groups, sessions, client

addresses, the total connection time, the average, median and longest connection time of a student, the most users at once and when, the projects started, the projects used, the evaluations asked and the time spent on the project pages), the **groups** of the students (students, sessions, time, average, projects, evaluations; shown when a group source is configured, like the Group column; a click on a group lists the users of that group alone, a second click every user again), the **users** (name, group, role, sessions, connected time, time on the project pages, first and last request in the period, addresses, projects, evaluations, requests; sortable by the headers), the **labs** (one row per lab, every instance merged: projects, users, students, the time spent on the project pages and its average per user, the starts, the evaluations) and the **distribution** of the students' connection time (less than 15 minutes, 15 to 30, 30 to 60, 1 to 2 hours, 2 to 4, more). The time on a project page is that of its `project_close` lines (the page open as long as its events WebSocket was), clipped to the period and merged per user and lab; a page still open is not counted yet, and the pages of the spectators of a presentation never are; the starts are the `start` lines with `result=created`, the evaluations the `eval` lines answered 200; the requests, projects and evaluations of a session are those of the whole session. The portal reads the lines of those four events from the start of the period to two days after its end (a session or a page active in the period but closed later than that is missed), 200 000 of them at most: beyond, the page says the statistics are computed on the newest rows only and asks to narrow the period.

The **Group** select of the form (shown when a source of user groups is configured, *User groups* above: the departments, the directory groups and the custom groups, listed by kind as `GET /api/groups` gives them) restricts the three views to the members of one group, whatever its kind: the portal resolves the group into the logins of its current members and asks the database for their rows alone (one `IN` list on the indexed `login` column, so the sessions, the events or the statistics of a class group are one query; the open sessions are filtered the same way). A group nobody belongs to as far as the portal knows (a custom group emptied or deleted since, a department of nobody) gives nothing and the page says so. The department cell of a session filters on that department. The filter is kept in the URL as `group=kind:name` (a bare name is a department, like the Watch page's) and logged as `group_filter`; without any group source the parameter is refused (400).

In the two list views the filters stay in the URL (the sort of the headers does not), so a filtered view reloads and can be sent to a colleague; *Older* / *Newer* page through the rows (100, 500 or 1000 at a time, by a cursor on the row ids: a page is stable while new events arrive; each page is sorted on its own) and a click on a login, address or, in the events view, event, host or project cell filters on that value. Nothing is polled: *Search* asks again. Each query is a `history` line of the log itself, with the filters asked (`view=sessions` for the sessions, `view=statistics` and the period resolved for the statistics).

In proxy mode (the production site behind Apache) the page shows the same sessions: a session starts at the first request carrying the proxy's identity headers, right after the browser's password dialog (no `login` line: Apache authenticates, the portal only sees the result); the Logout button still closes it on the portal before the browser is sent to `logout_url`, where Apache's 401 makes it forget the Basic credentials; a tab closed without a logout ends it by the idle timeout like the other modes; the credentials the browser cached make a later return a new session without any dialog; the client address comes from `X-Forwarded-For` of the `trusted_proxies` peer (set in every mode: the proxy's address alone would merge the devices of a user); the authentications Apache refuses never reach the portal (its own log holds them).

3.4.3 The Display tab

A lab machine declared `x11_host` draws its graphical applications (Wireshark, Firefox…) on the X server of the host: on a workstation, the student's own desktop. A pool host has no X server, so the agent runs one virtual desktop per project whose lab has such a machine: a TigerVNC `Xvnc` with an `openbox` window manager, started as the unprivileged `sreweb-x11` user right after `sre start`, shown in the **Display** tab by noVNC (`make novnc`). The containers reach display `:N` on TCP port 6000+N of the host with the cookie of the project (the core passes them `SRE_DISPLAY` and `SRE_XAUTH_COOKIE`, the `.bashrc` of the images 1.31 sets `DISPLAY` from them); the browser reaches the RFB Unix socket of the server through the agent and the portal, as a WebSocket of binary frames. The desktop follows the size of the tab (*Resize the desktop*; *Fit to window* scales it instead), the text box of the bar sends text to the X clipboard and, on the owner's page only, shows what the applications copy (put into the browser's clipboard too; an instructor helping on

the project can send text but receives none: any X client of the containers can set the selection), *Reconnect* opens the stream again. The number and the cookie of a project never change: a desktop that died, or that was lost when the agent restarted (its X server is a child of the agent), is started again at the next use of the tab, empty. `[display]` of `agent.toml` holds the geometry, the range of display numbers and the commands. When no number of the range is free (every one taken by a project, by the lock file of another X server in `/tmp` or by a listener on its TCP port, which any local user can leave), a project still starts, without a desktop (no Display tab); the agent logs the reason once. Session recording (`asciinema`) applies as on a workstation, since it happens in `sre connect`.

- The answers are saved as the user types (debounced), with the identity of the session.

3.5 Security

- The agent refuses every request without its bearer token and the identity headers the portal adds (`X-SRE-Login`, `X-SRE-Fullname`, `X-SRE-Group`, …); the browser never talks to it. With mutual TLS (above) only the holder of a client certificate of the CA reaches the token check, the traffic to the agents is encrypted, and `allowed_clients` refuses every other address with 403. Without TLS the token and the terminals cross the network in clear: keep the agents on a trusted management network or behind a tunnel (the agent warns at startup).
- The session cookie is signed (HMAC-SHA256), `HttpOnly`, `SameSite=Strict`, `Secure` behind HTTPS; it lives 14 days from the sign-in (a language change sets it again with its original date: a session never slides) and carries the role, group and administrator flag of the sign-in (a change in the directory applies at the next sign-in: Logout, or the expiry); the state-changing calls need the `X-Requested-With: sre-web` header and the WebSockets a matching `Origin`; the pages carry a `Content-Security-Policy` (the origin of the BigBlueButton server added to its `frame-src` when `[bbb]` is set: the only other origin a page may frame).
- In proxy mode nothing is stored in a cookie: every request carries the identity set by the reverse proxy, accepted from the peers of `trusted_proxies` only (a request reaching the portal from anywhere else has no identity, headers or not).
- The directory is reached over TLS (`ldaps://`, or `start_tls` on `ldap://`) and the portal verifies the server certificate on every connection: the chain against the system CA store or `[auth.ldap] tls_ca`, the host of the `uri` against the names of the certificate; a StartTLS the server declines aborts the login, and a plain `ldap://` is refused at startup unless `allow_cleartext = true` (the student and instructor passwords, in LDAP mode, and the answers the roles and groups are built from would otherwise be exposed to anyone on the path). The `ldap3` library validates nothing by itself.
- One account is one user: in LDAP mode the identity carries the login as the directory stores it (the login attribute of the entry found, else the typed login lower-cased), not what the user typed, since the directory matches `Bob` for `bob` and binds either; the role tests naming the login (`memberUid`, which matches case-exactly) use that form too. In proxy mode the proxy must pass that form (`AuthLDAPRemoteUserAttribute` in the Apache example).
- Rate limits per user (evaluations, starts; per client address in anonymous mode, where a new pseudonym is free) and per client address (logins); the size of the answers is capped; the reports reading thousands of rows (the Statistics view, the summary of a lab on the Archives page) run two at a time, a third waits ten seconds for a slot then gets a 503 to retry. The sign-in page shows its own messages only (`/login?error=<code>`: `password`, `rate_limited`, `directory`), never a text taken from the URL.
- The `answers/` directory of a project is world-writable (the Qt GUI of the student writes there) and the agent, as root, merges the cheat answers `sre state` leaves in it (`answers/cheat.json`): that file is opened without following a symbolic link and read only when it is a regular file with one link, owned by root, `sre` or the reader, of at most `cheat_file_max_size` bytes (one million); anything else planted under that name is removed (the entry, never what a link points to) and logged once.

- The connection log (`[access_log]`) keeps who did what from where: the sessions with their duration and projects, the logins and their failures, the denied calls, the administration calls. The only header it reads is `X-Forwarded-For`, from the peers of `trusted_proxies`, for the client address; the identity never comes from it. With `[access_log.database]` the same lines are in a MariaDB / MySQL table, read on the History page by the administrators only (`[auth] administrators` and the administrator group tests: instructors, never students; every consultation is itself logged); the account of the portal needs `SELECT, INSERT, DELETE` on that table and nothing else.
- A project's owner is the third field of its running lab name; the portal, the agent and, in user mode, the `sre` CLI itself (`params.check_project_owner`: the local GUI of a pool host lists and reaches the same projects as the CLI lets through) check it. An instructor (see *Instructors* above) reaches every project, but the agent never runs a command as the student for them: a non-owner's `eval`, `state` and `connect` are privileged `sre` calls under the instructor's own login, the answers a non-owner writes go into the student's file with the student's metadata kept (the file never names the instructor), and a private terminal is listed to instructors only; a terminal an instructor opens on a device the student may not open themself (a closed machine or switch, a hidden machine) is private whatever the page asks, since a shared session is joined without the device check. The operations log of an instructor-mode project goes to the subscribers allowed to read it only.
- What the applications of a project's desktop copy (the X selection, which any X client of the containers can set) is received by the owner's browser only, where the Display tab puts it into the clipboard; the page of an instructor helping on the project does not listen to it. Likewise the hyperlinks a program prints in a terminal (OSC 8 sequences) open, after a confirmation naming the target, on the owner's page only; on an instructor's or a spectator's page they are inert, the target shown as a tooltip.
- The spectators of a presentation reach the presented project through the portal only, on a short list of read-only calls (the project, its events, the schema, the log, a terminal to *join*, the display; the evaluation table comes from the presenter's page through the portal, never from the agent), relayed to the agent under the presenter's identity (the agent trusts the portal for every identity anyway); everything else is refused, the portal never forwards what a spectator's browser sends on a terminal socket and the agent attaches a read-only client that cannot type nor resize, and the display socket of a spectator goes through a filter dropping the RFB input and resize messages (an unexpected message closes it). From the browsers, the presentation socket takes the pointer frames of the presenter's page only (a JSON object of at most 1 KiB locating the mouse, at most 60 a second, every other frame ignored; a spectator's frames are ignored); the pointer and the selection name nodes of the page and cells of a terminal, never a pixel, and a spectator's page resolves them on its own layout. The presentations live in the portal's memory.

The virtual desktops. Each `Xvnc` listens on TCP port 6000+N on every interface of the pool host, protected by the MIT cookie of its project only, exactly like the X server of a workstation configured for the labs (`installation.md`); an nftables rule such as `nft add rule inet filter input tcp dport 6010-6099 iifname != "docker0" drop` keeps the other hosts out. The RFB socket of a desktop is reachable by root only (the agent); the window manager runs as `sreweb-x11` with no menu, no launcher and no key binding running a program of the host; the browser reaches a desktop through the owner check of the portal and of the agent.

3.6 Limitations

- After an update of the tree, the portal and the agents must be restarted for the Python code (`sre-web-tool restart --all` for the agents, see *Restarting the agents* above; the templates are re-read when they change); the scripts and style sheets of `web/static` are served with `Cache-Control: no-cache`, so a browser revalidates them on every page load (an `ETag` answers 304 for an unchanged file) and never runs a script older than the page. A page loaded before the update keeps its scripts until it is reloaded.

- The virtual X desktops die with the agent (a restart of its unit): they are started again, empty, at the next use of the Display tab; the applications shown must be launched again.
- The preloads of the Docker images are counted per portal (two portals sharing hosts each give `max_preloads` turns), need the portal (an agent never preloads by itself), are asked at the start of an agent or by hand only (no periodic check: a cron job running `sre-web-tool preload --all` does it) and are not kept across a restart of an agent: a preload asked by hand and not started yet is forgotten, one in progress is stopped (`[preload] at_start` asks again). A host that cannot be polled while it preloads stops counting, so one more host may get a turn meanwhile.
- The `ports` of the bridged machines are bound on the pool host and shown with its name.
- The exam mode of the Qt GUI (`exam.json` on a host) still excludes that host from the pool: the web site has its own exams (*Exams* above), per student rather than per host. The save of the terminal sessions across a restart of the agent is a later phase.
- A terminal is lost when the agent restarts; its sub-tab offers a Reconnect button. A page that left keeps its terminals for `terminals_linger` only (120 minutes by default); where each one was (a sub-tab, a window) is remembered by the browser, another browser of the same user gets them back as sub-tabs.
- The replay a joining viewer gets may start inside an escape sequence; the next prompt or redraw of the application settles the display.
- The `[limits] eval_interval` of the portal (10 s between two evaluations of a login) also applies to an instructor evaluating several students' projects in a row.
- A presentation ends when the portal restarts (nothing is kept on disk); the agents log the spectators under the presenter's login (the connection log of the portal has the real ones); a spectator's terminal shows the presenter's grid at a smaller font when their window is smaller; the presenter's pointer and selection are shown where the student's page holds the same element: a student reading the lab in another language sees the pointer on the matching paragraph and no selection there; in a terminal they follow the text (the rows are counted from the cursor, a selection is found again by the text of its first and last rows), so a selection of rows older than the student's 64 KiB replay is not shown, the student's terminal does not follow the scrollback position of the presenter's (a pointer on rows the student's screen does not show is hidden), and when several users type in the presented terminal its pty takes the smallest window, so a wider presenter's terminal wraps the long lines elsewhere and the pointer and the selection on them may miss; the pointer is not shown while the presenter's page has no socket open; a presented project never idles out while it is watched. A focus ends when the portal restarts too; while one is on, the student's other browser tabs all go to the project.
- A web conference is forgotten when the portal restarts (the meeting goes on on the BigBlueButton server until it expires); every page of the site joins the meeting again (a few seconds); two tabs of one user hand the client over to each other, but two pages loading at the same instant may both join.

3.7 Development

`make web-tests` runs the offline tests of the web front-end: the agent against a fake `sre` (`tests/mock_sre.py`), the portal against that agent, the templates. `python3 -m sreweb.agent --config agent.toml --listen 127.0.0.1:8451` and `python3 -m sreweb.portal --config web.toml --listen 127.0.0.1:8450 --web-dir web` (from `src/`, in the venv) run both locally; with `sre_exe` pointed at a wrapper of `tests/mock_sre.py` (`SRE_PUB_DIR` exported in the wrapper), the whole site works without Docker. The French catalog is `locale/fr/LC_MESSAGES/sreweb.po` (hand-maintained, `make web-translations`).

The pure JavaScript modules (the lab tree of the Open page, the group keys, the exam form, the floating terminal windows) are tested under `node` or `bun`; on a machine with neither, `make tests` runs them under bun in a throwaway container of the `oven/bun` image instead (`SRE_TEST_JS=docker`, what the Makefile passes then: the image is pulled once, the tests skip without a reachable Docker daemon, root or the `docker`

group; SRE_TEST_JS=docker:<image> names another image, SRE_TEST_JS= leaves them skipped). Installing a runtime (apt install nodejs) is the lighter alternative.

3.8 Stress test

scripts/web-stress.py simulates a class of students on a portal through its HTTP / WebSocket API, as the browser drives it: for each student (logins stress001, stress002…), the Projects page (GET /api/projects every 5 s, the presence socket), the Open page (GET /api/labs), POST /api/projects read as NDJSON until the result line (a 503 or 429 is retried after its retry_after), the project page (the project JSON, the schema, the events socket kept open and reconnected with the browser's backoff, POST .../touch every 60 s), a terminal on the first device open to the student with a few commands typed (the echo of the first one is checked), then, over --hold seconds, --answers saves and --evals self-evaluations, and finally the stop. The students begin spread over --ramp seconds. --instructor adds an instructor on the Watch page (GET /api/watch, the Pool page's calls, every 5 s), --admin-token samples GET /api/pool every 5 s (the reachable flag and the project count of each host as the portal sees them), --probe measures GET /api/me every 2 s. The tool needs Python 3.11 and aiohttp only (the venv of the installation has them) and runs in **proxy authentication mode**: the identity of each student travels in the X-Remote-* headers, so it must run on a host of trusted_proxies (the portal's own host, against http://127.0.0.1:8450); the instructor is made by X-Remote-Gid: 2000 (--instructor-header / --instructor-value otherwise).

The summary on stdout gives, per phase (start, project_get, events_ws, terminal_ws, eval, stop…), the number of calls, the errors, the latencies (p50 / p95 / max) and the statuses, then the students completed, the checks failed (own_projects_only: a listing showed another student's project; project_listed: the new project was missing from GET /api/projects; terminal_echo; eval_grades; events_stayed_open; no_unexpected_removed; stopped), the hosts used and the pool samples (the flips of reachable show the status polls timing out). --report FILE writes everything as JSON (one entry per student), --events FILE a CSV timeline (one line per request or socket event). The exit status is 0 when every student completed with every check true. --keep leaves the projects running; --cleanup stops every project of the synthetic logins (through the instructor identity) and exits.

3.8.1 Stage 1: a fake pool, no Docker

scripts/web-fake-pool.py launches from the checkout N real agents whose sre is a wrapper of tests/mock_sre.py (the projects are directories, the terminals /bin/sh, a start takes 7 × --start-delay seconds, an evaluation --eval-delay), and a real portal in proxy mode trusting the loopback, with the production [limits] (--start-interval / --eval-interval override them), max_projects per host and an admin token; then it runs the command given after -- with SRE_STRESS_PORTAL, SRE_STRESS_ADMIN_TOKEN and SRE_STRESS_WORKDIR in its environment (the defaults of --portal and --admin-token) and stops everything. Every MOCK_* variable of its environment reaches the fake sre (MOCK_NO_MARK=1: the letters of a self-evaluation, MOCK_EVAL_ERRORS, MOCK_COOLDOWN, see the header of tests/mock_sre.py):

```
venv/bin/python3 scripts/web-fake-pool.py --hosts 4 --max-projects 25 -- \
    venv/bin/python3 scripts/web-stress.py --users 100 --ramp 60 --hold 120 --instructor␣
↪--probe \
        --report report.json --events events.csv
```

Without a command the pool stays up until Ctrl-C (portal=... admin_token=... workdir=... is printed first), for runs by hand. The work directory (configs, portal.log, access.log, one agent.log and sre.log per host) is removed at the end unless --keep-workdir or a daemon died; the end of the log of a daemon that died is printed with the failure. The agents listen on the ports after the portal's (--listen, 18450 by default): keep them below the ephemeral ports of the system (32768 on Linux), where a port may be held by a client connection, even for a minute after it closed. --administrators prof,... makes those logins administrators of the portal ([auth] administrators), so that an instructor among them (X-Remote-Gid: 2000) can exercise the History page; its Sessions view lists the open sessions without any database.

3.8.2 Stage 2: the production pool

On the portal's host, outside class hours, with the tool copied there (or `/opt/sre/scripts/` once synced) and the venv of the installation:

1. **Preflight.** The portal must see the tool as a trusted peer: from the host itself when the portal container uses the host network (`docker inspect sre-web --format '{{.HostConfig.NetworkMode}}'`), from inside the container otherwise (`docker exec`). Read the admin token in `[admin]` of `web.toml`. `sre-web-tool status` and `list`: the hosts up and the spare slots; with fewer slots than students, the pool wakes hosts during the ramp (`wake_timeout`, the students refused with 503 "a host is starting" retry after the `retry_after` of the answer, 30 s). Check `ulimit -n` of the portal process (two relayed sockets per student). Note the `archive_dirs` of the hosts: every evaluation writes an archive there.
2. **Smoke run:** `web-stress.py --portal http://127.0.0.1:8450 --users 3 --hold 60 --lab sre/dhcp.py --instructor --admin-token ... --probe` must give 3 students completed and no check failed.
3. **Full run:** the same with `--users 100 --ramp 300 --hold 600 --report ... --events ...`. Meanwhile: `docker stats sre-web` (the CPU of one event loop, the memory), the connection log (`event=start ... result=`, `denied`, hosts unreachable), `sre-web-tool list` (states, projects per host), the journal of an agent (`journalctl -u sre-agent -f`), the probe's p95 in the summary.
4. **Cleanup:** `web-stress.py --cleanup ...` stops what a stopped run left (a Ctrl-C stops the students' projects by itself), then remove the archives of the synthetic logins (`*@@@stress0*` under `archive_dirs` on the hosts) and check `sre-web-tool list` is back to 0 projects.

The reverse proxy and the directory are bypassed (the tool speaks to the portal), and `follow_local_sessions` never applies (the synthetic logins have no local session).

CHAPTER

FOUR

LAB AUTHORING GUIDE

A lab is a Python module that defines three classes: `Data`, `NetScheme`, and `Grade`, each inheriting from the corresponding `*0` base class in `lib_sre.py`. An optional `Flavor` class can be defined to parameterize the lab at start time.

A lab is usually a single `.py` file.

Directory labs

SRE also supports **directory labs** — a subdirectory containing a `srelab.py` plus per-state file trees (`initial/`, `state1/`, …) that are copied into the containers at the matching state transition. This is the Kathara layout, but in practice it's rarely needed: most setup is better expressed in code, since `Data`-derived values (random IPs, secrets, etc.) can then be injected into the generated files. The directory form is mainly useful when you need to ship payload that can't reasonably be generated at runtime — a pre-built apt package, a large data file, or anything else you don't want to download from the Internet on every lab start.

```
/opt/sre/lab/s4/tp_ssh/
+-- srelab.py          ← the module
+-- initial/           ← files injected at startup
|   +-- router/        ← files for the machine named "router"
|   |   +-- etc/network/interfaces
|   +-- all/           ← files copied to every machine
|       +-- etc/motd
+-- state1/            ← files injected when "sre state <lab> state1" is called
    +-- router/
        +-- etc/...
```

4.1 The authoring workflow on the CLI

While iterating on a `srelab.py`, you typically alternate between editing the module and exercising it with a handful of `sre` subcommands. Full reference lives in *CLI reference*; this section just names the commands you'll reach for as an author and explains the one option that exists for authors only.

4.1.1 `sre check [-p] <lab> [<state>]`

Static validation, no containers deployed. Imports the module, runs `Data.compute_pre_generate()` → `Data.generate()` → `data.compute_post_generate()`, checks that the `Data` instance survives the `data.json` round trip (`to_json()` / `from_json()`, `pack()` / `unpack()`, as `sre start` and `sre eval` do), instantiates `NetScheme`, applies `initial()` (op registration only), then calls `Grade.grade()` once. Catches import errors, missing fields, bad topology, and exceptions raised at registration time. With a trailing `<state>` argument, the named `@sre_state` method is also exercised. Run this first after every non-trivial edit — it's

much faster than starting a real lab. The numbered sections of `informations` are resolved and printed as an outline, and the `@@ref@@` references of the question texts are checked (see *Numbered sections*).

4.1.2 `sre start --debug-project [-p] <lab> [--xauth-file <path>]`

The author counterpart to `sre start`. Privileged only and incompatible with `--user`. Deploys the lab exactly like a normal start, then drops a `.private/debug_project` marker that the rest of the runtime keys on. Effect:

- **Topology**: every machine is shown in the GUI's *Machines* tab — even those declared `hidden=True` or `allow_connection=False`. *Connect* buttons are exposed for all of them so you can step inside infrastructure machines (DNS, monitors, helpers) to inspect their state. A *Full Schema* tab, right after *Schema*, draws the topology with the hidden machines too: they, their links and the networks only they use are in red (the *Schema* tab stays the student's view).
- **Restrictions lifted**: user-mode guards on `sre state` and `sre connect` (which normally refuse to touch hidden machines or apply `user_allowed=False` states) are bypassed.
- **Grading**: when you `sre eval` a debug project, marks are always shown and every grade scope is surfaced — `no_mark_on_self_grade`, `hide_potential_penalty_grades_in_self_grade` and the periodic-eval gating are all ignored.
- **Operations log**: every state application (`initial` at start, `sre state`, the `save`/`restore` lifecycle states) and every evaluation appends what it executed to `<project dir>/operations.log`: one header per run, then `stepN - on <machine|host> : <operation>` lines with the command output and exit code. File writes, appends and copies show the path, mode, owner and size, followed by the content written (text only, capped like command outputs). Each evaluation ends with its grade elements (`grade - [<part>] <title> : <grade> / <max>`, with `(self-eval only)` / `(exo-eval only)` when the scope is restricted) and the totals and marks of both scopes. The GUI shows it live in the *Log* tab. Never written for a normal project.
- **Instructor texts**: the texts wrapped in *`instructor()`* are kept in `info.json`, as for a project in instructor mode, and the GUI shows its *Instructor mode* button on the project to display or hide them.
- **`-p` is implicit**: `--debug-project` always treats the lab argument as a filesystem path, so you can point it directly at the `.py` you're editing (e.g. `~/labs/draft.py`) without copying it into `/opt/sre/lab/` first.
- **`--debug-web-project`** is the name form: the same debug project with the lab given by its name as for a normal start (`sre start --debug-web-project sre/dhcp.py`; the exam-only and draft labs of `sre list --include-exam-only` accepted), so that the project keeps the lab name of the catalog (`sre@dhcp.py`, not `@opt@sre@lab@sre@dhcp.py`) and is grouped with the lab's other projects by the reports and the web site. It is what the *Debug mode* of the web site's Open page runs. The two options and `-p` are mutually exclusive; `--instructor-mode` combines with either.

The marker survives container restarts and is cleared when the project is `sre stop`ped or `sre wipe`d.

`--xauth-file <path>` is the other authoring-time option on `sre start`. By default, machines marked `x11_host=True` pick up the host's X magic cookie from the `SRE_XAUTH_COOKIE` environment variable (the sre-wrapper sets this for the GUI flow). When you start a project by hand from a shell where that variable isn't set — typical for `--debug-project` — pass `--xauth-file ~/.Xauthority` to source the cookie from a file instead. Privileged only.

4.1.3 `sre connect <running_lab> <device>` and `sre exec <running_lab> <device> <command…>`

`sre connect` opens an interactive shell inside `<device>` (using the machine's configured `shell`), or the management console when `<device>` is a managed switch (a network with `'mode': 'managed'`, see *Switches and*

VLANs). `sre exec` runs a one-shot command and returns its stdout/stderr/exit code — useful for scripting checks against a running lab without holding a TTY. On a managed switch `sre exec <running_lab> <network> <command…>` runs one console command (`vlan/print`, `port/setvlan @pc1 10`). `sre exec` is privileged only; both honor the debug-project marker, so they can target hidden machines when the project was started with `--debug-project`.

`sre connect --exec <argument…>` is a hybrid: launches the machine's shell, runs the command, exits. Unlike `sre exec` it goes through the shell launcher and is available to students.

4.1.4 `sre state <running_lab> <state_name>`

Applies a non-`initial` `@sre_state` method against the live containers. The main use case during authoring is exercising the instructor's "fully-configured" state (often called `final`) so you can run `sre eval` against a known-good configuration and verify the grading code reports the expected full marks. In a non-debug project, students can only apply states declared with `@sre_state(user_allowed=True)` *and* only when the module sets `allow_user_states = True` — `--debug-project` lifts both guards.

4.1.5 `sre eval <running_lab>`

Runs an evaluation against the live containers — equivalent to pressing the *Start evaluation* button in the GUI. The evaluation also refreshes the project's view of the lab module, so any edits to `informations`, questions, or grade rubric take effect on the next display without needing to restart the lab.

4.1.6 `sre wipe`

Privileged only (the user-mode form is `sre stop-all`, the caller's own projects): stops every running Kathara lab and removes everything under `/var/lib/sre/projects/`. The reset button between iterations: when a lab is misbehaving and `sre stop <running_lab>` isn't enough (orphaned bridges, broken Kathara state, leftover marker files), `sre wipe` brings the host back to a clean slate. It does **not** touch `exam.json` or archive directories.

A typical edit-test cycle:

```
sre check -p ~/labs/draft.py final            # validate module + the 'final' state
sre start --debug-project -p ~/labs/draft.py  # deploy, with debug visibility
sre connect <running_lab> router              # poke around
sre state <running_lab> final                 # apply the instructor's known-good state
sre eval <running_lab>                        # confirm grade == max
sre wipe                                       # reset before the next edit
```

4.2 Identifying a running lab and where its files live

Every running project lives in its own subdirectory of `/var/lib/sre/projects/`. The directory name encodes the launch timestamp, the lab name, and the student username:

```
/var/lib/sre/projects/{YYYYmmddHHMMSS}@@@{lab_name}@@@{username}/
```

e.g. `20260606143215@@@s4@ssh@@@alice`. List the directory to see what's currently running:

```
ls /var/lib/sre/projects/
```

Partial names are accepted. Every subcommand that takes a `<running_lab>` argument resolves it by substring match against the directory listing — you only need to type enough of the name to uniquely identify one project. If your substring matches several running labs, `sre` prints the candidates and exits

so you can disambiguate; if it matches none, you get `no running lab matches '...'`. In practice the lab name itself (or even a fragment of it) is usually enough:

```
sre connect ssh router        # works if only one ssh project is running
sre connect 20260606 router      # disambiguate by timestamp prefix
sre connect alice router      # disambiguate by username
```

Inside the project directory you'll find:

Path (relative to the project dir)	Contents
`info.json`	Public metadata read by the GUI: lab title, `informations`, machine list, question list. Written at `sre start` and refreshed on `sre eval`.
`answers/answers.json`	Student answers to `question_text` / `question_form` blocks.
`answers/cheat.json`	Optional instructor-provided cheat answers keyed by state name (used by `cheat_answers=`).
`shared/`	Bind-mounted into every container as `/home/sre/{running_lab_name}/` when the module sets `shared_path = True`. The host-side path for file exchange.
`.private/`	Mode `0o700`. Holds everything the runtime needs but students shouldn't touch.
`.private/data.json`	The serialized `Data` instance, reloaded on every later operation.
`.private/srelab`	Symlink to the lab's `.py` file (whatever `sre start` was pointed at).
`.private/files/`	Target of `self.cp_from_host()` / `self.cp_to_host()` — also where `cp_from_host` resolves relative source paths.
`.private/records/`	Asciinema recordings of terminal sessions, if `record_sessions` is enabled.
`.private/eval_in_progres`	PID lock created during `sre eval` to prevent concurrent evaluations.
`.private/debug_project`	Marker dropped by `sre start --debug-project` (see above).
`.private/instructor_mode`	Marker of the instructor mode (`sre start --instructor-mode`, `sre set-instructor-mode`; see *Instructor-only texts*).
`.private/auto_eval.log`	One line per student-triggered self-eval; drives the `self.auto_eval_count` counter exposed to `Grade.grade()`.

Evaluation archives are **not** stored under the project directory — they go to `/var/lib/sre/archives/` (plus any extra `archive_dirs` declared at module level), named `{YYYYmmddHHMMSS}_{running_lab_name}.zst`.

4.3 The four classes at a glance

A lab module defines up to four classes, each with a narrow role:

- `Data` — a `@dataclass` that holds every per-instance parameter of the lab (IP addresses, secrets, ports, randomized values). `Data.generate()` is called once at `sre start`; the resulting instance is serialized to `.private/data.json` and reloaded on every later operation.
- `Flavor` *(optional)* — a `@dataclass` that lets a single `srelab.py` produce different variants of the lab at start time (e.g. random vs. fixed addresses, easy vs. hard). The GUI renders `flavor_form` as a form; the chosen `Flavor` is then passed to `Data.generate(flavor)`.
- `NetScheme` — declares the network topology (`_machine_specs`, `_network_specs`, `_topology`) and the imperative configuration of each *state*. The `initial` state runs at `sre start`; additional `@sre_state`

methods can be applied later with `sre state <lab> <name>`.

- **`Grade`** — registers what to evaluate and how to score it. It does **not** run anything itself: SRE drives a multi-step `run_tests()` loop that calls `Grade.grade()` repeatedly, executing the commands registered by each call between passes. See *The grading lifecycle*.

The flow at `sre start` is: `Data.generate(flavor)` → `NetScheme(data).initial()` (which lays out interfaces and writes files). The flow at `sre eval` is: reload `data.json` into a fresh `Data`, rebuild `NetScheme`, then run `Grade.run_tests()` against the live containers.

4.4 `Data` class

`Data` is a `dataclass` that holds all lab-specific parameters (IP addresses, random secrets, etc.). It inherits from `Data0`.

```
from dataclasses import dataclass
from ipaddress import IPv4Interface
from SRE.lib_sre import Data0
from ips import random_ipv4networks, random_ipv4s

@dataclass(slots=True)
class Data(Data0):
    secret: str = ''
    vlan_id: int = 0

    @classmethod
    def generate(cls, flavor=None):
        data = cls(secret="changeme", vlan_id=42)
        # data.nets and data.ips are injected automatically by Data0.__post_init__
        data.nets.lan, data.nets.mgmt = random_ipv4networks([24, 24],␣
↪from_private_network=True)
        data.ips.router = random_ipv4s(data.nets.lan, 1)[0]    # an IPv4Interface, prefix␣
↪included
        data.ips.printer = IPv4Interface('192.0.2.7/24')        # explicit values work␣
↪too
        return data
```

Key points:

- `data.ips` holds `IPv4Interface` values (address + prefix length); `data.nets` holds `IPv4Network` values; `data.ips6` holds `IPv6Interface` values; `data.nets6` holds `IPv6Network` values; `data.macs` holds `netaddr.EUI` (MAC address) values.
- All five containers are injected automatically into every `Data0` subclass instance by `__post_init__` — no declaration needed (and do not declare fields with these names).
- The containers enforce their types: assigning a plain string to `data.ips` raises `TypeError`; always wrap with the correct type before assigning. The families are kept apart: `data.ips` refuses an `IPv6Interface` and `data.ips6` an `IPv4Interface`.
- `data.ips` requires `IPv4Interface` (not bare `IPv4Address`) — always assign with a prefix, e.g. `IPv4Interface('10.0.0.1/24')`; likewise `data.ips6` requires `IPv6Interface`, e.g. `IPv6Interface('2001:db8::1/64')`.
- `Data.generate(flavor)` is called once at `sre start`; the result is saved to `data.json`.

- Serialization: the containers are stored as strings; standalone fields of type `IPv4Address` / `IPv6Address`, `IPv4Interface` / `IPv6Interface`, `IPv4Network` / `IPv6Network`, `EUI` and nested `Data0` subclasses are encoded with markers and restored with their exact type. Any other field must be JSON-serialisable (`sre check` verifies the round trip).

4.4.1 IP helper functions (from `/opt/sre/lib/ips.py`)

```
from ipaddress import IPv6Network
from ips import (random_ipv4networks, random_ipv4s, random_ipv6networks, random_ipv6s,
                 random_ips_from_topology)

# n disjoint IPv4 networks with the given prefix lengths (RFC 1918 ranges with␣
↪from_private_network=True):
nets = random_ipv4networks([24, 28, 24], from_private_network=True)
# n distinct random IPv4Interface values (prefix included) in a network;
# the network and broadcast addresses are never returned:
data.ips.host, data.ips.gw = random_ipv4s(nets[0], 2, exclude_nets=[nets[1]])

# IPv6 twins - search space: global unicast 2000::/3 by default, unique local fd00::/8␣
↪with
# from_private_network=True, or anything with from_network=IPv6Network('2001:db8::/32'):
data.nets6.lan, data.nets6.wan = random_ipv6networks([64, 64], from_private_network=True)
# n distinct IPv6Interface values; offset 0 (the subnet-router anycast address) is never␣
↪returned:
data.ips6.host, data.ips6.gw = random_ipv6s(data.nets6.lan, 2)

# Fill data.ips (and data.ips6 with ipv6=True) for every machine of a topology from
# data.nets / data.nets6 - data.ips.m for single-homed machines, data.ips.m_net␣
↪otherwise:
random_ips_from_topology(data, NetScheme._topology, ipv6=True)   # ipv4=False,␣
↪ipv6=True: IPv6-only lab
```

`random_ipv4s_with_range` / `random_ipv6s_with_range` draw ordered address ranges (for DHCP pools), `random_mac_address` random unicast MAC addresses.

4.4.2 IPv6 labs

Kathara starts every container with IPv6 **disabled** (`net.ipv6.conf.all.disable_ipv6=1`). A lab turns it on with the module-level option:

```
ipv6 = True   # IPv6 enabled in every machine of the lab
```

`Machine(ipv6=False)` (an `'ipv6': False` entry in `_machine_specs`) opts one machine out, `Machine(ipv6=True)` opts one in when the module option is absent. With IPv6 enabled Kathara sets `disable_ipv6=0`, `net.ipv6.conf.all.forwarding=1` and `accept_ra=0` in the container (every interface gets its link-local address), so, as for IPv4 (`set_ip_forward`), the `initial` state turns forwarding off on the hosts with `set_ipv6_forward(self, m, False)`. `sre export` writes the effective flag as `m[ipv6]="true"` in `lab.conf`.

A dual-stack lab keeps both families in the same `net_config` entry, IPv4 first:

```
from ipaddress import IPv4Network, IPv6Network
from net_config import get_net_config_from_topology, set_net_config_entry,␣
↪set_ip_forward, set_ipv6_forward
```

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```
# by hand:
self.net_config = {
    'pc': [([d.ips.pc, d.ips6.pc], [(IPv4Network('0.0.0.0/0'), d.ips.gw), (IPv6Network(
↪'::/0'), d.ips6.gw)])],
}
# or from the topology (data.ips6 / data.nets6 follow the data.ips / data.nets naming; a␣
↪machine
# without an entry in data.ips6 - a SLAAC or IPv4-only host - simply gets no IPv6 part):
self.net_config = get_net_config_from_topology(self, gateway='gw', ipv6=True)   #␣
↪default_route6=... for a ::/0 on gw;
# default_route (172.17.0.1, the Docker bridge, for a bridged=True gateway) /␣
↪default_route=None: no 0.0.0.0/0 on gw

# in initial(): set_net_config_entry() emits `ip addr add` / `ip route add` for both␣
↪families
set_net_config_entry(self, 'pc', self.net_config['pc'])
set_ipv6_forward(self, 'pc', False)
```

Readers take `ipv6=True` to *also* return the IPv6 side (link-local and temporary addresses are left out): `get_ip_addresses`, `get_routes` (adds `ip -6 route`, `default` → `('::', 0)`), `get_net_config_entry`, `get_persistent_net_config_entry` (parses `iface ethN inet6 static` stanzas); `set_persistent_net_config_entry` writes one `inet` and one `inet6` stanza per interface; `eval_net_config` compares both families (`net_config_entry_family(entry, 6)` grades one family apart); `eval_ping(self, 'pc', 'srv', ipv6=True)` pings the IPv6 address of a machine named in `net_config` (an IPv6 literal needs no flag); `create_hosts_file(..., ipv6=True)` adds the IPv6 lines; `setup_simple_tcp_server(.. ., ipv6=True)` listens on `::`.

Router advertisements / SLAAC: on the router `set_radvd(self, 'gw', {2: [d.nets6.lan]})` writes `/etc/radvd.conf` and starts radvd; on the hosts `set_slaac_client(self, 'pc')` sets `accept_ra=2` and `autoconf=1` (a forwarding host ignores RAs otherwise). Grade with `get_ip_addresses(self, 'pc', ipv6=True)` (the SLAAC address is in `d.nets6.lan`) and `get_routes(self, 'pc', ipv6=True)[('::', 0)]` (next hop `fe80::…`). The Docker bridge has no IPv6 unless the daemon is configured for it: no IPv6 reaches the outside through `bridged=True` machines, and `set_nat_gateway` stays IPv4. See `lab/sre/_DRAFT_dummy/ipv6_example.py` for a complete dual-stack lab.

4.4.3 `compute_pre_generate` and `compute_post_generate`

Two optional lifecycle hooks let a `Data` subclass derive auxiliary values without storing them in `data.json`. Override either as needed; the defaults are no-ops.

Hook	Signature	Receive	Purpose
`compute_pr`	`@classmethod def compute_pre_generate(cls, flavor=None)`	class	Set **class-level** attributes derived from `flavor` (machine lists, topology sizes, role tables, etc.) before any `Data` instance exists.
`compute_po`	`def compute_post_generate(sel`	instanc	Set **instance-level** attributes derived from the dataclass fields after generation or reload.

When they run:

1. At `sre start`: `Data.compute_pre_generate(flavor)` → `Data.generate(flavor)` → `data.compute_post_generate()`.

2. At `sre eval`, `sre state`, `sre connect`, etc.: after `data.json` is reloaded into a fresh `Data` instance via `from_json` / `from_dict` / `unpack`, both hooks run again — pre-generate first (with the persisted `flavor`), then post-generate.
3. `sre check` exercises the same sequence as a sanity check.

Because the hooks run on every reload, they should be **deterministic and side-effect-free**: no random number generation, no IP allocation, no file I/O. Anything that must be randomized once and then persisted belongs in `generate()`.

Typical use case — derive the machine list and per-machine spec from a `Flavor`:

```
@dataclass(slots=True)
class Data(Data0):
    secret: str = ''

    @classmethod
    def compute_pre_generate(cls, flavor=None):
        if flavor is None:
            flavor = Flavor()
        match flavor.network_size:
            case "small":
                r_max, m_max = 2, 2
            case "medium":
                r_max, m_max = 3, 4
            case _:
                r_max, m_max = 4, 7
        cls.routers = [f"r{i}" for i in range(1, r_max + 1)]
        cls.non_routers = [f"m{i}" for i in range(0, m_max + 1)]
        cls.machine_specs = {'gw': {'bridged': True}}

    @classmethod
    def generate(cls, flavor=None):
        data = cls(secret=random_password(16))
        # cls.routers / cls.non_routers are already populated by compute_pre_generate
        data.nets.lan = random_ipv4networks([24], from_private_network=True)[0]
        return data
```

`NetScheme.build()` and `Grade.grade()` can then read `self.data.routers` / `self.data.non_routers` directly, even on reload, without those fields needing to live in `data.json`.

4.5 `Flavor` class

A `Flavor` is an optional dataclass that parameterizes a lab at start time. If defined, the GUI presents a form to the student before starting.

A typical use case — see `lab/sre/static_routing.py` — is to switch a lab between two modes: when students work on it autonomously or during an exam, randomized IP addresses are preferable so each student has their own topology; in a supervised classroom, the instructor may want every student to share the same values, so a single explanation at the board applies to everyone. A `Flavor` lets the lab expose both modes from the same `srelab.py` and pick one at start time.

```
from dataclasses import dataclass
from typing import Tuple
from SRE.lib_sre import Flavor0
```

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```
@dataclass(slots=True)
class Flavor(Flavor0):
    nb: int = 0

    flavor_form = """
    Number of clients: @@{nb:[0-9]+}@@
    Mode: @@{mode:>easy|hard}@@
    """

    def allowed_by_user(self) -> Tuple[bool, str]:
        """Return (True, '') if the student is allowed this flavor."""
        if self.nb <= 5:
            return True, ""
        return False, "Maximum 5 clients allowed."

# Named presets (accessible as Flavor.easy, Flavor.hard, etc.)
Flavor.easy = Flavor(nb=1)
Flavor.hard = Flavor(nb=5)
```

The form takes the same fields as `question_form()` (single-line text with a regex, multi-line text, dropdown, checkbox: the `@@{field:spec}@@` grammar is described in *Questions*), plus `@@{name::Label}@@`, a button that submits the form: the lab gets the pressed button as a true attribute of the `Flavor` and the other buttons as false. The dialog adds a *Submit* button when the form declares none, and refuses to submit while a text field does not match its regex.

Module-level control:

```
flavor_form_at_startup = True   # show the flavor form when the student opens the lab
```

`Flavor` API:

Method	Description
`to_dict()` / `from_dict(d)`	Serialize/deserialize field values
`from_form_dict(d`	Build a `Flavor` from form field strings, coercing to declared types (`int`, `bool`, `float`, `str`). Extra keys are set as plain attributes.
`allowed_by_user(`	Returns `(bool, message)`. Override to restrict what students can choose.

In `Data.generate(flavor)`, check `if flavor is not None` before using flavor fields.

4.6 `NetScheme` class

`NetScheme` declares the lab's network topology and exposes the imperative API used by every state method. Topology is declared at class level via three dicts; per-state actions live in methods decorated with `@sre_state` (covered in the next section).

```
from SRE.lib_sre import NetScheme0, sre_state, make_tr

tr = make_tr('en')
```

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```
class NetScheme(NetScheme0):
    # Declare machines: keys are machine names, values are Machine kwargs.
    # A name follows Kathara's device-name rule: 1 to 30 characters among a-z, 0-9 and _
    # (lowercase only; `mX` or `pc-1` are refused by `Machine()`, so `sre check` reports them)
    _machine_specs = {
        'router':  {'color': 'green'},
        'client':  {},
        'hidden':  {'hidden': True, 'allow_connection': False},
    }

    # Declare network options: display hints, type of switch (hub by default)
    _network_specs = {
        'lan':  {'color': 'yellow'},
        'mgmt': {'color': 'gray'},
    }

    # Declare topology: net_name → list of machines (or dict with explicit interface numbers)
    _topology = {
        'lan':  ['router', 'client'],          # auto interface numbering
        'mgmt': {'router': 0, 'hidden': 1},    # explicit interface numbers
    }

    def __init__(self, data, running_lab_name):
        super().__init__(data=data, running_lab_name=running_lab_name)

        # Markdown text for the Informations tab (supports make_tr for i18n); see
        # "Numbered sections, references and table of contents" for the numbering helpers
        self.informations = tr(
            "## Lab description\nConfigure routing.",
            fr="## Description\nConfigurez le routage.",
        )
```

4.6.1 Declarations and accessors

Attribute / Method	Description
`_machine_specs`	Class-level dict: `{name: {Machine kwargs}}`
`_network_specs`	Class-level dict: `{net_name: {Network kwargs}}` — display hints and type of switch, see *Network parameters*
`_topology`	Class-level dict: `{net_name: [machine,...]}` or `{net_name: {machine: iface_index}}`
`self.data`	The `Data` instance
`self.informations`	Markdown text (or `TranslatedText`) for the Informations tab
`self.get_machines()`	Iterator over all `Machine` objects
`self.get_machine_names()`	Iterator over machine name strings
`self.get_networks()`	Iterator over all `Network` objects

4.6.2 `Machine` constructor parameters

Parameter	Default	Description
`image`	`params.default_`	Docker image
`bridg`	`False`	Enable host-network bridging (required for `ports`)
`x11_h`	`False`	Forward X11 to the host: inject `SRE_HOST_IP` (and the host's X magic cookie as `SRE_XAUTH_COOKIE`) so GUI apps launched in the container display on the host's X server (`DISPLAY` is set by the `.bashrc` of the images; needs `bridged=True` to reach the host). On the web site the apps show in the Display tab, a virtual desktop of the project (`SRE_DISPLAY`)
`hidde`	`False`	Hidden from the Machines tab
`allow`	`True`	Show *Connect* button in the GUI
`shell`	`None`	Shell launched by `sre connect` (interactive terminal session)
`katha`	`None`	Shell Kathara uses to execute startup `exec_commands` inside the container
`privi`	`None`	Run the container in privileged mode. Refused at startup unless `params.allow_privileged_machines = True`
`ipv6`	`None`	Enable IPv6 in the container. `None`: the module-level `ipv6` option decides (Kathara's own setting, off, when that one is absent too); `True` / `False`: per-machine override. See *IPv6 labs*
`color`	`None`	Node color in the SVG diagram
`exec_`	`[]`	Commands run at container start
`sysct`	`{}`	Kernel parameters, as an iterable of `"net.<key>=<value>"` strings (a dict is iterated over its keys, so `{"net.ipv6.conf.all.accept_ra=2": True}` works; a `{name: value}` dict is rejected by Kathara). Merged after Kathara's defaults, so they win
`envs`	`{}`	Environment variables
`ports`	`[]`	Port mappings, e.g. `["80XX:80/tcp"]` (X = wildcard digit)
`ulimi`	`{}`	ulimit settings
`volum`	`{}`	Volume mounts

Port wildcards: `"80XX:80/tcp"` allocates the first free port in 8000–8099.

4.6.3 `Network` parameters

Each `_network_specs` entry gives the keyword arguments of one network; a network that only appears in `_topology` takes the defaults.

Parameter	Default	Description
`color`	`None`	Node color in the schema
`shape`	`None`	Node shape in the schema
`mode`	`'hub'`	Type of switch the machines are plugged into: `'hub'` (every frame reaches every machine), `'switch'` (the switch learns the MAC addresses: a machine only receives its own traffic and the broadcasts) or `'managed'` (a switch with VLANs and a management console). See *Switches and VLANs*
`allow_`	`True`	Managed switch only: students may open its console (*Connect* button of the **Networks** tab, `sre connect`)
`vlans`	`{}`	Managed switch only: VLANs of the ports, by machine

4.6.4 Switches and VLANs

By default the machines of a network share a hub, as in every lab written before the switch types existed. `'mode': 'switch'` and `'mode': 'managed'` change that per network — the whole feature (the Networks tab, the console and its commands, states, grading, limits) is described in *Hubs, switches and VLANs*:

```
_network_specs = {
    'lan': {'mode': 'managed', 'allow_connection': False,
            'vlans': {'pc1': 10,                              # access port: untagged␣
↪frames in VLAN 10
                      'pc2': 20,
                      'r1': [10, 20],                         # trunk port: VLANs 10 and␣
↪20, tagged
                      'r2': {'vlan': 1, 'trunk': [30]}}},     # native VLAN 1 + VLAN 30␣
↪tagged
    'dmz': {'mode': 'switch'},
}
_topology = {'lan': ['pc1', 'pc2', 'r1', 'r2'], 'dmz': ['r1', 'srv'], 'old': ['srv', 'pc2
↪']}   # 'old' is a hub
```

- VLAN IDs go from 1 to 4094. A machine that `vlans` does not name stays in the default VLAN of the switch (VLAN 0, untagged) with every other undeclared port; a trunk port without `vlan` keeps that default VLAN for its untagged frames.
- On a trunk port the machine handles the tags itself, e.g. `ip link add link eth0 name eth0.10 type vlan id 10`.
- A switch that is not a hub drops the 802.1Q frames of a VLAN the port is not a member of: a trunk between two machines needs a hub or a managed switch with trunk ports, not a plain `'switch'`.
- An unknown `mode`, `vlans` on a network that is not managed, a machine that is not on the network or an invalid VLAN ID raise `ValueError` when the `NetScheme` is built, so `sre check` reports them.
- A managed switch has a management console: `sre connect <running_lab> <network>`, the *Connect* button of the **Networks** tab, a terminal in the **Terminals** tab. In user mode only the commands of `params.switch_user_commands` reach the switch, and `'allow_connection': False` closes the console to students.
- A state runs console commands with `self.switch_cmd(network, command, ...)`, where `@machine` stands for the port of a machine (see *Switch operations*); `grade()` reads the switch with `self.test_switch(network, command)` and `get_switch_ports()` (see *Switch helpers* in the Grading Library Reference).
- A save file and `sre export` keep the type of each switch and the declared VLANs, not what was changed on a console afterwards. A mode other than `hub` needs the VDE network plugin of the Kathara fork, installed by `make network-plugin` (see *Installation*).

See `lab/sre/_DRAFT_dummy/switch_example.py` for a complete lab: the three types of network, access and trunk ports with a router on a stick, an open and a closed console, two states built on `switch_cmd()` and a grade reading the switch.

4.6.5 Instructor-only texts — `instructor()`

`instructor(text, color=None, background=None)` marks a text as meant for the instructor: notes, hints, the solution. It takes a plain string or a `tr()` text and combines with `+` like any other text:

```
from SRE.lib_sre import NetScheme0, Grade0, instructor, make_tr
```

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```
class NetScheme(NetScheme0):
    def __init__(self, data, running_lab_name):
        super().__init__(data=data, running_lab_name=running_lab_name)
        self.informations = instructor(tr("""
            ### Solution
            - add the default route on `client`;
            - the `final` state does it.
            """, fr="""
            ### Corrigé
            - ajouter la route par défaut sur `client` ;
            - l'état `final` le fait.
            """)) + tr("Configure the routing.", fr="Configurez le routage.")

class Grade(Grade0):
    def grade(self):
        super().grade()
        self.question_text(
            title=tr("Gateway") + instructor(" (10.0.0.1)"),
            description=tr("Which gateway does the client use?")
                        + instructor(tr("\n\nAny notation is accepted."), color="#1a4fa0
↪", background="#e3edff"))
```

- In a normal project the function ignores its argument: it returns an empty text, and nothing of it is written to `info.json` (which students can read).
- In a project in **instructor mode** (`sre start --instructor-mode <lab>`, `sre restore --instructor-mode <file>`, or `sre set-instructor-mode <running_lab>` on a running project — privileged only) the text is kept, and the GUI displays it in red on a light red background while its *Instructor mode* button is on. `color` / `background` (`'#rrggbb'` or a colour name) change the colours of one text; `params.instructor_text_color` / `params.instructor_background_color` are the defaults.
- A **debug project** (`sre start --debug-project`) keeps the text as well: the same button displays or hides it, so the hints can be checked while the lab is being written.
- A question hash does not depend on the instructor texts: the answers stay attached when the mode is switched on a running project.

Rules:

- call `instructor()` from `NetScheme.__init__` (after `super().__init__()`) or from `Grade.grade()`. The mode of the project is not known while the module is imported, so a module-level call (`title`, `@sre_state(description=...)`, `Flavor.flavor_form`) always gives an empty text;
- use it for `self.informations` and for the titles and descriptions of the questions. The other texts (grade elements, state descriptions, files pushed to the machines) are plain text and would show the raw marks in instructor mode;
- a fragment is either inline text or one or several whole markdown blocks (paragraphs, lists, code blocks, tables). It is dedented on its own, so an indented triple-quoted block works whatever the indentation of the public text; it cannot be nested inside a list item of the public text;
- no `@@{field:regex}@@` form field inside a fragment (a student would not get the field);
- use `+` or `TranslatedText.format()` to combine texts, as with `tr()`: `%` and f-strings do not work on translated texts.

A lab file without the instructor texts — `sbin/strip-instructor`

The running system keeps the instructor texts away from students, but the lab file itself still holds them. `sbin/strip-instructor` writes the file without its `instructor()` calls, and with `--full` without its solution states either, for instance before handing a lab over:

```
sbin/strip-instructor lab/s4/mylab.py /tmp/mylab_public.py    # output file
sbin/strip-instructor lab/s4/mylab.py /srv/public_labs/       # existing directory → /
↪srv/public_labs/mylab.py
sbin/strip-instructor -i /srv/public_labs/mylab.py            # replace the file itself
sbin/strip-instructor --full lab/s4/mylab.py /srv/public_labs/   # the solution states␣
↪removed as well
```

- an `instructor(...)` operand of a `+` disappears with its operator (`instructor(tr("note")) + tr("public")` → `tr("public")`); a call standing alone becomes `''`;
- the `_TRANSLATIONS` entries of the `tr()` strings that only those calls used are deleted, in every language;
- `instructor` is removed from its `from ... import` when nothing uses it any more;
- formatting and comments are kept; the result is checked (it must parse and hold no `instructor()` call), otherwise nothing is written.

With `--full` (no short form) the file loses the states students cannot apply as well, so that it holds no solution any more:

- every `@sre_state` method is removed with its decorator, unless it is `initial`, a lifecycle state (`save`, `restore`: `sre save` / `sre restore` apply them) or user-allowed (`@sre_state(user_allowed=True, ...)`); the `_TRANSLATIONS` entries that only those methods used go with them, and `sre_state` leaves its import when no state is left;
- the `cheat_answers={...}` of the questions lose the entries keyed by a removed state (the whole keyword when no entry is left);
- a removed state that a kept method still uses (`self.final()` in `restore`) makes the file refused: move the shared code to a helper method, or make the state user-allowed.

The stripped lab behaves like the original outside the instructor mode. Limits:

- a text kept in a variable is not followed: with `note = tr("...")` then `instructor(note)`, the definition of `note` stays in the file. The script warns about such variables; write `note = instructor(tr("...."))` to have the text removed;
- with `--full`, the helper methods and the variables that only the removed states (or their `cheat_answers`) used stay in the file: a warning names them (`_solution_dhcpd_conf`, `q1_answers`…), to be removed by hand;
- comments are not examined, and only the lab file is processed (not the state directories of a directory lab: with `--full` a warning names the directory of a removed state standing next to a `srelab.py`);
- a question keeps its hash as long as the removed text has no language that the text it was added to lacks (the usual case). Otherwise the archives of the stripped lab do not match the original lab in `sre re-eval`.

In instructor mode every state can be applied from the GUI, as in a debug project: the **Apply Configuration** tab also lists the states that are not `user_allowed` (in red), so the instructor can apply a `final` state in front of the class without making it available to students. The project also gets a **Log** tab listing what every applied state executed (`self.cmd()`, `self.file()`…, with outputs and exit codes), again only while the button is on.

4.6.6 Numbered sections, references and table of contents — `info_subtitle()`, `info_toc()`

The headers of a course, its table of contents and the mentions of a section (`see section 7`) are computed, so that inserting a section renumbers nothing by hand. Four functions imported from `SRE.lib_sre`, like `tr()` and `instructor()`, emit plain-text *markers*; the numbers, the links and the table of contents are resolved when `info.json` is written, in every language, so there is nothing else to call:

```
from SRE.lib_sre import NetScheme0, Grade0, make_tr, no_tr, info_subtitle, info_tag,␣
↪info_ref, info_toc

tr = make_tr('fr')

class NetScheme(NetScheme0):
    def __init__(self, data, running_lab_name):
        super().__init__(data=data, running_lab_name=running_lab_name)
        self.informations = (
            no_tr("## ") + title + no_tr("\n")
            + tr("**Sommaire**\n", en="**Contents**\n") + info_toc()
            + info_subtitle(tr("À quoi sert DHCP", en="What DHCP is for"), tag="why")
            + tr("""
Un serveur prête une adresse pour la durée d'un **bail** (section @@ref:lease@@).

### @@sec@@ Les acteurs

Trois rôles : @@tag:roles@@ client, serveur, relais.
""", en="""
A server lends an address for the duration of a **lease** (section @@ref:lease@@).

### @@sec@@ The actors

Three roles: @@tag:roles@@ client, server, relay.
""")
            + info_subtitle(tr("La vie d'un bail", en="The life of a lease"), tag="lease
↪")
            + tr("""...""")
        )

class Grade(Grade0):
    def grade(self):
        super().grade()
        self.question_text(
            title=tr("Le bail", en="The lease"),
            description=tr("Lisez la section @@ref:lease@@ des Informations (les rôles :␣
↪@@ref:roles:title@@).",
                           en="Read section @@ref:lease@@ of the Informations tab (the␣
↪roles: @@ref:roles:title@@)."))
```

The student sees a **Sommaire** listing *1. À quoi sert DHCP*, *1.1. Les acteurs* and *2. La vie d'un bail* as links, the headers `## 1. À quoi sert DHCP`, `### 1.1. Les acteurs`, `## 2. La vie d'un bail`, the sentence *(section 2)* where the number is a link that scrolls the tab to the section, and in the question *Lisez la section 2 des Informations (les rôles : 1. À quoi sert DHCP).*

function	marker it returns	resolved form in the course
`info_subtitle(titl level=1, tag="")`	`\n\n## @@sec@@ Title\n\n` (`###` for `level=2`…), `## @@sec:tag@@ Title` with a tag	`## <a id="tag"></a>2. Title` (an untagged section gets the id `sec.2`)
`info_tag(tag)`	`@@tag:tag@@`	`<a id="tag"></a>`; a reference to it gives the number of the section it stands in and scrolls to the spot
`info_ref(tag)` / `info_ref(tag, title=True)`	`@@ref:tag@@` / `@@ref:tag:title@@`	`[2.1](#tag)` / `[2.1. Title](#tag)`; in a question text: `2.1` / `2.1. Title` (its browser has no anchor)
`info_toc(depth=Non`	`\n\n@@toc@@\n\n`, `@@toc:1@@` with a depth	a nested bullet list of `[2.1. Title](#tag)` links, every level or the first *depth* levels

The functions return plain strings (a `tr()` title keeps its languages) that combine with `+` like any text. The markers may just as well be typed inside a `tr()` block — the natural form for a sub-section or a reference in the middle of a long text, and the only one inside a block holding literal braces, which `TranslatedText.format()` would refuse: `### @@sec@@ Sub-title` is numbered by its number of `#` (`##`: level 1, `###`: level 2…), `(section @@ref:lease@@)` becomes a link.

Rules:

- a header without a marker is not numbered, and a `#` header (the lab title) never is;
- a tag is made of letters, digits, `_` and `-`, in English like the identifiers of the lab, and is unique; a level cannot be skipped (no `####` right after a `##`);
- a question text may hold `@@ref@@` markers only; they give bare numbers;
- the headers read `1.`, `2.1.`, `2.1.3.`, a reference drops the final dot; a marker inside a fenced code block is left as it is;
- do not number a header inside `instructor()`: the numbers must be the same in and out of the instructor mode, so a `@@sec@@`, `@@tag@@` or `@@toc@@` standing inside an instructor fragment is dropped (a `@@ref@@` there is resolved);
- the languages of a `tr()` course must declare the same sections and tags in the same order;
- a question hash is computed from the marked title, so renumbering the course never detaches the stored answers.

`sre check` resolves the course as `sre start` does, prints its outline (number, title, tag of every section) and reports a bad marker, a level jump, a tag defined twice or unknown — in the course or in a question — and languages whose sections differ, as a `FAIL`. The `sre export` PDF keeps the numbers and the table of contents without the links.

4.7 State methods

A *state* is a method of `NetScheme` decorated with `@sre_state`. The body of the method does not execute commands directly — instead, it **registers** operations (run a shell command, write a file, copy a file from the host, …) which SRE then applies in order against the running containers.

The `initial` state is always applied at `sre start` and is where the lab configures interfaces, launches services, and writes per-machine files derived from `Data`. Additional states are applied on demand with `sre state <running_lab> <state_name>`. Their main use case is the instructor's workflow: a state that brings the project into a fully-configured, all-questions-answered shape, so the grading code can be exercised end-to-end without going through the student workflow. Students see and can apply a

state only if the module-level attribute `allow_user_states = True` **and** that state was decorated with `@sre_state(user_allowed=True)`.

```
@sre_state(user_allowed=False)
def initial(self):
    """Always applied at sre start."""
    d = self.data
    self.cmd('router', f'ip addr add {d.ips.router} dev eth0')
    self.cmd('router', 'sysctl -w net.ipv4.ip_forward=1')
    self.file('client', '/etc/resolv.conf', f'nameserver {d.ips.router.ip}\n')

@sre_state(user_allowed=True, description=tr("Final config", fr="Configuration finale"))
def final(self):
    """Optional additional state; students can apply it via 'sre state'."""
    self.cmd('router', 'iptables -A FORWARD -j ACCEPT')
```

4.7.1 Lifecycle states: `save` / `restore`

`NetScheme0` defines three *lifecycle* states that SRE applies itself: `initial` (at `sre start`), `save` (by `sre save`, just before the container filesystems are captured) and `restore` (by `sre restore`, on the new instance right after the containers have been redeployed from the saved filesystems). `save` and `restore` are empty by default and only matter for labs that set `allow_save_restore = True`.

A save captures **files only**: a restored container starts from its saved filesystem but nothing that `initial()` launched with `cmd()` is running any more. Relaunch those daemons in `restore()`:

```
@sre_state()
def restore(self):
    self.cmd('server', 'service ssh start')
    self.cmd('server', 'service isc-dhcp-server start', allow_error=True)
```

Lifecycle states are never user-allowed, never listed in the GUI, and `sre check` runs `save()` / `restore()` when the lab allows save/restore. `<srelab_dir>/save/` and `<srelab_dir>/restore/` are therefore reserved state-file directories (see *State file transfer*).

4.7.2 `@sre_state` decorator

Parameter	Description
`user_al`	If `False`, students cannot apply this state themselves (only root/instructor can).
`descrip`	Human-readable label shown in the GUI (supports `TranslatedText` from `make_tr`).
`multi_p`	If `True`, the state method is re-run before each step so that `self.cmd()` / `self.host_cmd()` return real results (see *Reading command results* below). Default `False`: the method is called once, as before.

4.7.3 Per-machine operations

These all register an op against a single machine and accept a `step=` parameter (see *Multi-step state setup* below).

Method	Description
`self.cmd(machine, command, step=1, timeout=120, default_value='', default_code=0, allow_error=False)`	Run a shell command inside `machine` (under `sh`, via `exetests.py`). Returns `(output, exit_code)` — a placeholder until the command has run, see *Reading command results*. Non-zero exit codes are reported on stderr unless `allow_error=True`.
`self.file(machine, path, content, permissions=0o644, owner="root:root", mtime=None, step=1)`	Create or overwrite a file inside `machine`. `content` may be `str` or `bytes`.
`self.append_to_file(machine, path, content, permissions=None, owner=None, mtime=None, step=1)`	Append to a file (creates it if missing).
`self.idempotent_append_to_file(mac path, content, ..., step=1)`	Same as `append_to_file` but only appends if the file does not already end with `content` — safe to call repeatedly.

4.7.4 File transfer between host and container

Method	Description
`self.cp_from_host(src, machine, dest, owner="root:root", permissions=None, mtime=None, step=1)`	Copy a file from the host into `machine`. Relative `src` is resolved against `params.files_dir(running_lab_name)`.
`self.cp_to_host(machine, path, dest, step=1)`	Copy a file from `machine` back to the host, inside `params.files_dir(running_lab_name)`. `dest` is restricted to that directory.

4.7.5 Host-side operations

Method	Description
`self.host_cmd(command, step=1, timeout=120, default_value='', default_code=0, allow_error=False)`	Run a shell command on the **host** (not inside any container). Returns `(stdout, exit_code)` with the same contract as `cmd()`. Refused if `params.execute_commands_on_host is False`.
`self.host_callback(callable, step=1)`	Invoke a Python callable on the host at this step, with no arguments. Useful when the next steps need values computed in Python.

4.7.6 Switch operations

Method	Description
`self.switch_cmd(networ command, step=1, default_value='', default_code=0, allow_error=False`	Run one command on the management console of the managed switch `network` (a network with `'mode': 'managed'`; `ValueError` otherwise). A word `@machine` in `command` is replaced by the number of the port the machine is plugged into, e.g. `port/setvlan @pc1 10`. Returns `(output, code)` with the same contract as `host_cmd()`: `code` is `0`, the error number given by the switch (`17`: the VLAN already exists) or `-2` when the command could not be run. See *Switches and VLANs*.

4.7.7 Multi-step state setup — the `step` parameter

Every state-method operation accepts `step=N` (default `1`). When SRE applies a state it groups all registered ops by step and runs them in ascending order: every step-1 op finishes before any step-2 op starts. This matters when later ops depend on earlier ones being in place — for example writing a config file at step 1 and only restarting the service at step 2:

```
@sre_state(user_allowed=False)
def initial(self):
    self.file('dns', '/etc/unbound/unbound.conf', conf, step=1)
    self.cmd('dns',  'systemctl restart unbound',    step=2)
```

Inside a single step the per-machine op order is preserved, and ops on different machines run in parallel. `host_cmd` / `host_callback` / `switch_cmd` for step `N` run, in registration order, *before* the container ops of step `N` (so a key generated on the host at step 1 can be copied into a machine at step 1).

Container commands registered with `self.cmd()` run under `sh` through `/usr/local/sbin/exetests.py`, the runner `Grade.test()` also uses: consecutive `cmd()` ops of one machine at one step are sent as a single batch, shell syntax such as `|`, `>>` or `&&` works, and each command is killed after `timeout` seconds (default `params.default_state_cmd_timeout`, 120 s; `0` disables the timeout; the exit code is then `-1`). A non-zero exit code is reported on stderr (hidden in `--user` mode) unless the call passes `allow_error=True`.

4.7.8 Reading command results — `multi_pass=True`

`self.cmd()`, `self.host_cmd()` and `self.switch_cmd()` return `(output, exit_code)` with the same register-then-resolve contract as `Grade.test()`: the value is the placeholder `(default_value, default_code)` until the command has actually run. By default a state method is called **once**, before anything runs, so it only ever sees placeholders.

Decorate the state with `@sre_state(multi_pass=True)` to have SRE call the method again before each step: the call that registers the ops of step `N+1` sees the real results of steps `1..N`. The method runs `max_step + 1` times, like `grade()` during an evaluation: a final call after the last step sees the results of every command and is the natural place to copy them into `self.data`. Each call only contributes the ops of the step about to be applied; re-registering the ops of an earlier step is expected and harmless.

```
@sre_state(multi_pass=True)
def initial(self):
    hostname, code = self.cmd('client', 'cat /etc/hostname', step=1)   # ('', 0) on the␣
↪first call
    self.file('server', '/etc/motd', f'welcome {hostname.strip()}\n', step=2)
    self.data.client_hostname = hostname.strip()   # real on the final call; data.json␣
↪is saved after initial()
```

Rules for a `multi_pass` state:

- **Consume a result at a later step than the command.** An op that uses a result (`file()`, another `cmd()`) must be registered by a call that runs after the command, i.e. at step `N+1` or later; a plain `self.data` assignment can simply rely on the final call. An op registered during the final call for a new, higher step extends the loop — another pass follows, exactly as a late `self.test(step=N)` extends `grade()`.
- **The method must be idempotent.** It runs several times: `print()` shows up once per pass, and anything random or filled in later must give the same answer on every pass. Wrap such values in `self.once(key, factory)`, which calls `factory()` the first time `key` is seen and returns the cached value afterwards (`pcap_gen.generate_pcap_tcp_example` does this for its ports and result dict).
- `self.step` is the number of steps already applied when the method runs (0 on the first call) and `self.max_step` the highest step registered so far.

`sre check` and `sre export` always call the method once and only see placeholders.

4.7.9 Network config helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/net_config.py`)

```
from net_config import set_net_config_entry, set_sysctl, NetConfigEntry, SysctlConfig

# In initial():
set_net_config_entry(net_scheme=self, machine_name='router', nc_entry=[
    ([data.ips.router_lan], [(IPv4Network('0.0.0.0/0'), data.ips.gw)]),
])
set_sysctl(net_scheme=self, machine_name='router', sysctl_config={'ipv4.ip_forward': 1})
```

`NetConfig` is a list of interface entries; each entry is `([addresses], [(dest_network, gateway), ...])` or `'dhcp'` or `None`. An entry may hold both families (`[d.ips.pc, d.ips6.pc]`, routes to `IPv4Network('0.0.0.0/0')` and `IPv6Network('::/0')`): `set_net_config_entry` dispatches on the address family, and `get_net_config_from_topology(..., ipv6=True)` builds such entries — see *IPv6 labs*.

`set_ip_forward(net_scheme, machine_name, ip_forward, step=1)` and `set_ipv6_forward(net_scheme, machine_name, ipv6_forward, step=1)` set `net.ipv4.ip_forward` / `net.ipv6.conf.all.forwarding` (Kathara starts every machine with forwarding on in both families).

Persistent equivalents — these write to `/etc/network/interfaces` (one `inet static` and one `inet6 static` stanza per interface as needed) and `/etc/sysctl.d/99-sre.conf` so the config survives a container restart:

- `set_persistent_net_config_entry(net_scheme, machine_name, nc_entry)`
- `set_persistent_sysctl(net_scheme, machine_name, sysctl_config)`

4.7.10 State helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/state_helpers.py`)

Convenience functions called inside `@sre_state` methods:

```
from state_helpers import (set_unbound_server, set_basic_unbound_server,
                           change_password, create_user,
                           hosts_file_content, create_hosts_file,
                           setup_simple_tcp_server, set_radvd, set_slaac_client)
```

Function	Description
`set_unbound_server(net_scheme machine)`	Drop a permissive Unbound DNS config into `/etc/unbound/unbound.conf` and start the service. (Thin alias for `set_basic_unbound_server`.)
`set_basic_unbound_server(net_s machine)`	Same as above; explicit name when you want to make the "basic / permissive" intent obvious.
`change_password(net_scheme, machine, username, password)`	Set a user's password via `chpasswd`. The password is written to a temporary file (never passed on the command line).
`create_user(net_scheme, machine, username, password, uid=None, gid=None)`	Create a user with `useradd` (if not already present) and set its password. `uid`/`gid` are passed as integers. The password is written to a temporary file; the username is passed via an environment variable to prevent shell injection.
`hosts_file_content(net_scheme domain_extension, included=None, ips=None, separator="\t\t", ipv6=False, ips6=None)`	Return `/etc/hosts` lines for a set of machines. Each machine gets one line per network it is connected to (two lines if multi-homed, with `machine_net` naming). Addresses are read from `net_scheme.data.ips.*` by convention (`machine` for single-homed, `machine_net` for multi-homed), or from the `ips` dict if provided. `included` defaults to all visible machines. `ipv6=True` adds, after each IPv4 line, the IPv6 line of the machines that have an address in `net_scheme.data.ips6.*` (or in the `ips6` dict).
`create_hosts_file(net_scheme, domain_extension, machine_list=None, included=None, ips=None, separator="\t\t", ipv6=False, ips6=None)`	Write `/etc/hosts` to each machine in `machine_list` (defaults to all visible machines). Each file begins with standard loopback entries (`127.0.0.1 localhost`, `127.0.1.1 <machine>`, plus `::1` / `ff02::1` / `ff02::2` with `ipv6=True`) followed by the lines from `hosts_file_content()`.
`setup_simple_tcp_server(net_s machine, port, answer, ip=None, ipv6=False)`	Start an idempotent daemon that answers `answer` to every TCP connection on `port`, bound to `ip` (IPv4 or IPv6, prefix stripped), to `0.0.0.0`, or to `::` (dual stack) with `ipv6=True`.
`set_radvd(net_scheme, machine, prefixes, step=1, *, rdnss=None, dnssl=None, min_rtr_adv_interval=3, max_rtr_adv_interval=10, adv_autonomous=True, adv_on_link=True, adv_router_addr=False, enable_forwarding=True)`	Write `/etc/radvd.conf` (`prefixes = {interface: [IPv6Network, ...]}`, interfaces as `'eth1'` or `1`, /64 prefixes for SLAAC) and start radvd, after enabling IPv6 forwarding. Returns the configuration text.
`set_slaac_client(net_scheme, machine, interfaces=None, step=1)`	Make the machine configure itself from router advertisements: `accept_ra=2` and `autoconf=1` on `interfaces` (default: every interface of the topology). Needed because Kathara starts the machines with forwarding on, which makes the kernel ignore RAs.

4.8 `Grade` class

`Grade` declares **what** the evaluator checks and **how** results are scored. It does not execute anything itself: every `self.test(...)` call merely registers a command. SRE then drives a multi-step loop (`run_tests()`) that calls `Grade.grade()` repeatedly, executing registered commands between passes and feeding their real results back into the next call.

```python
from SRE.lib_sre import Grade0

class Grade(Grade0):
    def grade(self):
        """Register tests, questions, and grade elements.
        Called multiple times per evaluation - must be side-effect-free."""
        super().grade()

        # Register a test: run a shell command in a container
        result, code = self.test('router', 'ping -c1 -W1 8.8.8.8', timeout=5)

        # Register a question (student's text answer)
        answer = self.question_text(
            title='Default gateway',
            description='What is the default gateway for the client?',
            default_answer='',
        )

        # Register a grade element and set its score
        self.add_grade_element('Connectivity', max_grade=4)
        if code == 0:
            self.set_grade('Connectivity', 4)
        elif '64 bytes' in result:
            self.set_grade('Connectivity', 2)

        self.add_grade_element('Gateway answer', max_grade=2)
        if str(self.data.ips.router.ip) in answer:
            self.set_grade('Gateway answer', 2)
```

4.8.1 The grading lifecycle

`Grade.grade()` is **not** called once. It is called repeatedly by `run_tests()`, with the registered commands actually executed between calls. The loop is:

1. `self.step` starts at 0, `self.max_step` at 1. `load_answers()` reads the student's `answers.json`.
2. `reset_before_grade()` clears questions, grade rubrics, and section counters.
3. `grade()` is called.
   - `self.test(machine, cmd, step=N)` registers `cmd` under `(machine, N)` and returns `(default_value, default_code)` (i.e. placeholders) the *first* time it is seen.
   - If a call uses `step=K` larger than `self.max_step`, `max_step` is bumped to `K`, extending the loop.
   - `self.add_grade_element` / `self.set_grade` / `self.question_*` calls all register entries; they don't read any container state directly.
4. `self.step` is incremented to `N`. All commands registered at step `N` are bundled per machine into one `EXETESTS@@@cmd1@@@cmd2@@@…` env var and run inside each container in parallel (16-worker `ThreadPoolExecutor`, via `/usr/local/sbin/exetests.py`). The `test_switch()` commands for step `N` are then sent to the consoles of the managed switches, and the host-side `test_host()` commands run in parallel on the host.
5. Results are stored back into `self._tests[(machine, N)]`. The loop returns to step 2. On this pass, the registration calls for step `N` find the entry already populated and return the **real** `(stdout, exit_code)`; the code paths gated on those results now execute.

6. When `self.step > self.max_step`, the loop exits. The archive (zstd-compressed msgpack with all tests, answers, errors, and grade list) is written to `params.archives_dir` and to every directory in the module-level `archive_dirs`.

This has two consequences for `grade()`:

- **It must be side-effect-free.** It is run several times — at least twice (one registration pass, one result pass), more if you use multi-step tests. Never call `subprocess`, write to disk, or mutate global state inside it. All work goes through `self.test` / `self.question_*`.
- **`self.test()` returns placeholders the first time it is reached.** Code that branches on the return value (e.g. `if code == 0:`) executes both with the placeholder (no-op) and with the real result. Make sure the placeholder branch is harmless — it will execute, but its `add_grade_element` calls are wiped by `reset_before_grade()` before the next pass, so only the final pass's calls end up in the archive.

A worked two-step example: configure step 1 to perform a setup action, then read its effect at step 2.

```
def grade(self):
    super().grade()
    self.test('router', 'systemctl restart bird', step=1)
    out, code = self.test('router', 'birdc show route', step=2)
    self.add_grade_element('OSPF routes', max_grade=5)
    if 'OSPF' in out:
        self.set_grade('OSPF routes', 5)
```

On the first call, both `self.test()` invocations register; both return placeholders. SRE executes the step-1 command (`systemctl restart bird`). On the second call, the step-1 test returns its real result; the step-2 test registers and returns its placeholder. SRE executes the step-2 command. On the third call, both tests return real results; `out` contains the routing table, the rubric is populated, and the loop exits.

4.8.2 Grade parts

A *grade part* is a named group that bundles related rubric items together. Parts are **purely presentational**: they affect how grades are displayed in the GUI's *Evaluations* tab and in the PDFs produced by `sre outline` — each part is rendered as a labeled block with a **subtotal row** summing its elements. The overall total, the archive contents, and the marks returned by `mark_exo_eval()` / `mark_self_eval()` are unchanged.

Register a part with `self.add_grade_part(title, description='')` and pass the returned object as `grade_part=` to every element that belongs to it:

```
def grade(self):
    super().grade()

    part1 = self.add_grade_part("part1", tr("Client DNS dig"))
    self.add_grade_element(title="dig_host1_a", max_grade=1, grade=int(host1_ok),
                           grade_part=part1, description=tr("dig - A de host1"))
    self.add_grade_element(title="dig_host2_a", max_grade=1, grade=int(host2_ok),
                           grade_part=part1, description=tr("dig - A de host2"))

    part2 = self.add_grade_part("part2", tr("Serveur DNS cache Unbound"))
    self.add_grade_element(title="unbound_running", max_grade=2, grade=int(unbound_ok),
                           grade_part=part2, description=tr("unbound actif"))
    # ...
```

Elements registered without `grade_part=` are shown ungrouped (above or between the parts, in registration order). Parts are rendered in the order they were registered with `add_grade_part()`. See `lab/sre/dns1.py` for a real-world example with three parts.

4.8.3 Self-eval vs instructor-eval scope

Every `add_grade_element` call takes a `scope=` bitmask that decides which audiences see the element. Three values are defined in `params`:

Value	Visible in
`SELF_EVAL_SCOPE` (1)	Student self-eval only — `sre eval --auto-eval` (GUI **Start evaluation** button)
`EXO_EVAL_SCOPE` (2)	Instructor view only — `sre eval` (non-auto), `sre outline`, `sre sheet`, periodic exam-mode evals
`BOTH_EVAL_SCOPE` (3, default)	Both audiences

The total mark reflects only the elements in the active scope: `mark_self_eval()` sums elements with `scope & SELF_EVAL_SCOPE`, `mark_exo_eval()` sums elements with `scope & EXO_EVAL_SCOPE`. The same `grade()` body can therefore produce a different total for a student self-eval than for the instructor's archive.

A common pattern is to register a **detailed rubric** for the instructor and a **coarse summary** for the student — enough feedback to know something is broken in a given part, without disclosing which individual check failed:

```
from SRE import params

def grade(self):
    super().grade()

    part1 = self.add_grade_part("part1", tr("DNS resolution"))
    host1_ok = ...   # bool computed from self.test(...) results
    host2_ok = ...
    ptr_ok   = ...

    # Detailed rubric - only the instructor (and sre outline / sre sheet) sees these
    self.add_grade_element('dig host1 A',   max_grade=1, grade=int(host1_ok),
                           grade_part=part1, scope=params.EXO_EVAL_SCOPE)
    self.add_grade_element('dig host2 A',   max_grade=1, grade=int(host2_ok),
                           grade_part=part1, scope=params.EXO_EVAL_SCOPE)
    self.add_grade_element('dig host1 PTR', max_grade=1, grade=int(ptr_ok),
                           grade_part=part1, scope=params.EXO_EVAL_SCOPE)

    # Summary - what the student sees during self-eval
    all_ok = host1_ok and host2_ok and ptr_ok
    self.add_grade_element('part1_global', max_grade=1, grade=int(all_ok),
                           scope=params.SELF_EVAL_SCOPE,
                           description='Part 1 (combined)')
```

During the student's self-eval, only the `SELF_EVAL_SCOPE` element appears: one row per part with a pass/fail score (no need for grade parts there). During the instructor's evaluation, only the three `EXO_EVAL_SCOPE` rows appear. `scope` and `grade_part` compose freely — elements in the same part can have different scopes and will be subtotalled accordingly for each audience.

4.8.4 Questions

Three kinds of questions, registered from `grade()` like the tests and shown in the Questions tab of the GUI and of the web front-end. The answers live in `answers/answers.json` under the hash of the question and come back as the return value of the registration call, on every pass of `grade()`.

Method	What the student sees	Returns
`self.question_text(title, description='', default_answer='', ...)`	the description (markdown) above one free-text box	the text typed, or `default_answer` (`''`) before the first answer
`self.question_form(title, description='', ...)`	the description with one input in place of every `@@{field:spec}@@` marker	`{field: value}` with every field of the form, or `{}` before the first answer — read the fields with `.get()`
`self.question_dummy(title, description='')`	the description alone	nothing: a heading, an instruction block

The three take `section=` (a prefix of the title, usually `self.section(level)`, see *Grade methods*), `order=` (an integer sorting the questions in the tab; without it the questions get 100, 200, 300… in registration order, so `order=150` slips one between the first two) and `hash=` (the identity of the question in the answers file and in the archives: by default the SHA-256 of the title for a `question_text`, of the title and the description for the two others, so that a change of a form's description, a field spec included, detaches the stored answers unless `hash=` pins it; the instructor fragments and the numbering markers never count).

The fields of a form. A form is a markdown description holding `@@{name:spec}@@` markers; the text between the markers is rendered like the description of a `question_text`, a checkbox taking the row of the text before it. `name` is the key of the field in the returned dict (any characters but `:` and `}`, unique within the form); `spec` gives the kind of input:

Marker	Input	Value returned
`@@{name:regex}@@`	single-line text, meant to match the regex entirely (`[0-9]+`, `.+`, `[0-9.]+/[0-9]+`…); an empty spec, `@@{name:}@@`, puts no constraint	`str`, `''` for an untouched field
`@@{name:+}@@` / `@@{name:+N}@@`	multi-line text of N visible lines (`params.default_form_field_lines` = 4 without N)	`str`, newlines kept
`@@{name:>a|b|c}@@`	dropdown of the options, the first one selected by default	`str`, the option chosen
`@@{name:Label A>>>a|Label B>>>b}@@`	dropdown showing the labels	`str`, the value behind the label chosen
`@@{name:?}@@` / `@@{name:?true}@@`	checkbox, unchecked at first with `?` alone or `?false`, checked with `?true`	`bool`
`@@{name::Label}@@`	a button submitting the form — Flavor forms only (see *Flavor class*); in a question form `:Label` is a regex	`bool`, true for the button pressed

- The regex is a Python one, matched with `re.fullmatch()`. The GUI installs it as the validator of the input (a keystroke that can lead to no match is refused), the web front-end marks the input invalid (the `pattern` attribute, so the regex must be a valid JavaScript one too); in both cases the answer is saved as typed, a field left halfway or empty included, so the lab checks the value itself, as it does for a `question_text` answer.

- The options of a dropdown may hold spaces and accents; `|` separates them and `>>>` a label from its value, so neither can appear inside an option. The labelled form lets the student read a sentence while the lab compares a code.
- The markers must be the same in every language of a `tr()` description: the field list is read from one of its values.

```
q = self.question_form(
    tr("Routing table of r1"),
    section=self.section(1),
    description=tr("""
    Default gateway of `r1`: @@{gw:[0-9.]+}@@

    Protocol that installed it: @@{proto:>static|ospf|bgp}@@

    The route is in the kernel table: @@{installed:?}@@

    Commands used: @@{commands:+4}@@
    """),
    cheat_answers={'final': {'gw': str(self.data.ips.gw.ip), 'proto': 'static',
                            'installed': True, 'commands': 'ip route'}},
)
self.add_grade_element(tr("Default gateway"), max_grade=2,
                       grade=2 if q.get('gw') == str(self.data.ips.gw.ip) else 0)
self.add_grade_element(tr("Protocol"), max_grade=1,
                       grade=1 if q.get('proto') == 'static' and q.get('installed') else␣
↪0)
```

4.8.5 Cheat answers

`cheat_answers` on `question_text` / `question_form` maps a state name (e.g. `'final'`) to an answer: a string for a `question_text`, a `{field: value}` dict for a `question_form` (the values typed as the form returns them: `str`, `bool` for a checkbox, the value of a dropdown). When the student has applied that state, the cheat answer is used instead of the student's actual input. Useful when the instructor's `final` state should produce a fully-passing evaluation.

4.8.6 Letter grades vs numeric marks

By default, marks are numeric, scaled to `params.default_maximum_mark`, and rounded to one decimal. Set `self._use_numerical_marks = False` (per instance, inside `grade()` or earlier) to switch to letter grades on the **total**: `A+` 18/20, `A` 16, `B` 14, `C` 12, `D` 10, else `F`.

Per-element letter conversion (`OK` / `MEH` / `FAIL`) is also available via `GradeElement.to_grade_letter()` — full marks → OK, partial → MEH, zero → FAIL.

4.8.7 Bonus elements

`self.add_grade_element(..., bonus=True)` registers a *bonus* element: its grade counts in the totals, but its `max_grade` does not (neither in the grand total nor in the subtotal of its `GradePart`), so the mark is computed against the non-bonus maximum only. As soon as a scope holds a bonus element, its mark is capped at `_maximum_mark`: bonus points make up for lost points but never push the mark above the maximum (a lab without bonus elements keeps its usual, uncapped mark). The reports still show the `max_grade` of a bonus element, with the word "Bonus": `2 (Bonus)` in the Max column of the GUI Evaluations tab, of the `sre outline` PDFs, of the `sre sheet` Questions sheet and of the `sre watch` screens; the `--bonus-in-prefix`

flag of `sre outline` / `sre sheet` / `sre watch` writes `Bonus: <label>` before the label instead and leaves the Max column numeric.

```
part = self.add_grade_part('ebgp', tr("Part 2: eBGP sessions"))
self.add_grade_element('ebgp_md5', max_grade=1, grade=int(md5_ok), grade_part=part,␣
↪bonus=True,
                       description=tr("bonus: the r3-ispb session is MD5-authenticated␣
↪on both sides"))
```

4.8.8 Overriding `mark_exo_eval()` to adjust the overall mark

The overall mark stored in the archive (and surfaced by `sre outline`, `sre sheet`, and `sre cat`) is produced by `Grade.mark_exo_eval()`. The default implementation is:

```
def mark_exo_eval(self):
    return self._compute_mark(self._total_grade_exo_eval, self._total_max_exo_eval)
```

i.e. `ceil(10 · maximum_mark · total_grade / total_max) / 10` in numerical mode, or the A+/A/B/C/D/F letter in letter mode. `_total_grade_exo_eval` / `_total_max_exo_eval` are the sums over every `add_grade_element` that contributes to the instructor's view (i.e. excluding self-eval-only rubrics). `mark_self_eval()` is the counterpart used during student self-evaluations.

Override `mark_exo_eval()` (and/or `mark_self_eval()`) on the `Grade` subclass when you want a non-default scale — typically because the maximum of the rubric does not match the intended denominator. Common reasons:

- **Fixed denominator.** The exam was designed against an absolute target (e.g. 39 points). The rubric may sum to more, but you want the mark expressed against that fixed value. Replace `_total_max_exo_eval` with the constant, and cap at `_maximum_mark` so bonuses don't push above the cap:

  ```
  import math

  class Grade(Grade0):
      def mark_exo_eval(self):
          if not self._grade_list or self._total_max_exo_eval == 0:
              return None
          return min(self._maximum_mark,
                     math.ceil(10 * self._maximum_mark * self._total_grade_exo_eval /␣
  ↪39) / 10)
  ```

- **Bonus / penalty handling.** Bonus questions are better registered with `bonus=True` (see *Bonus elements*): no override needed. Penalty rubrics registered with `max_grade=0` (so they only subtract) don't enlarge the denominator either — but if you want them to *not* subtract below zero, clamp `total_grade` before scaling.

`mark_exo_eval()` is called once at the end of `run_tests()`, after every pass of `grade()` and after `compute_total()`. By that time `self._grade_list`, `self._total_grade_exo_eval` / `_total_max_exo_eval`, `self._maximum_mark`, and `self._use_numerical_marks` are all final, so the override is free to read them. Return `None` to signal "no mark" (shown as blank), a `float` for a numeric mark, or a string for a letter grade.

4.8.9 Grade methods

Method	Description
`self.test(machine, command, step=1, timeout=20, allow_error=False, default_value='', default_code=0)`	Register a command in a container; returns `(stdout, exit_code)` (placeholder on first pass, real result on subsequent passes).
`self.test_host(command, step=1, timeout=20, allow_error=False, default_value='', default_code=0)`	Same as `self.test` but the command runs on the host. Refused if `params.execute_commands_on_host is False`.
`self.test_switch(network, command, step=1, default_value='', default_code=0, allow_error=False)`	Same as `self.test` for one command of the management console of the managed switch `network` (`vlan/print`, `port/print @pc1`: `@machine` is the port number of the machine). The exit code is `0`, the error number given by the switch or `-2`. The result is archived with the tests of the machines, under the name of the network. See *Switches and VLANs*.
`self.question_text(title, section='', description='', hash=None, order=None, default_answer='', cheat_answers=None)`	Register a free-text question; returns the student's answer (or `default_answer`). See *Questions*.
`self.question_form(title, section='', description='', hash=None, order=None, cheat_answers=None)`	Register a form question: one input per `@@{field:spec}@@` marker of the description — single-line text with a regex, multi-line text, dropdown, checkbox; the grammar is in *Questions*. Returns the student's answers as `{field: value}`, `{}` before the first answer.
`self.question_dummy(title section='', description='', hash=None, order=None)`	Display-only block (no input shown to the student). See *Questions*.
`self.add_grade_part(title description='')`	Register a named group of grade elements and return the resulting `GradePart`. Pass it to `add_grade_element(..., grade_part=...)` to associate elements with this group; parts render in registration order with a subtotal row per part in the GUI Evaluations view and in `sre outline` PDFs.
`self.add_grade_element(ti max_grade, description='', grade=0, scope=params.BOTH_EVAL_SCOPE, grade_part=None, bonus=False)`	Add a graded rubric item. `scope` is a bitmask: `SELF_EVAL_SCOPE` (1) restricts the element to student self-eval, `EXO_EVAL_SCOPE` (2) restricts it to instructor/auto eval / `sre outline` / `sre sheet`, `BOTH_EVAL_SCOPE` (3, default) shows it everywhere. `grade_part` is a `GradePart` returned by `add_grade_part()`. `bonus=True` makes a bonus element: its grade counts, its `max_grade` is shown (with "Bonus") but not counted, and the mark is capped at the maximum (see *Bonus elements*).
`self.set_grade(title, grade)`	Set the score of a previously registered element.

4.9 Grading Library Reference

4.9.1 DHCP helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/dhcp.py`)

```
from dhcp import DhcpParameters, DhcpSubnet, set_dhcp_server, get_dhcp_server,␣
↪check_running_dhcp_server
```

Data classes:

Class	Purpose
`DhcpSubne`	One `subnet` block: `subnet`, `range_start`, `range_end`, optional `routers`, `dns_servers`, `domain_name`, `default_lease_time`, `max_lease_time`, `fixed_addresses`
`DhcpParam`	Full server config: `interfaces_v4`, `interfaces_v6`, `subnets`, `authoritative`, `default_lease_time`, `max_lease_time`, `ddns_update_style`

Functions used in `NetScheme` (state setup):

`set_dhcp_server(net_scheme, machine, dhcp_params, step=1)` — writes `/etc/default/isc-dhcp-server` and `/etc/dhcp/dhcpd.conf` from a `DhcpParameters` instance, then enables and restarts `isc-dhcp-server`.

Functions used in `Grade` (evaluation):

`get_dhcp_server(grade, machine, step=1) → (DhcpParameters | None, int)` — reads and parses the DHCP server configuration from the running container. Returns the parsed parameters and the number of parse errors. Returns `(None, 1)` if `/etc/default/isc-dhcp-server` is absent.

`check_running_dhcp_server(grade, machine) → (bool, list[str])` — checks whether `isc-dhcp-server` is currently active. Returns `(running, interfaces)` where `interfaces` is the list of interface names dhcpd is bound to (e.g. `["eth0"]`), or `["*"]` if it listens on all interfaces. Interfaces are read from the live process command line, not from the config file.

4.9.2 Mail helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/smtp.py`)

```
from smtp import (install_smtp_probe, smtp_probe, smtp_query, imap_query, get_postconf,␣
↪get_master_services,
                  get_mailq, deferred_to, get_maildir_messages, find_messages,␣
↪received_hops, parse_dsn,
                  parse_received_spf, parse_authentication_results,␣
↪parse_dkim_signature, get_doveconf,
                  render_unbound_records, spf_record_ok, dkim_txt_record,␣
↪generate_dkim_keypair)
```

Helpers of the SMTP labs (Postfix, Dovecot, OpenDKIM, SPF). The evaluation is behavioural: a hidden machine runs an **active probe** (`lib/smtp_probe.py`, standard library only) that dialogues with the student's servers, and what must arrive is read in the Maildirs.

Functions used in `NetScheme` (state setup):

`install_smtp_probe(net_scheme, machine, step=1)` — copies the probe script into *machine*.

`render_unbound_records([(name, type, value), ...])` — `local-data:` lines for an unbound configuration (a TXT value is quoted and split into 255-character strings, `(address, 'PTR', name)` becomes `local-data-ptr:`); `dkim_txt_record(public_key_b64)` and `generate_dkim_keypair(bits)` (the private key as `opendkim-genkey` writes it) let `Data.generate()` carry the solution key.

Functions used in `Grade` (evaluation):

`smtp_probe(grade, machine, spec, step=1, timeout=45) → {query_id: ProbeResult}` — runs the probe with `spec = {'timeout': 5, 'queries': [...]}` built from `smtp_query(id, host, port=25, helo=, mail_from=, rcpt_to=[...], starttls=False, auth=(user, password), token=, subject=, body=)` and `imap_query(id, host, user, password, token=, poll=)`. A `ProbeResult` records every reply as `[code, text]` (`banner`, `ehlo`, `starttls`, `auth`, `mail`, `data`, `rcpt[address]`), the EHLO extensions before (`extensions`) and after STARTTLS (`extensions_tls`), the `queue_id`, and for IMAP `login`, `count` and `messages`; use `code(reply)`, `accepted(address)`, `sent`, `logged_in`. The spec must depend on lab data only (same command on every grade pass); the messages sent carry `X-SRE-Probe: token` and `X-SRE-Probe-Query: id`.

`get_postconf(grade, machine, params=POSTCONF_PARAMS, step=1) → {name: value}` (`postconf -x`), `mynetworks_covers(value, network)`, `relayhost_target(value) → (host, port)`, `get_master_services(grade, machine) → {'submission/inet': {..., 'options': {...}}}` (`postconf -M`), `get_mailq(grade, machine) → [MailqEntry]` (`postqueue -j`) and `deferred_to(entries, domain)`.

`get_maildir_messages(grade, machine, paths, step=, token=, expected=, max_wait=) → [MaildirMessage]` — every file of `new/` and `cur/` of the Maildirs *paths* in one base64 dump, after waiting at most *max_wait* seconds for *expected* files containing *token* (the deliveries of what the probe has just sent). Then `find_messages(messages, token, query=)`, `body_contains(msg, sentence)`, `received_hops(msg)` (most recent first: `from`, `from_ip`, `by`, `with`, `id`, `for`), `is_bounce(msg)` / `parse_dsn(msg)`, `parse_received_spf`, `parse_authentication_results`, `parse_dkim_signature`; `maildir_cleanup_command(paths, token)` removes the probe's messages at a later step, `queue_cleanup_command(sender)` its queued ones.

`get_doveconf(grade, machine)` (`doveconf -n` as nested dicts), `doveconf_listener(conf, path)`, `doveconf_value(conf, key)`; `parse_txt_strings(dig_output)`, `parse_spf`, `spf_record_ok(record, mx_ip=, mx_name=)`, `parse_dkim_txt`; `tls.get_tls_server_certificate(..., starttls='smtp')` reads the certificate of a STARTTLS server.

Facts verified on the mail image: OpenDKIM resolves with its own libunbound starting from the root, so a closed lab needs `Nameservers <dns>` in `opendkim.conf`; policyd-spf's `TestOnly = 1` still rejects on a `-all` fail (`Mail_From_reject = False` and `HELO_reject = False` give a header-only check); `nobody` is a valid local recipient of Postfix.

4.9.3 TLS helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/tls.py`)

```
from tls import eval_rsa_private_key, set_rsa_private_key, eval_self_signed_certificate,␣
↪eval_certificate
```

Functions used in `NetScheme` (state setup):

`set_rsa_private_key(net_scheme, machine_name, key_file, password, bits=4096, cipher='AES-256-CBC')` — generates an encrypted RSA private key inside the container using `openssl genrsa`. File paths and the password are shell-quoted automatically.

Functions used in `Grade` (evaluation):

`eval_rsa_private_key(grade, machine_name, key_file, password=None, bits=4096, cipher='AES-256-CBC', step=1) → bool` — verifies that `key_file` is an RSA private key with the expected size and PEM cipher. Returns `True` if all checks pass.

`eval_self_signed_certificate(grade, machine_name, key_file, cert_file, password, cn=None, bits=4096, cipher='AES-256-CBC', step=1) → dict` — checks that `cert_file` is a valid self-signed certificate whose public key matches `key_file`. Returns a dict with keys `subject`, `issuer`, `common_name`, `not_before`, `not_after`, `serial`, `fingerprint`.

`eval_certificate(grade, machine_name, key_file, cert_file, ca_file, step=1) → dict` — checks that `cert_file` is a valid certificate signed by `ca_file` and whose public key matches `key_file`. Returns the same dict as `eval_self_signed_certificate`.

4.9.4 DNS helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/dns.py`)

Used by `lab/sre/_DRAFT_misc/dns2.py` (private root, resolver, delegation, TSIG transfers, dynamic updates, DNSSEC, DoT/DoH, views, RPZ). Pure functions first, then `(grade, machine, …)` wrappers; fixtures in `tests/mock_data/dns/`.

- **Queries.** `dig_query(grade, m, server, "www.example.tp A", step=1, dnssec=True, cd=True, norecurse=True, tcp=True, key=(name, secret))` returns a `DigResult`: `status`, `flags` (`has_flag('ad')`), `answer` / `authority` / `additional` lists of `RR(name, ttl, rclass, rtype, rdata)`, `rdata('A')`, `soa_serial()`, `ttl()`, `error` (`'timeout'`, `'transfer failed'`, `'connection refused'`), `xfr_records` for AXFR listings; `referral(result)` gives the NS names and the glue of a referral. `kdig_query(grade, m, server, name, tls=True|https=True, ca_file=, hostname=)` → `KdigResult(session 'TLS'|'HTTPS', http_status, …)`. `nsupdate_run(grade, m, server, zone, ["update add host.example.tp. 300 A 10.0.0.9"], key=)` → `(ok, rcode)`; the same `nsupdate_cmd()` text serves in states (one `printf | nsupdate -y` line: exetests needs single-line commands).
- **DNSSEC.** `ecdsa_p256_keypair()` gives `(private_b64, public_b64)` to keep in `Data`; `render_bind_key_files(owner, priv, pub)` writes them as `dnssec-keygen` would (named adopts them with `dnssec-policy`); `ds_rdata(owner, dnskey_rdata)`, `keytag_of()`, `ds_covers_keys(ds_rdatas, dnskey_rdatas, owner)` check a published DS against the keys a server serves; `trust_anchor_line()` (unbound) and `render_bind_trust_anchors()` (`delv -a`) write the anchor.
- **Configurations.** `get_named_conf(grade, m)` parses `named-checkconf -p` (keys, options, zones, views); `get_unbound_conf(grade, m)` the concatenated `unbound.conf.d/*.conf` (`unbound_values(conf, 'server', 'access-control')`, `unbound_clauses(conf, 'rpz')`); `get_stubby_conf`, `get_firefox_doh` (policies.json or `network.trr.*` prefs), `get_zone_status(…, view=)` / `get_dnssec_status` (`rndc`), `get_named_journal` / `get_unbound_log` (events of `journalctl`: transfers, notifies, updates, RPZ hits), `get_unbound_list(…, 'forwards'|'stubs')`. `unbound_default_local_zone(net)` names the built-in local zone a resolver must declare `nodefault` before it can resolve a private reverse zone.
- **Renderers** for states and instructor texts: `render_zone_file`, `render_tsig_key`, `render_root_hints`, `render_rpz_zone`, `render_stubby_yml`, `reverse_zone_name` / `reverse_label`, `spki_pin`, `random_tsig_secret`; `tls.generate_ca_pem(cn)` for a lab-provided CA.

4.9.5 TCP port helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/grade_helpers.py`)

```
from grade_helpers import eval_tcp_server, test_dig
```

`eval_tcp_server(grade, machine_name, server_name, step=1) → list[int] | None` — returns the TCP ports in LISTEN state of the processes matching `server_name` (`pgrep -f`, `ss -tlnp`), whatever the local address form (`0.0.0.0:80`, `*:80`, `[::]:80`, `[fd00::1]:8080`, `127.0.0.53%lo:53`), or `None` when no such process runs.

`test_dig(grade, machine_name, server_ip, *, proto='udp', port=53, request, timeout=2, step=1) → (stdout, exit_code)` — runs `dig +short` against `server_ip` (a string, an `IPv4Address` / `IPv6Address` or an `IPv4Interface` / `IPv6Interface`, prefix stripped).

4.9.6 OSPF helpers (from /opt/sre/lib/frr.py)

```
from frr import get_ospf_interfaces
```

`get_ospf_interfaces(grade, machine_name, step=1) → dict` — runs `vtysh -c "show ip ospf interface"` inside the container and parses the output. Returns a dict keyed by interface name, each value containing: `area`, `cost`, `state` (DR/BDR/DROther/…), `dr`, `bdr`, `neighbor_count`, `adj_neighbor_count`.

4.9.7 BGP helpers (from /opt/sre/lib/frr.py)

```
from frr import (get_bgp_summary, get_bgp_neighbor, get_bgp_routes, get_bgp_prefix,
                 get_bgp_advertised_routes, bgp_best_path, bgp_paths, is_bgp_protocol)
```

These helpers parse the `json` output of `vtysh` (FRR 9). Like the OSPF ones, each `get_*` registers one command through `grade.test()` (two-pass contract) and returns its empty shape (`{}`) on the registration pass, when BGP is not running or when the output cannot be decoded. Pass `allow_error=True` while BGP may not be configured yet.

Function	Returns	Description
`get_bgp_summary(grade machine, step=1, allow_error=False)`	`dict`	`show bgp ipv4 unicast summary`: `router_id`, `as`, `peers: {ip: {remote_as, state, established, policy_blocked, pfx_rcd, pfx_snt, description, uptime}}`. `policy_blocked` is `True` for an eBGP peer without inbound/outbound policy (RFC 8212, `(Policy)` in the text output)
`get_bgp_neighbor(gra machine, peer, step=1, allow_error=False)`	`dict`	`show bgp neighbors <peer>`: `remote_as`, `local_as`, `state`, `established`, `link` (`external`/`internal`), negotiated `hold_time`/`keepalive` (seconds), `local_host`/`foreign_host`, `update_source`, `route_reflector_client`, `next_hop_self`, `default_originate`, `route_map_in`/`route_map_out`, `prefix_list_in`/`prefix_list_out`, `accepted_prefixes`, `sent_prefixes`; `{}` for an unknown neighbour
`get_bgp_routes(grade machine, step=1, allow_error=False)`	`dict[ list[`	`show bgp ipv4 unicast`: `{prefix: [path, ...]}`; each path has `valid`, `best`, `reason` (FRR `selectionReason`), `path_from` (`external`/`internal`), `nexthop`, `peer`, `aspath` (`'65100 65000'`), `as_list` (`[65100, 65000]`), `locprf`, `med`, `weight`, `origin`, `local`
`bgp_best_path(routes, prefix)`	`dict`	The best path of `prefix` in a `get_bgp_routes()` result (`{}` when none)
`bgp_paths(routes, prefix, nexthop=None, peer=None, first_as=None, ends_with=None, path_from=None, valid=None)`	`list[`	Paths of `prefix` matching every given criterion (`ends_with=[65001, 65300]` compares the end of `as_list`)
`get_bgp_prefix(grade machine, prefix, step=1, allow_error=False)`	`dict`	`show bgp ipv4 unicast <prefix>`: `{'prefix', 'paths': [...]}` with the fields above plus `accessible` (next-hop reachability), `peer_router_id`, `originator_id`, `cluster_list` (route reflection) and `communities` (`['65001:300']`)
`get_bgp_advertised_r machine, peer, step=1, allow_error=False)`	`dict`	`show bgp ipv4 unicast neighbors <peer> advertised-routes`: `{prefix: {nexthop, aspath, as_list, locprf, med, weight, origin}}`, i.e. what is really sent to that peer after the outbound policy
`is_bgp_protocol(prot`	`bool`	`True` when a kernel route `protocol` (see `get_kernel_routes`) denotes a route installed by bgpd; `kernel_route_gateways(routes, prefix, protocols=BGP_ROUTE_PROTOCOLS)` lists the gateways of a BGP kernel route

`parse_frr_config` / `get_frr_running_config` also return the BGP configuration: `router_bgp` (`as`, `router_id`, `ebgp_requires_policy`, `network_import_check`, `bestpath`, `neighbors: {peer: {remote_as, description, update_source, timers, shutdown, password, next_hop_self, route_reflector_client, default_originate, route_map_in/out, prefix_list_in/out, ...}}`, `networks`, `aggregate_addresses`, `redistribute`), `prefix_lists`, `route_maps` (`{name: [{seq, action, match: [...], set: [...]}]}`), `as_path_lists`, `community_lists`; interface blocks expose their `ip address` lines in `addresses`.

Verified FRR 9 defaults worth knowing when writing a BGP lab: `bgp ebgp-requires-policy` is on (an eBGP session without route-map/prefix-list exchanges no prefix), `bgp network import-check` is on (a `network` statement needs a matching route, e.g. `ip route X/22 blackhole`), and `interface lo` / `ip address A/32` in `frr.conf` configures the loopback address through zebra.

4.9.8 Standard machine wiring (from `/opt/sre/lib/std.py`)

`machine_config(net_scheme, machine_name, config)` — concise helper for wiring a machine inside `NetScheme.build()` (or `initial()`). `config` is a `(interfaces, sysctls)` tuple:

- `interfaces`: list of `(network_name, address, routes)` entries, where `routes` is a list of `(dest_network, gateway)` pairs.
- `sysctls`: dict of kernel parameter names to values.

Compared to calling `set_net_config` and `set_sysctl` directly, `machine_config` resolves network names through the `NetScheme` topology automatically.

4.9.9 Miscellaneous generators (from `/opt/sre/lib/utils.py`)

```
from utils import random_password, random_sentence
```

Function	Description
`random_password(len`	Returns a random alphanumeric password of the given length
`random_sentence(len`	Returns a random sequence of lowercase words, space-separated, approximately `length` characters long

4.9.10 Network inspection helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/net_config.py`)

These functions are used inside `Grade.grade()` to read live container state.

```
from net_config import (get_ip_addresses, get_routes, get_sysctl_conf,
                        get_net_config_entry, get_persistent_net_config_entry,
                        eval_net_config, net_config_entry_family,
                        get_ip_forward, get_ipv6_forward, get_sys_parameter_bool,
                        get_sys_parameter)
```

Function	Returns	Description
`get_ip_addresses(g machine, step=1, ipv6=False, link_local=False)`	`dict[str, list[tuple[ int]]]`	Run `ip a`; return `{iface: [(addr, prefixlen), ...]}` (sorted by prefix desc, addr asc). `ipv6=True` adds the IPv6 addresses after the IPv4 ones (SLAAC addresses included, temporary ones excluded; link-local ones only with `link_local=True`)
`get_routes(grade, machine, step=1, ipv6=False)`	`dict[tuple[ int], tuple[str, str,int]]`	Run `ip route` (and `ip -6 route` with `ipv6=True`); return `{(net, mask): (via, dev, metric)}` — `default` maps to `('0.0.0.0', 0)` (`('::', 0)` in the IPv6 table)
`get_sysctl_conf(gr machine, step=1)`	`dict[str, str]`	Read `/etc/sysctl.conf` and `/etc/sysctl.d/*.conf`; return `{key: value}`
`get_ip_forward(gra machine, step=1)`	`bool`	Read `/proc/sys/net/ipv4/ip_forward`; return `True` if `1`
`get_ipv6_forward(g machine, step=1)`	`bool`	Read `/proc/sys/net/ipv6/conf/all/forwarding`; return `True` if `1`
`get_sys_parameter( machine, param, step=1)`	`str | None`	Read an arbitrary `/proc/sys/...` file (e.g. `'net.ipv4.ip_forward'`); return string value or `None`
`get_sys_parameter_ machine, param, step=1)`	`bool | None`	Same as `get_sys_parameter` but cast to `bool` (`'1'` → `True`, `'0'` → `False`, else `None`)
`get_net_config_ent machine, step=1, ipv6=False)`	`NetConfigEn`	Run `ip a` + `ip route`; reconstruct a `NetConfigEntry` from live state. `ipv6=True` adds the IPv6 addresses and routes to the same entries (a SLAAC address counts as dynamic: an interface with only SLAAC addresses is `'dhcp'`; the RA default route has a `fe80::` next hop)
`get_persistent_net machine, step=1, ipv6=False)`	`tuple[NetCo int]`	Parse `/etc/network/interfaces`; return `(entry, n_errors)`. `ipv6=True` also parses the `inet6 static` stanzas (`address`, `netmask <prefixlen>`, `gateway`, `post-up ip [-6] route add` / `ip addr add`; 'inet6 auto
`net_config_entry_f version)`	`NetConfigEn`	Keep only the addresses and routes of IP `version` (4 or 6) in each tuple, to grade the two families of a dual-stack configuration apart

`eval_net_config(grade, expected, machine_name=None, current=None, step=1)` — compare a live or provided `NetConfigEntry` against an expected one (`0.0.0.0/0` and `::/0` are both default routes). Returns an attribute-accessible dict with the following keys:

Key	Description
`ips`	Number of IP addresses that match
`ips_expected`	Number of IP addresses in expected
`default_route`	`1` if the default route matches, `0` otherwise
`default_route_expected`	`1` if expected has a default route
`other_routes`	Number of matching non-default static routes
`other_routes_expected`	Number of non-default routes in expected
`wrong_routes`	Non-default routes present in current but not in expected
`dhcp_interfaces`	Number of positions where both expected and current are `'dhcp'`
`dhcp_interfaces_expected`	Count of `'dhcp'` entries in expected
`none_interfaces_expected`	Count of `None` entries in expected

If `current` is `None`, `get_net_config_entry(grade, machine_name, step)` is called automatically.

4.9.11 Switch helpers (from /opt/sre/lib/switch.py)

For the managed switches (see *Switches and VLANs*), on top of `Grade.test_switch()`:

```
from switch import get_switch_ports, get_switch_vlans

ports = get_switch_ports(self, 'lan')
# {'pc1': {'port': 2, 'interface': 'eth0', 'vlan': 10, 'tagged_vlans': []},
#  'r1':  {'port': 1, 'interface': 'eth0', 'vlan': 0,  'tagged_vlans': [10, 20]}}
same_vlan = bool(ports) and ports['pc1']['vlan'] == ports['pc2']['vlan']

vlans = get_switch_vlans(self, 'lan')      # {10: {'untagged': [2], 'tagged': [1]}, ...}␣
↪(port numbers)
```

`vlan` is the VLAN of the untagged frames of the port (0: the default VLAN of the switch), `tagged_vlans` the VLANs of a trunk port. Both functions return `{}` on the registration pass and when the console failed; they take `step=` and `allow_error=` like `test_switch()`. `parse_switch_ports(port_allprint, vlan_allprint)` and `parse_switch_vlans(vlan_allprint)` are the underlying pure parsers.

4.9.12 Ping helper (from /opt/sre/lib/ping.py)

```
from ping import eval_ping
```

`eval_ping(grade, src, dest, step=1, net_config=None, count=1, deadline=1, allow_error=False, ipv6=False)` → `bool` — run `ping -c count -w deadline dest` from `src` machine; return `True` if `"bytes from"` appears in the output. Raise `count` / `deadline` for multi-hop paths; `allow_error=True` keeps an expected failure out of the archive's errors.

`src` and `dest` can each be:

- An `IPv4Address` / `IPv6Address` (or Interface) object, or a valid IPv4 / IPv6 literal — used directly (the literal decides the family); `src` is resolved by reverse-lookup in `net_config`
- `"machine_name"` — machine name looked up in `net_config`; `dest` → first IPv4 address of the first interface, or first IPv6 address with `ipv6=True`
- `"machine_name:N"` or `"machine_name:ethN"` — resolves to interface index N of that machine (same family rule)

If `net_config` is not provided, `grade.net_scheme.net_config` is used. Raises `ValueError` on resolution failure.

4.9.13 SSH helpers (from /opt/sre/lib/ssh.py)

Used in `@sre_state` methods (state setup):

```
from ssh import (add_ssh_monitor_agent, create_ssh_key_on_host,
                 remove_ssh_password_authentication_on_sshd,
                 set_forward_ssh_agent_in_ssh_config, copy_ssh_pub_key_on_machine)
```

Function	Description
`add_ssh_monitor_agent(net_sc machine, step=1)`	Deploy and start an SSH monitor daemon on `machine`. It tails `/var/log/auth.log` and writes one line per forwarded-agent key to `/var/log/.ssh_monitor.log` when a user logs in via SSH. Used with `eval_ssh_connection_with_ssh_agent()`.
`create_ssh_key_on_host(net_s filename, bits=4096, key_type='rsa', password=None, step=1)`	Generate an SSH key pair on the **host** (`ssh-keygen`). Returns the `filename`.
`remove_ssh_password_authenti machine, restart_ssh=False, step=1)`	Set `PasswordAuthentication no` in `/etc/ssh/sshd_config`. Optionally restart sshd.
`set_forward_ssh_agent_in_ssh machine_name, step=1)`	Write `/etc/ssh/ssh_config.d/forward_agent.conf` with `ForwardAgent yes` for all hosts.
`copy_ssh_pub_key_on_machine( machine, pub_key, username, step=1)`	Copy a public key file (host path) into `~username/.ssh/authorized_keys` on `machine`.

Used in `Grade.grade()` (evaluation):

```
from ssh import (check_ssh_key, eval_ssh_public_key_in_authorized_keys,
                 eval_ssh_agent_exists, eval_ssh_agent_with_loaded_key,
                 eval_ssh_possible_with_password_authentification,
                 eval_ssh_connection_with_password, eval_ssh_connection_with_key,
                 eval_ssh_connection_with_ssh_agent, eval_synchronized_file)
```

Function	Returns	Description
`check_ssh_key(grade, machine, private_key, key_type='rsa', bits=4096, password=None, step=1)`	`bool`	Verify that a key pair on `machine` has the expected type, bit length, and passphrase. Public key expected at `private_key + '.pub'`.
`eval_ssh_public_key_in_authorize`	`bool`	Check that a public key appears in `~username/.ssh/authorized_keys` with correct ownership and restricted permissions. Provide either `public_key_file` (host path) or `public_key` (content string).
`machine, username, public_key_file=None, public_key=None, step=1)`		
`eval_ssh_agent_exists(grade, machine_name, username, step=1)`	`bool`	Return `True` if an `ssh-agent` process is running as `username` on `machine_name`.
`eval_ssh_agent_with_loaded_key(g`	`bool`	Check that a specific private key (on the host) is loaded in a running agent belonging to `username` on `machine_name`.
`machine_name, username, key_on_host, password=None, step=1)`		
`eval_ssh_possible_with_password_`	`bool`	Probe `dest_machine`'s sshd from `src_machine`; return `True` if password authentication is offered.
`src_machine, dest_machine, username='nobody', step=1)`		
`eval_ssh_connection_with_passwor`	`bool`	Read `/var/log/auth.log` on `machine_name`; return `True` if a successful password login for `username` is present.
`machine_name, username, step=1)`		
`eval_ssh_connection_with_key(gra`	`bool`	Read `/var/log/auth.log`; return `True` if a successful public-key login for `username` is present.
`machine_name, username, step=1)`		
`eval_ssh_connection_with_ssh_age`	`bool`	Read `/var/log/.ssh_monitor.log` (written by `add_ssh_monitor_agent`); return `True` if `username` logged in using an agent carrying `key_on_host`.
`machine_name, username, key_on_host, password=None, step=1)`		
`eval_synchronized_file(grade, machine_list, filename, step=1)`	`tuple[ str]`	Return `(True, content)` if `filename` has identical content and mtime on every machine in `machine_list`; `(False, '')` otherwise.

4.9.14 Packet capture helpers (from `/opt/sre/lib/pcap_gen.py`)

Used in `@sre_state` methods (state setup):

```
from pcap_gen import generate_pcap_tcp_example, setup_tcp_client_server
```

`generate_pcap_tcp_example(net_scheme, src_machine, dst_machine, dst_ip, dst_interface, output_file, dst_port_min=2000, dst_port_max=2999, payload_size=10, step=1) → dict`

Generate a synthetic TCP traffic capture for pcap analysis exercises. Uses 3 consecutive steps starting at `step`. The pcap file is written to `output_file` inside `dst_machine` (must be under `/shared/` for host-side analysis). Returns a dict with the captured port numbers and one TCP frame chosen from each direction:

Key	Description
`server_port`, `client_port`	TCP port numbers used
`packet_src_to_dst`	1-based frame number (src → dst direction)
`packet_src_to_dst_tcp_window`	TCP window field of that frame
`packet_src_to_dst_absolute_seq_number`	Absolute sequence number
`packet_src_to_dst_absolute_ack_number`	Absolute acknowledgment number
`packet_dst_to_src`	Same fields for the dst → src direction

The dict is populated at `step+2` via a host callback after the capture finishes.

`setup_tcp_client_server(net_scheme, src_machine, dst_machine, src_ip, dst_ip, secret, dst_port_min=3000, dst_port_max=3999, interval=3, step=1) → dict`

Deploy a persistent background TCP client/server pair for generating live traffic throughout the lab. Uses 2 steps. The server runs on `dst_machine`, the client on `src_machine`; both survive for the lifetime of the lab. Returns `{'server_port': int, 'client_port': int}`.

Used in `Grade.grade()` (evaluation):

```
from pcap_gen import check_zero_window_probe, get_frame_info
```

`check_zero_window_probe(grade, file, max_length, packet_number) → bool`

Return `True` if the packet at 1-based `packet_number` in the pcap file (relative to the project shared directory) is a valid TCP Zero Window Probe. Checks: file within `max_length` KiB; target packet has ≤ 1 byte payload; a prior packet in the reverse direction advertised window=0; target SEQ equals `SND.UNA` or `SND.UNA-1`.

`get_frame_info(grade, filename, max_length, frame_number) → dict | None`

Return all parsed fields for a single frame from a pcap file (relative to the project shared directory). Returns `None` if the file is missing, too large, not a valid pcap, or `frame_number` does not exist. The returned dict always contains `frame_number`, `frame_link_type`, `captured_length`, `original_length`, `timestamp_sec`, `timestamp_usec`; plus protocol-specific fields for Ethernet, Linux cooked capture, ARP, IPv4, IPv6, ICMP, TCP, and UDP headers.

4.10 Module-level Attributes

Declare these at the top level of `srelab.py` to customize behavior. They are read with `getattr(module, name, default)`, so any attribute may simply be omitted to keep the default.

4.10.1 Lab identity and presentation

Attribu	Type	Default	Description
`titl`	`str` | `Trans`	filename without `.py`	Lab title shown in the GUI tab header and in exported reports. Pass a `TranslatedText` (via `tr()` / `make_tr()`) for multilingual titles. The same title is also surfaced in the GUI's *Open project* picker and on the Open page of the web front-end once an admin has run `sre make-titles` to materialise per-directory `titles.json` sidecars, whose `"@sort"` option also chooses the order of the labs of a directory, by file name, by title or by hand (see `sre make-titles` in the CLI reference)
`defa`	`str`	`'en'`	Language code used to resolve `TranslatedText` values when the GUI's locale is unavailable and when `make_tr()` is called without an explicit `default_language=`

4.10.2 Student self-evaluation

Attribute	Type	Default	Description
allow_self_	bool	Fals	If True, students may trigger their own evaluation from the GUI
delay_betwe	int	0	Cooldown in seconds between two student self-evaluations (only enforced for sre --user eval --auto-eval, i.e. when the student presses **Start evaluation** in the GUI; periodic background evals do not count). The remaining delay is stored under params.self_grade_timestamp_dir (/var/lib/sre/last_self_grades/{lab_name})
no_mark_on_	bool	Fals	During a student-triggered evaluation, hide numeric grades and show only the OK / MEH / FAIL letters
hide_potent	bool	Fals	During a student-triggered evaluation, drop grade-list entries whose grade and max_grade are both 0 (i.e. penalty rubrics that have not yet fired). Has no effect on instructor-triggered evals

4.10.3 Automatic evaluation

Attribute	Type	Default	Description
eval_interval_	int	0	Auto-eval interval in seconds when no exam is configured. 0 disables periodic evaluation
eval_before_ex	bool	False	If True, run a final evaluation when the student closes the project
use_numerical_	bool	params.use_numerical_marks_by_ (True)	If False, the lab reports OK / MEH / FAIL letters instead of numeric scores
display_marks_	bool	params.display_marks_in_auto_e (False)	If False, the numeric mark is hidden from students during automatic (periodic) evaluations even when use_numerical_marks=True
maximum_mark	int | float	params.default_maximum_mark (20)	Upper bound used when normalizing the lab's total grade

4.10.4 Archives and recordings

Attribute	Type	Default	Description
archive_di	list	[]	Extra directories to write evaluation archives (.zst) to, in addition to params.archive_dirs
files_to_s	list	[]	Container paths whose contents are copied into each evaluation archive (under the files key). Useful for capturing config files, logs, or pcap traces produced by the student
record_ses	bool | None	None	Override whether terminal sessions opened from the GUI are recorded (asciinema). None defers to the global / exam setting
save_recor	list	[]	Extra directories to write session-record archives (.tar.gz) to during an exam, in addition to params.save_records_dir (/var/lib/sre/archives). Read by sre save-records and by the automatic save loop during eval-exam
save_recor	int	params.default_save_rec (60)	Minimum delay in seconds between two automatic session-record saves for the same project during an exam. Set to 0 to disable automatic saving for this lab

4.10.5 State machine and flavors

Attribute	Type	Default	Description
allow_user_	bool	Fals	If True, students can apply states decorated with @sre_state(user_allowed=True) from the GUI. States decorated with user_allowed=False remain instructor-only
flavor_form	bool	Fals	If True and a Flavor subclass is defined, the GUI shows the flavor form before calling sre start, letting the student parameterize the lab

4.10.6 Networking

Attribute	Type	Default	Description
ipv6	bool	params.default_ipv6 (None: Kathara's own setting, off)	If True, IPv6 is enabled in every machine (disable_ipv6=0, forwarding and accept_ra=0 set by Kathara); Machine(ipv6=...) overrides it per machine. The effective value is written to the lab.conf of sre export. See *IPv6 labs*

4.10.7 Filesystem and export

Attribute	Type	Default	Description
`shared_`	`bool`	`Fals`	Create `/home/sre/{running_lab_name}/` (mode `0o777`) and bind-mount it into each container for file exchange between host and containers
`export_`	`bool`	`True`	If `False`, disable **File → Export Kathara Project** in the GUI and refuse `sre export` for this lab
`export_`	`bool`	`True`	If `False`, disable **File → Export Schema to PDF** in the GUI: the drawing of the *Schema* tab (the visible machines only, with the tab's lines / spacing / order / icons settings) written to a PDF by graphviz. See *Exporting a project*
`allow_`	`bool`	`Fals`	If `True`, students may save a running project to a file (**File → Save Project**, `sre save`) and restore it later as a new instance (**File → Restore Project**, `sre restore`). The save file holds `data.json` and `.private/files` — in clear unless `save_key` is set — so enable it only for labs whose `Data` holds nothing the student must not read, or set `save_key`
`save_k`	`str`	*(unset)*	Non-empty secret string. When set, the payload of every save file is encrypted (AES-256-GCM, key derived from `save_key`); only a lab with the same key can restore it, and students cannot restore cleartext files. Keep the lab file unreadable by students

4.10.8 Schema rendering

These attributes tweak the graphviz topology diagram drawn for the GUI's *Schema* tab and embedded in the PDF produced by `sre export`.

Attribute	Type	Default	Description
`show_nat_netwo`	`bool`	`params.default_show_nat_netw` (`True`)	If `False`, hide the host-network vertex even when machines are marked `bridged=True`
`host_network_r`	`str`	`params.default_host_network_` (`"Internet"`)	Label shown on the host-network vertex
`host_network_c`	`str`	`params.default_host_network_` (`"deepskyblue"`)	Fill color of the host-network vertex (graphviz color name or `#rrggbb`)
`host_network_e`	`bool`	`params.default_host_network_` (`False`)	If `True`, draw one separate host-network vertex per `bridged=True` machine instead of a single shared one
`host_network_e`	`floa`	`params.default_host_network_` (`1.0`)	Relative length (graphviz `len`) applied to edges between `bridged=True` machines and the host vertex. `< 1` shortens them, `> 1` lengthens them
`schema_splines`	`str`	`params.graphviz_default_spli` (`"curved"`)	Graphviz `splines` attribute (e.g. `"line"`, `"ortho"`, `"curved"`, `"polyline"`)
`schema_overlap`	`str`	`params.graphviz_default_over` (`"prism"`)	Graphviz `overlap` attribute controlling how the layout resolves node overlaps

4.11 Complete Minimal Example

```
# /opt/sre/lab/example/srelab.py

from dataclasses import dataclass
from ipaddress import IPv4Interface, IPv4Network
from typing import Dict

from SRE.lib_sre import Data0, NetScheme0, Grade0, sre_state, make_tr
from ips import random_ipv4networks, random_ipv4s
from net_config import set_net_config_entry, NetConfigEntry,␣
↪get_net_config_from_topology, set_ip_forward
from state_helpers import set_nat_gateway

tr = make_tr('en')
title = tr("Example: Router", fr="Exemple : Routeur")
allow_self_grade = True
delay_between_self_grade = 60
eval_interval_without_exam_mode = 120


@dataclass(slots=True)
class Data(Data0):
    @classmethod
    def generate(cls, flavor=None):
        d = cls()
        d.nets.lan1, d.nets.lan2 = random_ipv4networks([24, 24],␣
↪from_private_network=True)
        d.ips.router_lan1, d.ips.client1 = random_ipv4s(d.nets.lan1, 2)    #␣
↪IPv4Interface values
        d.ips.router_lan2, d.ips.client2 = random_ipv4s(d.nets.lan2, 2)
        return d


class NetScheme(NetScheme0):
    _machine_specs = {
        'router': {'color': 'green'},
        'client1': {},
        'client2': {},
    }
    _network_specs = {
        'lan1': {'color': 'yellow'},
        'lan2': {'color': 'cyan'},
    }
    _topology = {
        'lan1': ['router', 'client1'],
        'lan2': ['router', 'client2'],
    }

    def __init__(self, data, running_lab_name):
        super().__init__(data=data, running_lab_name=running_lab_name)
        self.informations = tr(
            "## Router Lab\nConfigure routing between lan1 and lan2.",
```

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```
            fr="## TP Routage\nConfigurez le routage entre lan1 et lan2.",
        )
        d = data
        self.net_config = get_net_config_from_topology(net_scheme=self, gateway="router")
        # self.net_config: Dict[str, NetConfigEntry] = {
        #     'router': [([d.ips.router_lan1], [(d.nets.lan2, d.ips.router_lan2)]),
        #                ([d.ips.router_lan2], [])],
        #     'client1': [([d.ips.client1], [(IPv4Network('0.0.0.0/0'),␣
↪d.ips.router_lan1)])],
        #     'client2': [([d.ips.client2], [(IPv4Network('0.0.0.0/0'),␣
↪d.ips.router_lan2)])],
        # }

    @sre_state(user_allowed=False)
    def initial(self):
        for machine, config in self.net_config.items():
            set_net_config_entry(net_scheme=self, machine_name=machine, nc_entry=config)
        self.cmd('router', 'sysctl -w net.ipv4.ip_forward=1')
        for m in self.get_visible_machine_names():
            set_ip_forward(net_scheme=self, machine_name=m, ip_forward=(m == "router"))
        set_nat_gateway(net_scheme=self, machine="router")



class Grade(Grade0):
    def grade(self):
        super().grade()
        d = self.data

        # Test cross-network reachability
        result, code = self.test('client1', f'ping -c1 -W2 {d.ips.router_lan2.ip}',␣
↪timeout=5)
        self.add_grade_element('Cross-network ping', max_grade=10)
        if code == 0:
            self.set_grade('Cross-network ping', 10)

        # Ask a question
        answer = self.question_text(
            title=tr('Routing protocol', fr='Protocole de routage'),
            description=tr('Which mechanism routes packets between the two LANs?',
                           fr='Quel mécanisme route les paquets entre les deux LANs ?'),
        )
        self.add_grade_element('Routing answer', max_grade=5)
        if 'ip_forward' in answer or 'forward' in answer.lower():
            self.set_grade('Routing answer', 5)
```

4.12 The list of labs

Everything a student can open comes from one tree, `/opt/sre/lab/` (`params.lab_dir`), walked by `sre list` and shown as a tree by the *Open project* dialog of the GUI (*Opening a project*) and by the Open page of the *web front-end*. This section gathers what decides which labs are listed, under which name, and in which order.

4.12.1 What is a lab, and its name

- A **file lab** is any `.py` file of the tree (`s2/lab.py`, `sre/dhcp.py`).
- A **directory lab** is a directory holding a `srelab.py`, with its state directories next to it (`s4/tp_ssh/`); nothing below it is scanned.
- Any other directory only groups labs, as deep as you like (`class1/week3/tp_arp`). A directory without a lab below it is not listed.

The name of a lab is its path relative to the tree, with the `.py` of a file lab: it is what `sre start`, `sre set-exam --labs` and the web API take, and what the running lab name carries. The shipped labs live in `lab/sre/` (a symbolic link to `/usr/share/sysreseval/lab` on a Debian install: links to directories are followed); `sre update` replaces that directory and leaves the others alone.

4.12.2 Exam-only labs

A lab whose name, or the name of any directory above it, contains `_EXAM_`, `_OLD_`, `_DRAFT_` or `_TESTS_` (`params.exam_only_affix`) is left out of `sre list` and of both pickers, and the directory is not even walked. It stays usable by the privileged commands (`sre start s4/ssh_EXAM_final.py`, `sre check`) and by `sre set-exam --labs`, which is how an exam lab stays invisible until the exam starts, and how a draft stays out of the students' sight: see *Exam-only labs*.

4.12.3 Titles: `sre make-titles` and `titles.json`

The pickers show a lab by its `title` attribute (a string or a `tr()` text) instead of its file name once the titles are materialised: each directory of the tree may hold a `titles.json` mapping the local names of its entries (`"dhcp.py"`, `"tp_ssh"`) to a title, a plain string or a `{lang: text}` dict resolved in the language of the user. `sre make-titles -r /opt/sre/lab` (as root) imports every lab, exam-only ones included, and writes one file per directory; run it again after adding or renaming labs: a rerun keeps the options and the order of an existing file, replaces the titles of the labs found, drops the entries that name nothing on disk any more and appends the new labs by name. A lab without `title` is shown by its file name without `.py`. The title of a running project (the tab, the reports) comes from the lab itself through `info.json`, not from `titles.json`.

4.12.4 The order of a directory: `"@sort"`

Written by hand in the `titles.json` of a directory, the reserved key `"@sort"` chooses the order of the entries of that directory, the same in the GUI and on the web (every key starting with `@` is an option, never an entry):

Value	Order of the entries
`"nam`	By file name, byte-wise (capitals first). The default.
`"tit`	By title in the language of the user (the language priority of the GUI, the language of the page on the web): case and accents ignored, numbers compared as numbers so that "TP 2" comes before "TP 10"; an entry without title sorts by its name.
`"man`	The entries of the file in their order, then the unlisted ones by name.

In every mode the sub-directories come first, then the labs. A directory without the option takes the one of the nearest ancestor: `/opt/sre/lab/titles.json` sets the whole tree, a sub-directory may override it. A key may also name a sub-directory, with a title (shown instead of the directory name) or `null` (listed for its place in the manual order only); this is the way to order a level that holds directories only, such as the root. An unknown value is ignored; `sre make-titles` warns about it and keeps the file as it is.

```
{
  "@sort": "manual",
  "sre":               {"en": "Shipped labs",   "fr": "TP fournis"},
  "s4":                null,
  "static_routing.py": {"en": "Static routing", "fr": "Routage statique"},
  "tp_ssh":            null
}
```

What the pickers receive is `sre list --with-titles`: the tree flattened in display order, a directory entry before its content, each entry with its `title`, its `kind` (`dir` / `lab`) and the `sort` mode it is placed by; the front-ends keep that order and only sort the `"title"` mode themselves (see `sre list` and `sre make-titles` in the *CLI reference*).

CHAPTER

FIVE

HUBS, SWITCHES AND VLANS

Every network of a lab connects its machines through one of three kinds of equipment. The lab chooses the kind per network; a network the lab says nothing about is a hub, as all networks were before this choice existed.

Kind	`mode` in the lab	Name in the GUI	What it does
Hub	`'hub'` (default)	*Hub*	Every frame is sent to every machine of the network: any machine can capture the traffic of the others (`tcpdump`, Wireshark).
Switch	`'switch`	*Switch*	The switch learns the MAC addresses and sends a frame to its destination only: a machine sees its own traffic and the broadcasts. No configuration, no console.
Manageable switch	`'manage`	*Manageable switch*	A switch with VLANs (access and trunk ports) and a management console, which the students may open unless the lab closes it.

This page describes the feature as a whole. The reference tables of the lab API are in the *Lab Authoring Guide*, the commands in the *CLI Reference*, and the plugin a host needs for switches in *Installation*.

5.1 In the GUI

5.1.1 The Networks tab

A project always shows a **Networks** tab, after **Machines**, whatever the types of its networks. The tab lists every network the student can see — hubs included — with three columns:

Column	Content
Name	Name of the network, as on the schema.
Type	*Hub*, *Switch* or *Manageable switch*. On a red background for a manageable switch whose console the lab closed to the students.
Connection	A green *Connect* button for a manageable switch the students may use. Empty otherwise: a hub or a plain switch has no console, and a closed manageable switch is not offered.

Connect opens the management console of the switch in an external terminal, like the *Connect* button of the **Machines** tab does for a machine. Each click opens a new terminal.

The **Terminals** tab also holds one embedded terminal per manageable switch the students may use, next to those of the machines.

A network that only connects hidden machines is not listed.

In a debug project (`sre start --debug-project`) every network is listed, and the manageable switches the lab closed to the students can be used all the same: their type stays red, but they get an orange *Connect* button in the Networks tab and a terminal in the Terminals tab, whose title is orange like the title of a machine the students cannot connect to.

5.1.2 The console of a manageable switch

The console is the management console of the underlying `vde_switch`. The prompt is the name of the network; `exit`, `quit` or Ctrl-D leave it.

```
lan$ vlan/print
VLAN 0010
 -- Port 0001 tagged=1 active=1 status=Forwarding
 -- Port 0002 tagged=0 active=1 status=Forwarding
VLAN 0020
 -- Port 0001 tagged=1 active=1 status=Forwarding
 -- Port 0003 tagged=0 active=1 status=Forwarding
lan$ port/print
Port 0001 untagged_vlan=0000 ACTIVE - NOT Unnamed Allocatable
 Current User: root Access Control: (User: NONE - Group: NONE)
  -- endpoint ID 0003 module unix prog   : kathara r1:eth0 user=0 pid=64086
Port 0002 untagged_vlan=0010 ACTIVE - NOT Unnamed Allocatable
 Current User: root Access Control: (User: NONE - Group: NONE)
  -- endpoint ID 0008 module unix prog   : kathara pc1:eth0 user=0 pid=64086
...
lan$ port/setvlan 3 10
lan$ exit
```

Command	Effect
`help`	List of the commands of the switch.
`port/print`, `port/allprint`	Ports in use / every port: the VLAN of its untagged frames (`untagged_vlan`) and what is plugged into it (`kathara <machine>:eth<N>`).
`vlan/print`, `vlan/allprint`	VLANs with their ports; `tagged=1` marks a trunk member, `tagged=0` an access port.
`vlan/create <vlan>`, `vlan/remove <vlan>`	Create / remove a VLAN.
`port/setvlan <port> <vlan>`	Put a port in a VLAN for its untagged frames (access port).
`vlan/addport <vlan> <port>`, `vlan/delport <vlan> <port>`	Add / remove a port as tagged member of a VLAN (trunk port).
`hash/print`, `hash/find <mac>`	MAC address table.
`fstp/setfstp <0|1>`, `fstp/print`	Spanning tree on / off, and its state.

Things to know:

- **Port numbers are not predictable.** They are given when the project starts: read them with `port/print`, where each port names the machine interface plugged into it.

- **VLAN 0 is the default VLAN** of the switch: a port the lab did not put in a VLAN is there, untagged, with every other such port.
- **A command the switch refuses** prints its error after `error:` (for instance `error: File exists` when creating a VLAN that exists) and the session goes on.
- **Students get a subset of the commands.** Through the GUI (user mode) only the commands of `params.switch_user_commands` reach the switch: those of the table above, `showinfo`, `port/showinfo`, `hash/showinfo`, `fstp/showinfo`, `fstp/setedge` and `fstp/bonus`. Any other one — creating or removing ports, loading plugins, shutting the switch down… — is answered `error: command '…' is not allowed` without being sent. A privileged user (`sre connect` from a root shell) is not restricted.
- **The console ends with the project.** When the project is closed (**File → Close Project**, `sre stop`, `sre wipe`) an open console prints *The project was closed* and ends within a second, so its terminal closes like the terminal of a machine.
- **What is typed on the console is not saved** with **File → Save Project**: a restored project gets the switches as the lab declares them (see *Limits*).

5.2 In a lab

5.2.1 Declaring the kind of a network

The kind of a network and, for a manageable switch, its VLANs and the access to its console are given in `_network_specs`. `_topology` keeps its syntax, and a network without entry — or without `mode` — is a hub.

```
class NetScheme(NetScheme0):
    _machine_specs = {'pc1': {}, 'pc2': {}, 'r1': {}, 'r2': {}, 'srv': {}}
    _network_specs = {
        'lan': {'mode': 'managed',                          # manageable switch
                'allow_connection': False,                  # students may not open its␣
↪console (default: True)
                'vlans': {'pc1': 10,                        # access port: untagged␣
↪frames in VLAN 10
                          'pc2': 20,
                          'r1': [10, 20],                   # trunk port: VLANs 10 and␣
↪20, tagged
                          'r2': {'vlan': 1, 'trunk': [30]}}},  # native VLAN 1 + VLAN 30␣
↪tagged
        'dmz': {'mode': 'switch'},                          # switch without VLAN nor␣
↪console
    }
    _topology = {
        'lan': ['pc1', 'pc2', 'r1', 'r2'],
        'dmz': ['r1', 'srv'],
        'old': ['srv', 'pc2'],                              # no entry in _
↪network_specs: a hub
    }
```

Key	Default	Meaning
`mode`	`'hub'`	`'hub'`, `'switch'` or `'managed'`.
`allow_cor`	`True`	Manageable switch only: the students may open its console. `False` shows the type of the switch in red in the Networks tab, without *Connect* button, and makes `sre connect` refuse them.
`vlans`	`{}`	Manageable switch only: the VLANs of the ports, by machine name.

The value given for a machine in `vlans` describes its port:

Value	Port
`10`	Access port: the untagged frames of the machine are in VLAN 10.
`[10, 20]`	Trunk port: the machine exchanges the frames of VLANs 10 and 20 with 802.1Q tags. Its untagged frames stay in the default VLAN.
`{'vlan': 1, 'trunk': [10, 20]}`	Both: native (untagged) VLAN 1 and tagged VLANs 10 and 20.

Rules:

- VLAN IDs go from 1 to 4094, and a VLAN cannot be both the untagged and a tagged VLAN of one port.
- A machine `vlans` does not name stays in the default VLAN of the switch (VLAN 0), with every other undeclared port.
- On a trunk port the machine handles the tags itself, typically with one sub-interface per VLAN — the classic *router on a stick*:

```
self.cmd('r1', 'ip link add link eth0 name eth0.10 type vlan id 10')
self.cmd('r1', f'ip addr add {d.ips.r1_vlan10} dev eth0.10')
self.cmd('r1', 'ip link set eth0.10 up')
```

- A switch that is not a hub drops the tagged frames of a VLAN the port is not a member of: a trunk between two machines needs a hub, or a manageable switch with trunk ports — not a plain `'switch'`.
- An unknown `mode`, `vlans` on a network that is not manageable, a machine that is not on the network or an invalid VLAN ID raise `ValueError` when the `NetScheme` is built: `sre check` reports them before any start.

5.2.2 Running switch commands from a state

`self.switch_cmd(network, command, step=1, default_value='', default_code=0, allow_error=False)` runs one command of the console of a manageable switch when the state is applied. Since port numbers are not known in advance, a word `@machine` in the command stands for the number of the port that machine is plugged into:

```
@sre_state(user_allowed=True, description="pc2 joins VLAN 10")
def move(self):
    self.switch_cmd('lan', 'vlan/create 10', allow_error=True)   # code 17: the VLAN␣
↪already exists
    self.switch_cmd('lan', 'port/setvlan @pc2 10')
```

It follows the contract of `host_cmd()`: it returns `(output, code)`, a placeholder until the command has run (the real result is visible in a `multi_pass` state). `code` is `0`, the error number given by the switch, or `-2` when the command could not be run at all (console unreachable, unknown `@machine`). The switch commands of a step run with its host operations, in registration order, before the operations on the containers. See *Switch operations*.

5.2.3 Grading the configuration of a switch

`self.test_switch(network, command, step=1, ...)` registers a console command in `grade()` like `self.test()` does for a machine, and returns `(output, code)` on the following pass. The helpers of `lib/switch.py` turn the port and VLAN tables into something directly usable:

```
from switch import get_switch_ports, get_switch_vlans

class Grade(Grade0):
    def grade(self):
        super().grade()
        ports = get_switch_ports(self, 'lan')
        # {'pc1': {'port': 2, 'interface': 'eth0', 'vlan': 10, 'tagged_vlans': []},
        #  'r1':  {'port': 1, 'interface': 'eth0', 'vlan': 0,  'tagged_vlans': [10, 20]}}
        in_vlan_10 = ports.get('pc2', {}).get('vlan') == 10
        self.add_grade_element(title='pc2 in VLAN 10', grade=int(in_vlan_10),␣
↪max_grade=1)

        vlans = get_switch_vlans(self, 'lan')   # {10: {'untagged': [2], 'tagged': [1]},␣
↪...} (port numbers)
```

Both helpers return `{}` on the registration pass and when the console failed. The results are archived with the tests of the machines, under the name of the network, so `sre cat`, `sre re-eval` and `sre check-eval` handle them like any other test. Behavioural checks (a ping between two machines of a VLAN, a capture on a third machine) remain the most robust way to grade what the students were asked to obtain; reading the switch tells *how* they obtained it. See *Switch helpers*.

5.2.4 A complete example

`lab/sre/_DRAFT_dummy/switch_example.py` uses everything above in one small lab: a hub, a switch and two manageable switches (one open, one closed), access ports and a trunk port with a router on a stick, two states built on `switch_cmd()`, questions about what a third machine sees on the hub and on the switch, and a grade reading the VLANs from the switch. It is in a `_DRAFT_` directory: start it as a privileged user with `sre start sre/_DRAFT_dummy/switch_example.py`.

5.3 On the command line

Command	With a switch
`sre connect <running_lab> <network>`	Opens the console of a manageable switch. In user mode: the allowed commands only, and refused when the lab closed the console (`allow_connection`) or when the network only connects hidden machines — unless the project is a debug project.
`sre exec <running_lab> <network> <command…>`	Privileged: runs one console command and exits with 0 or the error number of the switch, e.g. `sre exec <running_lab> lan port/setvlan @pc2 10`.
`sre check <lab> [<state>]`	Prints the kind of each network that is not a hub with the declared VLANs, and the switch commands of the states.
`sre export <running_lab>`	Writes the kinds and the VLANs in `lab.conf`: `pc1[0]="lan/vlan=10"`, `r1[0]="lan/trunk=10,20"`, `CD_MODE[lan]="managed"`. This syntax is the one of the Kathara fork SRE installs.

A hub or a plain switch has no console: `sre connect` and `sre exec` answer `device <network> is a hub: it has no console`.

In a debug project, and for the states of a project in instructor mode, the **Log** tab shows the switch commands a state or an evaluation ran, as `stepN - on switch <network> : <command>` followed by the output and the exit code.

5.4 Limits

- **Save and restore.** A save file keeps the kind of each network and the declared VLANs, not what was changed on a console afterwards: a restored project starts again from the lab's declaration. A lab for which this matters re-applies its own configuration in its `restore` state with `switch_cmd()`.
- **Schema.** The schema draws every network the same way, whatever its kind; the Networks tab tells them apart.
- **Trunks through a plain switch.** See the rules above: use a hub or a manageable switch.
- **Rates.** Links are user-space switches (about 45–50 Mbit/s in TCP), whatever the kind.

5.5 What a host needs

Hubs work everywhere. Switches and manageable switches need the Kathara fork SRE installs (`make venv`) and its VDE network plugin, which `make network-plugin` installs in place of the stock plugin — once per host, see *Installation*. On a host that only has the stock plugin, starting a lab with a switch fails cleanly: nothing is left running and the message names the networks concerned and the command to run.

```
sre: Collision domain `sw` cannot be deployed in `switch` mode: the Kathara Network␣
↪Plugin `kathara/katharanp_vde:amd64` does not support it. Use an up-to-date VDE␣
↪version of the plugin.
This lab has networks that are not hubs (lan, dmz, sw): they need the Kathara network␣
↪plugin with the switch types.
Install it with `make network-plugin` in /opt/sre (see the installation guide).
```

5.6 Tests

- Unit tests (no Docker): `tests/test_switch_modes.py` (declaration, deployment calls, `switch_cmd()`, `test_switch()`), `tests/test_switch_console.py` (console, allowed commands, `sre connect` / `sre exec`), `tests/test_switch_lib.py` (helpers of `lib/switch.py`), `tests/test_gui_switches_view.py` (Networks tab).
- Live tests (`make docker-tests`, real containers): `TestHub` checks that a third machine captures the traffic of a hub — it runs with any plugin — and `TestSwitchModes` that it does not on a switch nor inside a VLAN of a manageable switch, plus VLAN isolation, the console, a state, grading, export and save / restore. `TestSwitchModes` is skipped on a host without the plugin with the switch types.

CHAPTER

SIX

TRANSLATING A LAB

6.1 Internationalization with `tr()` / `make_tr()`

```
from SRE.lib_sre import make_tr

default_language = 'en'
tr = make_tr(default_language)

title = tr("SSH Lab", fr="TP SSH")
# In NetScheme.__init__:
self.informations = tr("## Description\nConfigure SSH.",
                       fr="## Description\nConfigurez SSH.")
```

`tr(default, **lang_overrides)` returns a `TranslatedText` dict subclass. Call `.resolve('fr')` to get the string for a given language.

`make_tr(default_lang, translations=None)` returns a `tr()` function bound to *default_lang* as the key for the first positional argument. When `translations=` is omitted, the caller module's globals are inspected for a `_TRANSLATIONS` dict at each call; pass it explicitly to avoid relying on module-level state.

6.2 Marking strings that must NOT be translated: `no_tr()`

```
from SRE.lib_sre import no_tr

label = no_tr("MTU")              # short internal label, identical in every language
```

`no_tr()` is an identity passthrough at runtime — it returns the string unchanged. Its sole purpose is to flag a literal so the translation toolchain leaves it alone: it is never wrapped in `tr()` and never registered in `_TRANSLATIONS`. Use it for short internal labels (grade-element titles, protocol names, command names) that are not natural-language prose.

By default, `prepare-sre-translations` already wraps any whitespace-free single-token bare string in `no_tr()` rather than `tr()` (see `--translate-isolated-words` below to override).

6.3 Centralizing translations with `_TRANSLATIONS`

For labs with many strings, keeping translations inline in every `tr()` call becomes unwieldy. The `_TRANSLATIONS` dict centralises them all in one place:

```
from SRE.lib_sre import make_tr

default_language = 'en'
tr = make_tr(default_language)

_TRANSLATIONS = {
    'fr': {
        "SSH Lab":                  "TP SSH",
        "Configure the SSH server": "Configurez le serveur SSH.",
        "SSH port":                 None,   # not yet translated
    },
}

title       = tr("SSH Lab")
description = tr("Configure the SSH server")
```

`None` marks a string that still needs translation; `tr()` falls back to the default-language text in that case.

You can pass the dict explicitly to `make_tr()`, which avoids any reliance on module-level state:

```
tr = make_tr('en', translations=_TRANSLATIONS)
```

6.3.1 Where to put _TRANSLATIONS

Two valid placements; the choice affects which `tr()` calls can resolve translations at import time.

At the top of the file (default for `prepare-sre-translations`): `_TRANSLATIONS` is defined right after `tr = make_tr(...)`, before any `tr()` call. Every `tr()` call — including module-level and class-body ones evaluated at import time — can look up its translation. Inline `fr=`/`de=`/… kwargs are not needed.

At the end of the file (`prepare-sre-translations --translations-at-the-end`): `_TRANSLATIONS` lives at the very bottom, out of the way of the lab code. Because Python evaluates the module top-to-bottom, any `tr()` call in the module body or in class bodies runs *before* `_TRANSLATIONS` exists. To keep those import-time calls correct, `prepare-sre-translations` keeps (and re-adds on each run) inline lang kwargs on every such call. `tr()` calls inside method bodies — which only run at lab-execution time — do not need the kwargs and remain bare.

6.3.2 Dynamic strings with format placeholders

For strings that embed runtime values, use `{placeholder}` syntax in `_TRANSLATIONS` values and call `.format()` on the result:

```
_TRANSLATIONS = {
    'fr': {
        "The machine {machine} is configured": "La machine {machine} est configurée",
    },
}

msg = tr("The machine {machine} is configured").format(machine=m)
```

The static key `"The machine {machine} is configured"` is what `tr()` looks up in `_TRANSLATIONS`; `.format()` applies `str.format` to every language value at once and returns a new `TranslatedText`.

This is the equivalent of the inline f-string form:

```
msg = tr(f"The machine {m} is configured",
         fr=f"La machine {m} est configurée")
```

The inline f-string form still works and is fine for one-off strings. Use `_TRANSLATIONS` + `.format()` when the same template appears in many places, or when you want the translation toolchain (`check-sre-translations`, `add-sre-translations`) to see the string as a static literal.

6.4 Translation toolchain

Three command-line tools manage the complete translation lifecycle.

6.4.1 1. `prepare-sre-translations` — migrate and scaffold

`sbin/prepare-sre-translations` reads a lab file and:

- wraps bare translatable strings (module-level `title`, `description`, `informations`, `lab_name`; `self.informations` / `self.description`; `title=`/`description=`/`informations=` kwargs; first positional arg of `question_text`/`question_form`/`question_dummy`/`add_grade_element`/`add_grade_part`) in `tr()` — or in `no_tr()` if the string is a single whitespace-free token
- recurses into `BinOp` (`"x" + var`) and `IfExp` (`"x" if c else "y"`) expressions in those positions, wrapping each leaf
- lowers bare f-strings to `tr("template").format(var=var, ...)`
- creates or updates `_TRANSLATIONS` with one entry per string per language (value `None` for strings not yet translated)
- inserts `tr = make_tr(...)` and the matching `from SRE.lib_sre import make_tr` (and `no_tr` if needed) if absent

```
prepare-sre-translations [--move-tr-strings] [--default-language xx]
                         [--change-default-language xx]
                         [--translations-at-the-end]
                         [--translate-isolated-words] file
```

Option	Effect
(no options)	Wrap bare strings; create/update `_TRANSLATIONS` after `tr = make_tr(...)`; infer default language from file or assume `en`
`--default-xx`	Declare (or confirm) the default language; error if the file already uses a different one
`--change-d xx`	Pivot the file's source language to `xx`: rewrite every `tr()` literal to its `xx` translation, re-key `_TRANSLATIONS` so the inner keys are the new source texts, and preserve the previous default as a regular language. Errors out if any `tr()` string lacks an `xx` translation, or any translatable string is still bare.
`--move-tr-`	Strip inline `fr=`/`de=`/… kwargs from existing `tr()` calls and move them into `_TRANSLATIONS`
`--translat`	Place `_TRANSLATIONS` at the very end of the file; keep/add inline lang kwargs on every import-time `tr()` call (module/class body) so they don't depend on the late definition
`--translat`	Also wrap whitespace-free single-token strings in `tr()` (default: wrap them in `no_tr()`)

`--default-language` and `--change-default-language` are mutually exclusive.

Strings already wrapped in `no_tr(...)` are left untouched: never wrapped in `tr()` and never added to `_TRANSLATIONS`.

Typical first run on an existing lab:

```
# Wrap bare strings, declare the language, migrate inline kwargs:
sbin/prepare-sre-translations --default-language en --move-tr-strings lab/my_lab.py
```

The file is modified in-place. Run it repeatedly — it is idempotent: already-wrapped strings and existing translations are left unchanged.

6.4.2 2. `check-sre-translations` — verify consistency

`sbin/check-sre-translations` performs a static (AST-level) analysis and reports three categories of problem:

Category	Meaning
`MISSING`	String appears in a `tr()` call but has no entry in `_TRANSLATIONS`
`UNTRANSLATED`	Entry exists but its value is `None` (translation not yet done)
`VANISHED`	Entry exists in `_TRANSLATIONS` but no `tr()` call uses that string any more

```
sbin/check-sre-translations lab/my_lab.py
# lab/my_lab.py: MISSING       [fr] 'SSH port'
# lab/my_lab.py: UNTRANSLATED  [fr] 'Configure the SSH server'
# lab/my_lab.py: VANISHED      [de] 'Old string'
# lab/my_lab.py: ok (12 strings, ['fr', 'de'] languages)
```

Exit code is 0 if no issues are found, 1 otherwise. Suitable for CI.

Multiple files are accepted; let the shell expand globs:

```
sbin/check-sre-translations lab/s4/*.py
```

6.4.3 3. `add-sre-translations` — machine-translate missing strings

`sbin/add-sre-translations` calls an online translation service to fill in every `None` value for one target language, then writes the result back into the file.

```
add-sre-translations --language XX [--service YY]
    [--api-key KEY] [--credentials FILE] [--region REGION]
    [--libre-url URL] [--auto] file
```

Services (`--service`):

Service	Default credentials
`deepl` *(default)*	`--api-key` or `$DEEPL_API_KEY`
`google`	`--api-key` or `$GOOGLE_API_KEY` (REST); or `--credentials service-account.json` / `$GOOGLE_APPLICATION_CREDENTIALS`
`libre`	`--api-key` or `$LIBRE_API_KEY` (optional); `--libre-url` for a self-hosted instance (default: `https://libretranslate.com`)
`azure`	`--api-key` or `$AZURE_TRANSLATOR_KEY`; `--region` (default: `global`)
`amazon`	Standard AWS credential chain (`~/.aws/` or env vars); `--region` or `$AWS_DEFAULT_REGION`

Interactive mode (default when stdin is a TTY):

For each string the tool shows the machine translation and prompts:

```
[fr] 'SSH port'
     → 'Port SSH'
  Accept [Enter] or type correction (q to quit):
```

Press Enter to accept, type a correction, or `q` to stop early. Progress is always saved, even on Ctrl-C or an API error. Pass `--auto` to accept all suggestions without prompting.

Typical session:

```
export DEEPL_API_KEY=your-key-here

# Fill in French translations interactively:
sbin/add-sre-translations --language fr lab/my_lab.py

# Fill in German translations automatically:
sbin/add-sre-translations --language de --auto lab/my_lab.py

# Verify everything is done:
sbin/check-sre-translations lab/my_lab.py
```

6.5 Complete translation workflow

For a new lab starting from scratch in English:

```
# 1. Scaffold: wrap strings, create _TRANSLATIONS skeleton at the end of the file
sbin/prepare-sre-translations --default-language en --translations-at-the-end␣
↪lab/my_lab.py

# 2. Verify what needs translating
sbin/check-sre-translations lab/my_lab.py

# 3. Fill in French with interactive review
sbin/add-sre-translations --language fr lab/my_lab.py

# 4. Final check - should report no issues
sbin/check-sre-translations lab/my_lab.py
```

For a lab that already uses inline `tr("text", fr="traduction")` kwargs:

```
# Migrate inline kwargs into _TRANSLATIONS in one step
sbin/prepare-sre-translations --move-tr-strings lab/my_lab.py

# Review and fill in anything still missing
sbin/check-sre-translations lab/my_lab.py
sbin/add-sre-translations --language fr lab/my_lab.py
```

6.6 Switching the default language: `--change-default-language`

`prepare-sre-translations --change-default-language xx` pivots the file's source language to `xx`. The resulting file is *semantically equivalent* to the original — same translations, just keyed off a different source — and `check-sre-translations` should report it clean immediately after the pivot.

It performs four edits:

- `default_language = '...'` is set to `xx`;
- the literal first argument of `make_tr('...')` is set to `xx` (a `Name` arg like `make_tr(default_language)` is left as-is and inherits the new value);
- every `tr("old_text", ...)` call's first positional arg is replaced with its `xx` translation; the `xx=...` kwarg, if present, is dropped (it is now the default), and if the call had any inline language kwargs, the previous default is added as `<prev>="old_text"` to preserve the inline-kwarg style;
- `_TRANSLATIONS` is re-keyed: the inner keys flip from the previous source texts to the new `xx` source texts, the `xx` top-level entry disappears, and the previous default appears as a regular language entry mapping new-source → previous-source text.

6.6.1 Prerequisites

The pivot only runs if the file is already fully prepared and every `tr()` literal has an `xx` translation reachable via inline kwargs or `_TRANSLATIONS`. The script reports an error and leaves the file untouched when it finds any of:

- a `tr()` literal without an `xx` translation (`add-sre-translations --language xx` is the suggested fix);
- a `tr()` call whose first argument is not a string literal (variables, f-strings, expressions cannot be statically rewritten — lower or inline these first by running `prepare-sre-translations` without `--change-default-language`);
- a bare translatable string still waiting to be wrapped (same fix: run `prepare-sre-translations` without `--change-default-language` first).

`--change-default-language` is incompatible with `--default-language`, and rejects a pivot to the language that is already the file's default.

6.6.2 Example: switching to English as a pivot before translating

Machine-translation services produce noticeably better results when English is the source language, especially for less-common target pairs. If your lab is currently in another language but you want to pivot to English so every subsequent `add-sre-translations --language fr/de/es/...` call uses English as `source_lang`:

```
# 1. Fill in English translations first - these become the new source.
sbin/add-sre-translations --language en lab/my_lab.py

# 2. Pivot the file: tr() literals + _TRANSLATIONS keys + declarations all move to en.
sbin/prepare-sre-translations --change-default-language en lab/my_lab.py

# 3. Every add-sre-translations call now uses English as source_lang.
sbin/add-sre-translations --language fr lab/my_lab.py
sbin/add-sre-translations --language de lab/my_lab.py
sbin/add-sre-translations --language es lab/my_lab.py
```

CHAPTER

SEVEN

INSTALLATION AND SETUP

7.1 Prerequisites

- A Linux host. `scripts/install.sh` knows how to `apt-get install` missing packages on Debian and Ubuntu; on anything else you must install the prerequisites yourself.
- **Root** access. The installer refuses to start unless `EUID == 0` (run with `sudo`).
- The **Docker daemon running**, with `/var/run/docker.sock` present. The installer reads the socket's GID and grants the `sre` user access to it; if the socket is missing it aborts with a hint to start the daemon.
- **Python 3.13**. On Ubuntu < 24.04 you may need the `deadsnakes` PPA; on Debian < 13 you need to upgrade or build it from source. The installer will offer to `apt-get install python3.13` on Debian-likes.
- **AppArmor** (on by default on Debian and Ubuntu) needs no action: the Kathara fork runs the non-privileged machines with the Docker option `apparmor=unconfined`, because Docker's `docker-default` profile denies the remount of `/proc/sys` and every write under `/proc/sys/net/` (the `initial` state of a lab could not reset `ip_forward`, and the students could not set it either; Docker runs the privileged machines unconfined by itself). With a stock Kathara, boot the host with `apparmor=0` on the kernel command line instead.

These tools must already be on `PATH` (always present on a POSIX system): `sed grep stat getent useradd groupadd usermod install`.

These tools are auto-installed via `apt-get` on Debian-likes if missing:

- `docker` (any variety) `asciinema make gcc graphviz python3.13`

On other distributions install them with your package manager before running the installer.

7.2 Deployment layout

SRE's runtime root defaults to `/opt/sre`, but the installer makes it configurable. Clone the repo (`git clone https://github.com/sysreseval/sysreseval /opt/sre`) or untar the release into `/opt/sre` — or into any other location you prefer.

`scripts/install.sh` detects where it is being run from and offers that path as the default — `/opt/sre` when run from `/opt/sre/scripts/`, otherwise the parent of the script directory. The chosen value is patched into `src/SRE/params.py` (`main_sre_dir`) and substituted for `/opt/sre` in the sudoers rule, the `.desktop` file, and the `sre-preload-images.service` unit at install time.

The installer is **interactive** — it asks roughly ten configuration questions, then creates the `sre` user, installs a sudoers file, and runs the build — and is meant to be run **once per build**, not once per student workstation. The trick to scaling from a single interactive run to a classroom of student machines is to share the resulting

runtime tree (and replay a small per-host setup on each workstation). The rest of this document uses `/opt/sre` as the canonical example path; substitute your `main_sre_dir` wherever it appears if you chose something else.

Two common topologies:

Single read-only NFS export (recommended for classrooms). Clone the repo on a build server inside the directory you intend to export, run `sudo ./scripts/install.sh` there once, then export the directory read-only and mount it as `/opt/sre` on every student workstation. Updates take effect everywhere as soon as the export is refreshed, and students cannot tamper with the binaries or with the project files. The shell wrappers in `sbin/` and `bin/` don't write to their own tree, and all runtime state lives elsewhere — `/var/lib/sre` (`sre_pub_dir`) and `/home/sre` (`sre_user_public_dir`) stay on the local workstation — so a read-only mount works.

Build once, replicate per workstation. Run the installer once on a reference machine cloned at `/opt/sre`, then `rsync` (or image-clone) the resulting `/opt/sre` tree to every workstation. Running `install.sh` interactively on each machine is impractical for more than a handful of hosts.

Either way, each student workstation still needs a few per-host bits that aren't part of the `/opt/sre` tree:

- the `sre` system user/group, with the UID/GID baked into `params.py` at build time
- `/etc/sudoers.d/sre`
- membership of `sre` in the local `docker` group
- a copy of `scripts/etc/sre_bash_completion` into `/etc/bash_completion.d/sre`
- a copy of `scripts/etc/sysreseval.desktop` into `/usr/share/applications/`
- raised inotify limits (`scripts/etc/sre-inotify.conf` into `/etc/sysctl.d/`, then `sysctl --system`)
- the other post-install steps (see *Post-install steps*)
- for the NFS topology, the mount itself

Script these from the relevant sections of `scripts/install.sh` if you have many machines.

The `/opt/sre` tree must contain `lab/`, `lib/`, `graphics/`, `translations/`, `locale/`, `bin/`, `sbin/`, `src/`, `venv/`. Lab authors also browse `src/` while writing `srelab.py` files. See *Runtime & Internals* for the expected layout.

If you'd rather build in a separate working checkout (CI runner, personal dev tree) and move the result over afterwards, `rsync` or bind-mount the built tree into `/opt/sre` once `make install` has finished, then continue with the *Post-install steps*.

7.3 Debian package

On Debian 13 (trixie) and 14 (forky) SRE can be installed from Debian packages instead of a checkout: `python3-kathara` (the SRE fork of Kathara as a Python library), `sysreseval` and `sysreseval-doc`, plus `python3-fs` on forky (rebuilt from the trixie source package, since forky dropped it). Every other dependency is a Debian package. The packages are served by the apt repository of the project on GitHub Pages (signed; `<dist>` is `trixie` or `forky`):

```
sudo curl -fsSL -o /usr/share/keyrings/sysreseval-archive-keyring.gpg␣
↪https://sysreseval.github.io/sysreseval/apt/sysreseval-archive-keyring.gpg
sudo curl -fsSL -o /etc/apt/sources.list.d/sysreseval.sources␣
↪https://sysreseval.github.io/sysreseval/apt/sysreseval-<dist>.sources
sudo apt update && sudo apt install sysreseval
```

The same `.deb` files are attached to each GitHub release: `apt install ./python3-kathara_*.deb ./sysreseval_*.deb` installs them with their dependencies without the repository.

The package follows the FHS instead of the `/opt/sre` tree:

Path	Content
`/usr/sbin/sre`, `/usr/bin/sysreseval`, `/usr/bin/sre-wrapper`	the CLI, the GUI, the wrapper (`sudo /usr/sbin/sre --user`)
`/usr/bin/strip-instructor`, `/usr/bin/*-sre-translations`	the lab-authoring tools
`/usr/sbin/sysreseval-network-plugin`	`make network-plugin` of a checkout (`scripts/network-plugin.sh`)
`/usr/lib/sysreseval/`	the Python code (`src/`), `lib/` readable by the `sre` user only
`/usr/share/sysreseval/lab/sre/`	the labs of the project, linked as `/var/lib/sre/lab/sre`
`/var/lib/sre/`	projects, archives, `exam.json`, `home/` (the directories shared with the machines), `lab/` (the site's own labs next to the `sre` link)
`/etc/sysreseval/params.py`	the site parameters (a conffile)
`/etc/sudoers.d/sysreseval`, `/usr/lib/sysctl.d/60-sysreseval.conf`, the `.desktop` file, the bash completion, `sysreseval-preload-images.service` (disabled)	the per-host bits of the list above

`params.py` is not edited on a packaged host: `/etc/sysreseval/params.py` (Python syntax) sets the site's values of any parameter (`admin_gids`, `terminal_cmd_prefix`, `allow_privileged_machines`, `archive_dirs`, `sre_user_public_dir`…). It is executed after the base parameters and before the derived ones, so a changed `sre_pub_dir` moves the projects, archives and labs with it. The `sre` system user is created with a dynamic uid unless it exists already (create it beforehand with a fixed uid when `/var/lib/sre` or the archives are shared over NFS); its uid, gid and the `docker` gid are read from the accounts at run time. `sre update` is disabled on a packaged host (apt updates it), `apt purge` keeps `/var/lib/sre` and the user. `sysreseval-network-plugin` still has to be run once per Docker host for the labs with switch types, and the X server must accept TCP connections (post-install steps 2 below).

Releasing. `scripts/release.sh 0.13.2` (or `make release VERSION=0.13.2`) asks to confirm the version and the uncommitted leftovers, asks for release notes (one item per line; `-m` / `--notes-file` give them, `--yes` skips the questions), sets `sre_version` in `params.py`, adds the `0.13.2-1` entry to `debian/changelog` with the notes as its bullets, runs the unit tests, commits `Release 0.13.2` (notes in the body), tags `0.13.2`, pushes, creates the GitHub release with the notes followed by the generated list of commits, then waits for the two workflows: `release.yml` builds the trixie and forky packages and attaches them to the release, `pages.yml` deploys GitHub Pages with the documentation of `docs/` and the apt repository rebuilt by `scripts/apt-repo.sh` from the packages of every release (nothing binary is kept in git). Once per repository, `scripts/release.sh --setup` generates the signing key of the repository (with `gpg`, in your keyring), stores it as the secret `APT_SIGNING_KEY` and switches GitHub Pages to the Actions deployment.

Building the packages by hand. `scripts/build-deb.sh --dist trixie --ref 0.12.0 --test-install` builds the packages of the release tagged `0.12.0` in a `debian:trixie` container (Docker on the build host, which may be a Mac or a CI runner), checks them with lintian and installs them in a second container where it exercises `sre` (`sre list` through the link, `sre check` of a shipped lab, a student running `sre-wrapper`, the purge). `--local` packages the working tree instead (`make deb DIST=forky`); `--arch arm64` builds for that architecture; the result is in `build/deb/<dist>/`. The packaging lives in `debian/` (sysreseval), `packaging/kathara/` (the overlay applied to the fork tarball at the commit of `pin.sh`) and `packaging/python-fs/` (the forky rebuild). `debian/rules` sets `install_layout =`

"fhs" and the version in the installed params.py; the unit tests of the repository run during the build unless DEB_BUILD_OPTIONS=nocheck (--no-check). The GitHub workflow .github/workflows/release.yml runs the script for trixie and forky on every tag and attaches the .deb files to the release.

7.4 Updating

sudo sre update refreshes an installed tree from the GitHub repository: the latest release by default, --main for the head of main, --check to only see whether a newer version exists. It downloads the sources, merges src/SRE/params.py with the site's settings (customised parameters are kept; the questions concern only the parameters both customised here and changed upstream), replaces the files, keeps the site's own labs (everything in lab/ but lab/sre/) and extra lib/ files, rebuilds bin/sre-wrapper and records the installed commit in <main_sre_dir>/.sre-update.json. See the *CLI reference* for the details.

Before it replaces anything it runs sre wipe: run it outside class hours, every running project is stopped. It must run on the host that owns the tree: the NFS server in the read-only export topology (without a Docker daemon there, the wipe is skipped and sre wipe has to be run on the client hosts), and every workstation of the "replicate per workstation" topology. The per-host bits listed above are not touched; when the templates of scripts/etc/ changed, the update says so and they have to be reinstalled by hand. The venv is rebuilt only with --venv (or make venv afterwards; the update says when the recipe changed). To go back to the previous version: sudo sre update --ref <previous commit>, printed at the end of each update. The sample labs of lab/sre/ are reinstalled in full at every update.

7.5 Running the installer

```
sudo ./scripts/install.sh
```

The script is interactive. It asks, in order:

Prompt	Default	Purpose
main_sre_d	/opt/sre if the script is at /opt/sre/scripts/, otherwise the script's parent directory	Runtime root for SRE binaries, libs, labs, graphics, translations, locale. Substituted for /opt/sre in the sudoers rule, .desktop file, and systemd unit at install time.
sre UID	1100	UID of the system user that owns running labs.
sre GID	1100	GID of the matching group.
sre_pub_d:	/var/lib/sre	Public state: running projects, archives, exam.json.
sre_user_l	/home/sre	Per-lab shared /home/sre/{running_lab} mounts.
allow_pri	y	Whether srelab.py files may declare privileged containers.
execute_c	shell	shell, split, or False — controls how lab host_cmd() calls are executed.
extra authorized src dirs	/home	Extra directories (beyond main_sre_dir + '/lab', which is always included) from which srelab.py files may be loaded. Type - for none to restrict loading to the lab directory only.
Admin UIDs / GIDs	*(none)*	Extra UIDs/GIDs that SRE treats as administrators.

The Docker socket GID is detected automatically (no prompt).

After you confirm the summary, the installer:

1. Saves a backup of params.py to params.py.bak.<YYYYmmdd-HHMMSS>.

2. Patches the answers into `src/SRE/params.py` (single-line `key = value` substitutions, each verified after the edit).
3. Runs `make remove-debug-mode` if `debug_mode = True` is currently set — `make install` refuses to build while debug mode is on.
4. Creates the `sre` system group and user (`nologin` shell, home `/home/sre`) if they don't already exist. If a user/group with the requested name exists with a different UID/GID, it is **kept as-is** rather than overwritten — the installer warns and continues.
5. Adds `sre` to the Docker group resolved from the socket GID.
6. Installs `/etc/sudoers.d/sre` (**required** — the `sysreseval` GUI shells out to `sudo /opt/sre/sbin/sre --user` via `sre-wrapper`, so labs cannot start without this rule), validated by `visudo -c` before being kept. The rule it installs is:

```
Defaults!/opt/sre/sbin/sre env_keep += "USER_USERNAME SRE_XAUTH_COOKIE"
ALL  ALL= NOPASSWD: /opt/sre/sbin/sre --user *
```

   The rule grants passwordless access to every user on the host, not a specific group — `sre-wrapper` is the only entry point and it always passes `--user` with the caller's real login, so widening the sudoers scope doesn't lower the security envelope. `sre` enforces this itself: a `--user` call is accepted only when sudo ran `sre` directly (`SUDO_COMMAND`) and the compiled `sre-wrapper` binary is an ancestor of the process (`/proc/<pid>/exe`), so the C binary built by `make sre-wrapper` is required and a script cannot stand in for it. Restrict it to a specific group (e.g. `%etudiant`) if your site policy requires it.
7. Optionally installs `scripts/etc/sysreseval.desktop` to `/usr/share/applications/` so the GUI appears in the desktop application menu.
8. Optionally installs `scripts/etc/sre_bash_completion` to `/etc/bash_completion.d/sre` so the `sre` CLI gets bash completion system-wide.
9. Optionally installs the `sre-preload-images.service` systemd unit (oneshot, requires `opt-sre.mount`; not enabled by default — enable with `systemctl enable --now sre-preload-images.service` once `/opt/sre` is mounted).
10. Optionally installs `scripts/etc/sre-inotify.conf` to `/etc/sysctl.d/60-sre-inotify.conf` and runs `sysctl --system`, raising the kernel inotify limits that privileged labs (systemd PID 1 in each container) would otherwise exhaust.
11. Runs `make venv` then `make install` (which is `check-debug-mode` + `sre-wrapper` + `wrappers`).
12. Optionally creates symlinks in `/usr/local/bin/` and `/usr/local/sbin/` pointing to each executable under `main_sre_dir/bin/` and `main_sre_dir/sbin/`, so `sre`, `sysreseval`, and `sre-wrapper` can be launched without their full path. Existing non-symlink files at the same paths are left untouched (with a warning).

7.6 Install manually

If you prefer to skip `scripts/install.sh` (e.g. on a non-Debian distribution, or to integrate with your own configuration management), perform the same steps by hand from a checkout of the repo:

1. **Create the `sre` system group and user.** Pick a UID/GID (the installer defaults to `1100`). The user needs a real home for shared `/home/sre/{running_lab}` mounts but no shell login:

```
groupadd --system --gid 1100 sre
useradd --system --uid 1100 --gid 1100 --home-dir /home/sre --shell /
↪usr/sbin/nologin sre
install -d -o sre -g sre -m 0755 /home/sre
```

2. **Add `sre` to the Docker group** so it can talk to `/var/run/docker.sock`:

```
usermod -aG "$(stat -c %G /var/run/docker.sock)" sre
```

3. **Edit `src/SRE/params.py`** to match your site. At minimum review:

   - `main_sre_dir` — runtime root for SRE binaries, libs, labs, graphics, translations, locale (default `/opt/sre`). If you change this, also rewrite the literal `/opt/sre` in the sudoers rule, `.desktop` file, and `sre-preload-images.service` snippets below.
   - `sre_uid`, `sre_gid` — must match the user/group created above.
   - `docker_gid` — GID of the group owning `/var/run/docker.sock`.
   - `sre_pub_dir` — public state directory (default `/var/lib/sre`).
   - `sre_user_public_dir` — per-lab shared directory (default `/home/sre`).
   - `allow_privileged_machines` — whether `srelab.py` files may declare privileged containers.
   - `execute_commands_on_host` — `'shell'`, `'split'`, or `False`.
   - `authorized_src_dir` — list of directories from which `srelab.py` files may be loaded. Must include `main_sre_dir + '/lab'`; defaults to also including `/home`.
   - `admin_uids`, `admin_gids` — extra UIDs/GIDs treated as administrators.
   - `terminal_cmd_prefix`, `terminal_title_opt` — the external terminal emulator the GUI launches to open machine connections (default `mate-terminal`). Check which terminals are installed and uncomment the matching pair shown in `params.py`:

     ```
     command -v mate-terminal gnome-terminal xfce4-terminal xterm terminator
     ```

   - `debug_mode` — **must be `False`** before building (`make wrappers` refuses otherwise). Use `make remove-debug-mode` if needed.

4. **Install the sudoers rule** — required for `sysreseval` to start labs (the GUI invokes `sudo /opt/sre/sbin/sre --user` through `sre-wrapper`). The rule allows every user on the host to invoke the wrapper without a password; restrict the first column to a specific group (e.g. `%etudiant`) if your site policy requires it. Then validate before keeping the file:

```
Defaults!/opt/sre/sbin/sre env_keep += "USER_USERNAME SRE_XAUTH_COOKIE"
ALL  ALL= NOPASSWD: /opt/sre/sbin/sre --user *
```

```
visudo -cf /etc/sudoers.d/sre && chmod 0440 /etc/sudoers.d/sre
```

5. **(Optional) Install the desktop entry** so the GUI appears in the desktop application menu:

```
install -m 0644 -o root -g root scripts/etc/sysreseval.desktop /
↪usr/share/applications/sysreseval.desktop
```

6. **(Optional) Install the image pre-pull systemd unit** from `scripts/etc/sre-preload-images.service` into `/etc/systemd/system/`. It requires `opt-sre.mount` and is not enabled by default — see *Pre-loading Docker images* below.

7. **(Recommended) Raise the kernel inotify limits.** Privileged labs run `/sbin/init` (systemd PID 1) inside each container, and systemd reserves inotify watches per cgroup. Debian defaults (`max_user_instances = 128`) are quickly exhausted once two privileged labs run side by side, after which systemd in any new container exits at startup with `Failed to create control group inotify object: Too many open files`. Drop in the file shipped under `scripts/etc/` and apply it:

```
install -m 0644 scripts/etc/sre-inotify.conf /etc/sysctl.d/60-sre-inotify.conf
sysctl --system
```

8. **(Optional) Install bash completion** for the `sre` CLI. The script under `scripts/etc/sre_bash_completion` completes subcommands, running lab names (read from `/var/lib/sre/projects/`), available labs (via `sre list`), and option arguments. Install it system-wide:

   ```
   cp scripts/etc/sre_bash_completion /etc/bash_completion.d/sre
   ```

   Or source it per-user from `~/.bashrc`:

   ```
   . /path/to/sre_bash_completion
   ```

9. **Build the venv and the binaries:**

   ```
   make venv      # creates venv/ with Python 3.13 deps - see Dependencies below
   make install   # check-debug-mode + sre-wrapper + wrappers
   ```

10. **(For labs with switches) Install the network plugin with the switch types:** `make network-plugin` — see *Network plugin for the switch types*. Labs whose networks are all hubs do not need it.

You can also run the CLI and GUI directly from source against the venv:

```
source venv/bin/activate
python3 -W ignore src/sre.py <command>     # CLI
python3 src/sysreseval.py                  # GUI
```

Most `sre` subcommands need root and a working Docker setup, but the pure-Python paths (e.g. `sre cat`, `sre sheet`, `sre outline`) work from a venv as a regular user against pre-existing archive files.

7.7 Post-install steps

Once the installer has built the binaries, finish the deployment:

7.7.1 1. Deploy and verify

1. Make sure the built tree is reachable at `/opt/sre` on every workstation that will run labs. If you ran the installer from `/opt/sre` directly (per *Deployment layout*) this is already done; otherwise copy/bind-mount the built tree into place, or expose it via the read-only NFS export and mount it as `/opt/sre` on each workstation.

2. Verify Docker access for the `sre` user:

   ```
   sudo -u sre docker ps
   ```

   The Docker images SRE needs are pulled from Docker Hub on first lab start; no local image build is required.

3. Make sure `/opt/sre/bin` and `/opt/sre/sbin` are reachable on `PATH` so that `sysreseval`, `sre-wrapper`, and `sre` can be launched without their full path. The installer offers to create the symlinks under `/usr/local/bin` and `/usr/local/sbin` for you; if you skipped that prompt (or installed by hand), either add the two directories to the system-wide `PATH` (e.g. via `/etc/profile.d/sre.sh`), or create the symlinks manually:

```
ln -s /opt/sre/bin/*  /usr/local/bin/
ln -s /opt/sre/sbin/* /usr/local/sbin/
```

(Optional) Tune `src/SRE/params.py` further — see *Runtime & Internals*.

7.7.2 2. Enable X11 access for lab virtual machines

Labs run graphical (X11) applications inside their containers and those apps display on the host's X server (if the parameter `x11_host` is set to `True` in a virtual machine configuration). For this to work the host's X server must accept TCP connections on **port 6000** (display `:0`). Modern X servers start with `-nolisten tcp`, so TCP is disabled by default and must be turned on explicitly. Access to individual labs is then authorized per project via an xauth cookie (`SRE_XAUTH_COOKIE` / `sre start --xauth-file`), so no `xhost` tweaks are needed — only the TCP listener.

How to enable TCP listening depends on your display manager. Two common cases:

- **GDM** — in `/etc/gdm3/custom.conf`:

  ```
  [security]
  DisallowTCP=false
  ```

- **LightDM** — in `/etc/lightdm/lightdm.conf` under `[Seat:*]`:

  ```
  xserver-allow-tcp=true
  ```

Restart the display manager (or log out and back in) for the change to take effect, then verify:

```
ss -ltn | grep 6000
```

You should see the X server listening on `0.0.0.0:6000` (and/or `[::]:6000`). `scripts/install.sh` runs this same check at the end and warns if no X server is listening on port 6000.

7.7.3 3. Restricting student access to Docker

For an exam to be meaningful, students must not be able to talk to Docker directly — otherwise a `docker exec -it ...` from a regular shell would let them connect to a forbidden container and bypass the lab's restrictions.

The recommended setup:

1. Remove students from the `docker` group entirely. Only `sre` (and any administrator account) should be a member.
2. Create a separate `docker-access` group and add the student accounts to it.
3. Toggle that group's access to `/var/run/docker.sock` with the two helpers shipped under `scripts/`:
   - `scripts/docker-allowed` grants `rw` on the socket to `docker-access` (run before non-exam sessions).
   - `scripts/docker-forbidden` revokes it (run before an exam).

Both helpers use `setfacl` on the Docker socket, so the change is immediate and survives until the next call.

7.7.4 4. Sharing evaluation archives for `sre watch`

`sre watch <directory>` runs an interactive terminal dashboard that monitors evaluation archives as they appear and alerts on student inactivity or errors. To use it during an exercise session or an exam, every workstation must drop its archives into a directory the instructor can read from one place. Set the `archive_dirs` attribute in `params.py` (or on some lab's `srelab.py`) so evaluations are written into the shared location in addition to the local one.

There are several ways to set up the shared hierarchy:

Single NFS share, server-side watch. Export one NFS directory, restrict read-write access to the `sre` user (e.g. `rw,no_root_squash` for the workstations, mounted only as `sre`), and run `sre watch` directly on the NFS server. This is the simplest setup and works well when the instructor's session is on the server itself.

Per-workstation NFS shares with nightly rotation. Export one subdirectory per student workstation, each writable only by that workstation. The script `scripts/misc/rotate-nfs-dirs.py` is meant to be invoked from `cron` (typically once a night). On each run it:

1. Renames `/home/sre-archives/current` to `/home/sre-archives/YYYY-MM-DD` (the previous day), so past-day archives are no longer reachable from any student computer.
2. Re-creates `/home/sre-archives/current/<machine>` for every workstation listed in the `MACHINES` constant.
3. Rewrites `/etc/exports.d/sre-archives.exports` so each subdirectory is exported only to the matching workstation IP.
4. `systemctl reload nfs-kernel-server`.

Edit the `MACHINES`, `BASE_DIR`, and `EXPORTS_FILE` constants at the top of the script to match your site before installing the cron job. `sre watch /home/sre-archives/current` then sees every workstation's live archives.

Read-only cross-mount for the instructor. In addition to either of the above, you can re-export the shared directory read-only to the instructor's workstation. The instructor can then run `sre watch` from their own machine without logging into the server.

7.7.5 5. Pre-loading Docker images

When an exam starts, every workstation pulls the same images at the same time — without precaution this can saturate the network and cause a meltdown. The fix is to pre-pull the images on each host ahead of time.

The unit `scripts/etc/sre-preload-images.service` (offered for installation by `scripts/install.sh`) runs once at boot and shells out to:

```
/opt/sre/sbin/sre preload-images --random-delay 120 /opt/sre/lab/
```

The `--random-delay` spreads the pulls over a 120-second window so workstations don't hit Docker Hub simultaneously. The unit requires `opt-sre.mount` (i.e. `/opt/sre` mounted as a systemd mount unit) and is **not enabled by default**:

```
systemctl enable --now sre-preload-images.service
```

On the pool hosts of the web front-end the random delay is not needed: the agent of each host runs the same command when the portal gives it its turn, and the portal lets only a few hosts download at the same time (`[preload] at_start = true` in `agent.toml`, `[pool] max_preloads` in `web.toml`; see *Pre-loading the images* in the *web front-end* page). Leave the unit disabled on such a host: both would pull.

7.8 Reference

7.8.1 Build targets

Target	Output
`make wrappers`	Marks `sbin/sre` and `bin/sysreseval` shell wrappers executable. Refuses to build while `params.debug_mode = True`.
`make sre-wrapper`	`bin/sre-wrapper` (small C helper that escalates via `sudo`).
`make install`	`check-debug-mode` + `sre-wrapper` + `wrappers`.
`make network-plugin`	Kathara VDE network plugin with the switch types, built from the fork and installed in place of the stock plugin (see *Network plugin for the switch types*).
`make translations`	Compile Qt `.ts` → `.qm` and gettext `.po` → `.mo`.
`make docs`	API docs (pdoc) + main docs (Sphinx) → `docs/html/main/`, `docs/html/api/`, `docs/documentation.pdf`.
`make set-debug-mode` / `make remove-debug-mode`	Flip `debug_mode` in `src/SRE/params.py`.

`debug_mode` must be `False` for `make wrappers` and `make install`, but **must be `True`** to run exam-mode integration tests — the GUI then emits the JSON event stream those tests assert on.

7.8.2 Tests

```
make tests                          # every test under tests/, the functional and web␣
↪tests included (excludes test_exam_mode.py, a script, and the Docker tests of make␣
↪docker-tests)
make test FILE=test_net_config.py   # single file
make functional-tests               # functional tests (test_functional.py)
make exam-tests                     # exam-mode integration tests (requires␣
↪debug_mode=True)
make docker-tests                   # the Docker integration tests, left out of make␣
↪tests and run by make all-tests (root, real containers: start/stop, save/restore, the␣
↪connection log's database on a MariaDB container)
make all-tests                      # tests + docker-tests + exam-tests
```

Unit tests don't need Docker or Kathara — they cover serialization, topology, grading logic, and pure-Python helpers. Functional and exam-mode tests stand up more of the system: see `tests/conftest.py` for the shared fixtures (`mock_sre_args`, `tmp_lab_dir`, `tmp_pub_dir`).

Pytest runs with `-p no:cacheprovider` so the production install (`/opt/sre/`, read-only) doesn't try to write a cache.

7.8.3 Building the documentation

```
make docs            # api_doc + main_doc_pdf + main_doc_html
make main_doc_html   # Sphinx HTML only → docs/html/main/
make main_doc_pdf    # Sphinx LaTeX → docs/documentation.pdf
make api_doc         # pdoc API → docs/html/api/
```

The Sphinx targets pip-install `sphinx myst-parser furo` into the existing venv on demand; `api_doc` does the same for `pdoc`.

7.8.4 Network plugin for the switch types

A lab may give each network a type of switch (`'mode': 'hub'`, `'switch'` or `'managed'` in its `_network_specs`, see *Hubs, switches and VLANs*). Hubs — the default, and the only type of every lab written before — work with the stock Kathara network plugin, the one Kathara downloads by itself on the first start. The two other types need the VDE plugin of the fork `emotchane/NetworkPlugin` (branch `main`), installed under the name Kathara uses (`kathara/katharanp_vde:<arch>`):

```
make network-plugin      # as root or a member of the docker group
```

The target installs the plugin **in place of the stock one** and enables it. It first tries the published build, `sysreseval/katharanp_vde:<arch>` on Docker Hub (`NETWORK_PLUGIN_IMAGE`), downloaded under the name Kathara uses; when that one is not available, or with `BUILD=1`, it clones the fork into `build/` and builds the plugin for the architecture of the host (a few minutes; needs `git`, `python3` and Docker with `buildx`). It does nothing when the installed plugin already knows the switch types (`FORCE=1` installs it again) and refuses to run while a Kathara network exists: stop the running projects first (`sre wipe`). The plugin belongs to Docker, not to the SRE tree: it is installed once per host and stays when SRE is reinstalled. `scripts/install.sh` offers to run the target.

To publish a build (maintainers), from a clone of the fork on a host of the wanted architecture, in a terminal, after `docker login` with an account allowed to push to the organisation:

```
cd NetworkPlugin/vde
make push_amd64 PLUGIN_NAME=sysreseval/katharanp_vde     # builds␣
↪sysreseval/katharanp_vde:amd64 and pushes it
```

A plugin that knows the switch types says so in its settings:

```
docker plugin inspect kathara/katharanp_vde:amd64 --format '{{.Settings.Env}}'    # ...␣
↪KATHARA_SWITCH_MODES=hub,switch,managed
```

Without it `sre start` of a lab that uses a switch fails — Kathara's message (*the Kathara Network Plugin … does not support it*) followed by the networks concerned and a reminder of `make network-plugin` — and nothing is left running. The management console of a managed switch is a unix socket the plugin gives to the group of `/var/run/docker.sock`: the `sre` user reaches it as it reaches Docker.

7.8.5 Dependencies

Installed by `make venv`:

Package	Purpose
kathara	Docker lab orchestration — installed from the fork `emotchane/Kathara`, branch `main`, which adds `save_lab()` / `restore_lab()` (used by `sre save` / `sre restore`) and the switch modes of the collision domains (hub / switch / managed switch with VLANs, used by the `mode` of a network); `git` must be available when running `make venv`
cryptg	AES-GCM encryption of save files for labs that define `save_key`
pysid	Qt6 GUI
msgpa	Efficient binary serialization
zstan	Archive compression
graph	Network topology diagrams
odfpy	LibreOffice ODS spreadsheet export
fpdf2	PDF report generation
markd	Lab description rendering
netad	MAC address handling
pytes	Test runner

Documentation builds also fetch `sphinx`, `myst-parser`, `furo`, and `pdoc` on demand.

CHAPTER

EIGHT

GUI REFERENCE — SYSRESEVAL

8.1 Launching

```
source venv/bin/activate && python3 src/sysreseval.py   # dev
sysreseval                                              # production
```

One instance per user. A PID file at `/tmp/sysreseval-{uid}.pid` kills any prior instance on startup.

8.2 Opening a project

File → Open Project (or the `+` tab) shows a dialog built from `sre list --with-titles`. Leaves display each lab's translated `title` (from per-directory `titles.json` sidecars, generated by `sre make-titles`), falling back to the filename without `.py`; a sub-directory listed in the `titles.json` of its parent shows its title too. The entries of a directory come in the order its `titles.json` sets (`"@sort"`, see `sre make-titles` in the CLI reference): by file name, by title in the language priority of the GUI, or in the order of the file; the sub-directories always come first. The web front-end shows the same tree in the same order. If the lab's `Flavor` sets `flavor_form_at_startup = True`, a form runs first. A progress dialog then tracks image pulls and container starts (JSON on stderr from `sre start`); the project tab appears when every machine is up.

During an exam, **Open Project** is disabled — only pre-authorised exam labs open automatically.

The project tabs are the projects of the logged-in user, plus those started on the host by root or the `sre` user (`sudo sre start …`). The projects of the other users of the host (another local login, the users of the *web front-end* placed on this host) are neither listed nor reachable through `sre-wrapper`; with `check_project_owner = False` in the site parameters every project of the host is listed, as before. **File → Close All Projects** runs `sre-wrapper stop-all` on the listed projects (`sre wipe` is privileged only).

8.3 Saving and restoring a project

File → Save Project appears only when the current project's lab sets `allow_save_restore = True`. A file dialog asks where to write the `.sre` save file (default `~/<lab>.sre`); the GUI then runs `sre-wrapper save <project>` with its stdout redirected to that file, showing a progress dialog. The file contains the filesystem of every machine (as a diff against its base image) and the project files; it is encrypted when the lab defines `save_key`.

File → Restore Project (always available outside exam mode) asks for a `.sre` file and runs `sre-wrapper restore -` with the file on stdin, showing the same image-pull / machine-start progress as **Open Project**. The saved project comes back as a **new** tab (new instance); the original one, if still open, is untouched. Only files are restored — the lab's `restore` state relaunches its services.

8.4 Exporting a project

File → Export Kathara Project (enabled unless the lab sets `export_kathara_project = False`) runs `sre-wrapper export <project>` with the display settings of the Schema tab and writes `~/<lab>.zip`: the Kathara project (`lab.conf`, the files of every machine) with `schema.pdf` and `informations.pdf`.

File → Export Schema to PDF (right below; enabled unless the lab sets `export_schema_pdf = False`) writes the drawing of the *Schema* tab to a PDF chosen in a file dialog (default `~/<lab>_schema.pdf`): the visible machines only, never the hidden ones, even for a debug project or while the *Instructor mode* button is on, with the tab's current Lines / Compact-Spread / Order / Icons settings and the machine order of `info.json`. The GUI draws it itself with graphviz from `info.json`; no `sre` command is run.

Both items are disabled in exam mode.

8.5 Project tabs

Tab	Content
Sche	Topology drawn by graphviz from the machines of `info.json`, without the hidden machines. Scroll = zoom, click-drag = pan.
Full Sche	Debug projects only (`sre start --debug-project`). The same drawing and controls with every machine: the hidden machines, their links and the networks only they use are in red, like the titles of the hidden machines in the Terminals tab. The Schema tab keeps showing what a student sees.
Information	Markdown lab description from `self.informations` in `NetScheme.__init__()`.
Machin	Per-machine state (polled from Kathara every 1 s), NAT network, ports, plus a *Connect* button opening an external terminal.
Networl	Always shown. One row per network with its type — *Hub*, *Switch* or *Manageable switch* — and, for a manageable switch the lab leaves open to students, a *Connect* button opening its management console in an external terminal (`sre-wrapper connect <project> <network>`). The type of a manageable switch the lab closed is on a red background and has no button — except in a debug project, where it gets an orange *Connect* button and an orange-titled terminal in the Terminals tab. See *Hubs, switches and VLANs* for the three types and the commands of the console.
Question	Three types: `question_text` (free text), `question_form` (inline fields: single-line text with a regex, multi-line text, dropdown, checkbox — the `@@{field:spec}@@` grammar is in *Questions*), `question_dummy` (display only). Written to `answers/answers.json` on every edit: the file is read first and only the answers changed in the GUI are merged in, then it is replaced atomically, so what the web front-end wrote meanwhile (the same student in a browser, an instructor helping) is kept; the read and the write are done under an advisory lock on the `answers/` directory that the web agent takes too, so that two writes at the same moment do not lose one of them; the file is read again every second when another program changed it and the current question shows the new value.
Evaluation	Last grade table + *Start evaluation* button. Letter grades (OK/MEH/FAIL) appear when the lab sets `no_mark_on_self_grade`. A countdown replaces the button while `delay_between_self_grade` is active.
Terminals	Embedded terminals per machine, launched via `params.terminal_cmd_prefix`, plus one per manageable switch students may use (its console).
Log	Debug projects (`sre start --debug-project`), and instructor-mode projects while the *Instructor mode* button is on (states only). Live tail of the project's `operations.log`: one `=== <time> state <name>` / `=== <time> evaluation` header per run, then one 'stepN - on <machine

`answers/answers.json` also carries metadata (`hostname`, `login`, `fullname`, `email`, `language`, `answers_updated_at`, plus `exam_*` fields in exam mode, and `group` for the projects of the web front-end); see *Archive format* for the full schema.

Start evaluation runs `sre eval --auto-eval` in a background thread. The periodic background eval (`eval_interval_without_exam_mode`) and `eval_before_exit` run plain `sre eval` (no cooldown, no log line, no stdout).

8.6 Instructor mode

A project in instructor mode (`sre start --instructor-mode`, `sre restore --instructor-mode` or `sre set-instructor-mode`, all privileged) adds a checkable **Instructor mode** button (mortarboard icon) at the left of the Wrap / Settings / Language buttons. The button is visible only while the current tab is such a project; it is off when the GUI starts and its state is not saved.

Button	Informations / Questions	Apply Configuration	Log tab
off	Exactly what a student sees: the `instructor()` texts are not displayed.	Only the states a student may apply (the tab is hidden when there is none).	Hidden.
on	The `instructor()` texts are displayed in colour (`params.instructor_text_color` on `params.instructor_background_color`, or the colours given by the lab).	Every state of the lab, those reserved to the instructor in red.	Shown, with what each applied state executed (no evaluation).

The button applies to every open project in instructor mode. Switching the mode of an open project with `sre set-instructor-mode` / `sre remove-instructor-mode` is picked up within a second.

A **debug project** (`sre start --debug-project`, or `--debug-web-project` for a lab named from the catalog) shows the same button: its `info.json` holds the `instructor()` texts too. There the button only displays or hides those texts in the Informations and Questions views; every state and the Log tab are shown whatever its position, as in any debug project.

8.7 Exam mode

When `/var/lib/sre/exam.json` exists, the GUI switches modes: File → Open / Restore / Save / Close / Close All / Export Kathara Project / Export Schema to PDF are disabled, and answers re-save with an updated `exam_time_remaining` on every exam-config change.

Phas	Trigger	Shows / actions
Wait ing	`now < start_after`	SRE logo + countdown to `start_after`. Calls `sre pre-start-exam` once ~60 s before `start_after`.
Ac- tive	`start_after ≤ now < end` and exam projects up	Project tabs + remaining-time countdown. Calls `sre start-exam` once on entry, `sre eval-exam` every `eval_interval`; re-calls `pre-start-exam` if `labs` changes.
Ende	`now end_before`, or `now started_at + duration`	Calls `sre eval-exam` then `sre end-exam` once; displays the *That's All Folks* logo.

8.8 Settings

File → Settings (persisted in `~/.config/sysreseval`, INI):

Section	Setting	Default	Effect / applies
Interface	Font size	10 pt	Menus and dialog text; immediate
Terminal	Font size	12 pt	Terminals opened after the change
Terminal	Color scheme	Black on White	`black_on_white` / `white_on_black`; new terminals
Schema	Lines	Straight	Straight or curved edges; next lab open
Schema	Spacing	3 (0–9)	Node spacing; next lab open
Schema	Nodes	Shapes	Icons or geometric shapes; next lab open
Content	Font size	12 pt	Informations + Questions panes; immediate

CHAPTER

NINE

CLI REFERENCE — SRE

`sre --help` groups subcommands into five buckets: **dual** (admins + GUI via `sre-wrapper`), **admin-only**, **exam management**, **post-exam management**, and **internal** (GUI-only).

9.1 Global options

```
sre [--user] [--debug] <subcommand> ...
```

Option	Description
`--us`	Set by `sre-wrapper`; reads student login from `USER_USERNAME` (else `LOGNAME`). Mutually exclusive with `--debug`. In user mode a command only reaches the caller's own projects and those started by root or the `sre` user (`sudo sre start …`); with `params.check_project_owner = False` every project of the host, as before 0.14.
`--de`	Verbose diagnostics to stderr.

Access is restricted to `root`, the `sre` user (`params.sre_uid = 1100`), members of `params.admin_uids`, or members of any `params.admin_gids` group. Non-privileged users may only run `cat`, `check-eval`, `re-eval`, `sheet`, and `outline`.

9.2 Dual commands

9.2.1 `sre start [-d data] [-p] [--flavor … | --flavor-json … | --set-flavor-name …] [--xauth-file <file>] [--instructor-mode] <lab> [data_version]`

Starts a new lab instance, named `{timestamp}@@@{lab_name}@@@{username}`. Imports `srelab.py`, runs `Data.generate(flavor)` (or loads `-d data.json`), builds `NetScheme`, pulls images, deploys via Kathara, applies the `initial` state, and writes `info.json`. See *Internals* for file-transfer and progress mechanics.

Argument / Option	Description
`lab`	Lab name (from `sre list`) or, with `-p`, a filesystem path.
`-p` / `--path`	Treat `lab` as a path.
`-d` / `--data`	Reuse an existing `data.json` instead of generating one.
`data_versi`	Optional seed for `Data.generate()` (privileged only; incompatible with `-d`).
`--flavor key:val …`	Flavor field values (e.g. `--flavor nb:3 mode:hard`).
`--flavor-j <json>`	Flavor as JSON dict (used by the GUI).
`--set-flav <name>`	Use a named preset `Flavor` (privileged only).
`--xauth-fi <file>`	Read `SRE_XAUTH_COOKIE` from an X authority file instead of the env var (privileged only; for `x11_host=True` machines).
`--instruct`	Start the project in *instructor mode* (privileged only).
`--debug-pr`	Start a debug project (see *Lab Authoring*; privileged only): `lab` is read as a path, `-p` implied.
`--debug-we`	The same debug project, `lab` read as a lab name as for a normal start (the exam-only labs accepted), so that the project keeps the lab name of the catalog; privileged only, what the web agent runs; incompatible with `-p` and `--debug-project`.

9.2.2 `sre stop <running_lab>`

Undeploys containers and removes the project directory from `/var/lib/sre/projects/`. Kathara only undeploys the containers whose `user` label matches the caller, so `stop` first aligns `SUDO_UID` with the label used at deploy time (`sre` for non-privileged labs, the project owner for privileged ones; both are tried when the lab is not loaded, as in `pre-start-exam`).

The name may be a unique substring of the running lab name (every command taking a `<running_lab>` resolves it this way). In user mode only the caller's own projects and those started by root or the `sre` user are candidates: another user's project is refused by its exact name and never listed nor matched by a substring (`params.check_project_owner`).

9.2.3 `sre stop-all`

Stops every running project the caller may access, each one as `sre stop` does (with the `lab_hash` of its `info.json`: no lab module is loaded and both container labels are tried): all of them for a privileged caller, in user mode the caller's own projects and those started by root or the `sre` user (every project when `params.check_project_owner` is off). The GUI's **File → Close All Projects** runs it. Unlike `sre wipe` nothing else is touched: no Kathara wipe, the stray entries of the projects directory and the orphan user public directories stay, and a project without `info.json` (a start in progress or failed) is left alone. Refused in user mode during an exam, like `stop`.

9.2.4 `sre save [-o <file>] [--full-images] <running_lab>`

Saves a running project into a single save file (`.sre`): the filesystem of every container (captured by the patched Kathara `save_lab`, as a diff against the base image by default) plus the project files (`data.json`, `answers/`, `.private/files`, the user public dir with `shared/` and the volume directories, `.private/mnt`). The lab must set `allow_save_restore = True`; the lab's `save` state is applied first (see *Lifecycle states*). Only files are captured, not running processes.

Option	Description
`-o` / `--output <file>`	Write the save file here instead of stdout (privileged only).
`--full-images`	Store full committed device images instead of filesystem diffs — self-contained but large (privileged only).

In user mode (`--user`, i.e. from the GUI) the file is always written to stdout. When the lab defines `save_key`, the payload is encrypted. See *Save file format*.

9.2.5 `sre restore [--instructor-mode] <save_file | ->`

Restores a save file as a **new** running project (fresh timestamp, current user): loads the lab module named in the header (`allow_save_restore` required), recreates the project directories and copies the saved project files back, rebuilds the Kathara lab from the restored `data.json` (fresh host ports, X11 cookie, volumes, `/shared`), redeploys the containers from the saved filesystems (`Kathara.restore_lab(…, lab=…)`, same `pull`/`deploy` progress events as `start`), refreshes `exetests.py`, applies the lab's `restore` state and writes `info.json`. On failure everything created so far is rolled back.

`-` reads the save file from stdin — the only form accepted in user mode (the GUI opens the file as the student). Labs referenced by an absolute path (`sre start -p`) can only be restored by privileged users, unless the path lies inside the lab directory (`/opt/sre/lab`), in which case the save file is restored like any other lab of that directory. An encrypted file needs a lab with the same `save_key`; a cleartext file for a lab that defines `save_key` is refused in user mode (accepted with a warning otherwise).

`--instructor-mode` (privileged only) puts the new project in instructor mode. A save file never carries the mode: without the option the restored project is a normal one, whatever the saved project was.

9.2.6 `sre wipe`

Stops every running Kathara lab and removes everything under `/var/lib/sre/projects/` and the user public directories. Privileged only: the user-mode form is `sre stop-all`.

9.2.7 `sre connect [--shell <shell>] [--exec <argument…>] [--no-records] <running_lab> <device>`

Opens a terminal session on a device: the shell of a machine, or the management console of a managed switch when `<device>` is a network declared with `'mode': 'managed'` (prompt `<network>$` , `exit` leaves). In user mode the console only accepts the commands of `params.switch_user_commands`, and it is refused when the lab sets `'allow_connection': False` on the switch. The commands of the console are listed in *Hubs, switches and VLANs*.

Option	Description
`--shell <shell>`	Override the machine default shell (privileged only; not for a switch).
`--exec <argument…>`	Run one command via the shell and return (consumes rest of argv). On a switch: one console command, privileged only.
`--no-records`	Do not record the terminal session (privileged only).

9.2.8 `sre eval [-p path] [--auto-eval] <running_lab>`

Evaluates a running lab. The atomic lock file `.private/eval_in_progress` prevents concurrent evals.

`--auto-eval` marks a *user-triggered self-evaluation* (sent by the GUI's *Start evaluation*). With `--user`, it enables the `delay_between_self_grade` cooldown (outside exam mode), appends a line to `.private/auto_eval.log`, and prints the result JSON. Without `--auto-eval`, a `--user` invocation runs silently — no cooldown, no log, no stdout. The `auto_eval_count` (lines in `.private/auto_eval.log` before this run) is assigned to `self.auto_eval_count` and embedded in the archive's `answers`. If the lab sets `no_mark_on_self_grade`, letter grades (OK/MEH/FAIL) replace numeric grades. Results are archived as `.zst` — see *Archive format*.

9.2.9 `sre state <running_lab> <state_name>`

Applies `NetScheme.<state_name>()` to a running lab. In user mode only the states declared `@sre_state(user_allowed=True)` of a lab setting `allow_user_states = True` are accepted, except on a debug project or a project in instructor mode, where every state is. File operations registered via `file()` / `append_to_file()` are injected via in-memory tar archives sent to `container.put_archive("/")`.

9.3 Admin-only commands

9.3.1 `sre exec [--shell <shell>] <running_lab> <device> <command…>`

Runs `shell -c <command>` in a container and forwards stdout/stderr/exit code. Default shell is `params.default_exec_shell`.

When `<device>` is a managed switch (a network with `'mode': 'managed'`), `<command…>` is one command of its management console, e.g. `sre exec <running_lab> lan vlan/print` or `sre exec <running_lab> lan port/setvlan @pc1 10` (`@machine`: the port of that machine). The exit status is 0, or the error number given by the switch (17 when a VLAN already exists) with the message on stderr.

9.3.2 `sre set-instructor-mode <running_lab>` and `sre remove-instructor-mode <running_lab>`

Switch the **instructor mode** of a running project (`sre start --instructor-mode` and `sre restore --instructor-mode` set it from the beginning). The mode is meant for the instructor's own project and has three effects:

- the texts the lab wraps in `instructor()` (see *Lab Authoring*) are kept in `info.json`; for any other project but a debug project (`sre start --debug-project`, which keeps them too) they are dropped before the file is written, so students cannot read them;
- every `sre state` appends what it executed to the project's `operations.log` (evaluations are not logged, unlike in a debug project);
- every state can be applied, as to a debug project: `sre state` in user mode (what the GUI runs) no longer requires `allow_user_states` nor `@sre_state(user_allowed=True)`.

In the GUI all three show only while the *Instructor mode* button is on (see *GUI*). Nothing else changes: hidden machines and grades are those of a normal project.

Both commands write `info.json` again; the question hashes do not depend on the mode, so the answers already given stay attached. `remove-instructor-mode` also deletes `operations.log`, unless the project is a debug project (which also keeps its instructor texts).

9.3.3 sre eval-all [--display-grades / --no-display-grades]

Evaluates every running lab instance concurrently. `--no-display-grades` suppresses the per-lab grade summary.

9.3.4 sre check [-p] <lab> [<state>]

Validates a lab module without deploying: imports it, runs `Data.generate()`, checks that the `Data` instance survives the `data.json` round trip (`to_json()` / `from_json()`, `pack()` / `unpack()`), builds `NetScheme`, runs `initial()`, calls `Grade.grade()`. With `state`, also validates that state method. The networks that are not hubs are printed with their type and the VLANs of their ports, and the console commands a state sends to a managed switch are listed with its other operations (`switch <network>: cmd …`). The numbered sections of `informations` (`info_subtitle()` / `@@sec@@` markers) are resolved as at `sre start` and printed as an outline (number, title, tag), and the `@@ref@@` references of the question texts are checked: a marker outside a header, a level jump, a tag defined twice or unknown, or languages whose sections differ, is a `FAIL`.

9.3.5 sre watch [--timeout <sec>] [--interval <sec>] [-H <regexp>] [-S <time>] [-L] <dir…>

Live terminal dashboard scanning `<dir…>` for `.zst` archives. Default refresh: `params.default_dashboard_refresh_interval_in_watch_command`. `--timeout` is the inactivity-alert threshold (default 90 s). `-H/--hostname-filter` and `-S/--starting-time` preset the `R` and `S` keys.

One row per **running project instance** on a host: hostname + lab + the start timestamp of `running_lab_name`. A lab opened twice by the same student gives two rows with their own grades and alerts; a lab stopped then started again keeps its old row until it is dismissed (`P`), hidden (`S`) or collapsed. `-L/--only-last-instances` (the `L` key) collapses to one row per host and lab: the most recently *started* instance, whatever the age of its archives. Dismissals and `S` apply after the collapse, so they never reveal an older instance. Lab counts and statistics are per instance.

Columns (from each archive):

Column	Source
HOSTNAME / LOGIN	`answers["hostname"]` / `answers["login"]`
LAB NAME	Middle segment of `running_lab_name`, its `@` decoded back to `/` (the lab path given to `sre start`)
STARTED	First segment of `running_lab_name` (instance start; time only when today)
GRADE	`total_grade / total_max`
ERR	Length of `errors`
LAST EVAL	`eval_date` (`YYYYmmddHHMMSS`)
TIME REMAINING	`answers["exam_time_remaining"]` minus elapsed since `answers["answers_updated_at"]`

Keys:

Key	Context	Action
`t`	Any	Toggle focus between Projects and Alerts
`↑` / `↓`	Projects / Alerts	Move selection
`Enter`	Projects	On a project row: its grade elements; on a `Lab:` row: per-element aggregation over the lab's instances
`P`	Projects	Dismiss selected project instance (hostname + lab + start)
`H`	Projects	Dismiss all projects from the selected hostname
`R`	Projects	Set a hostname regexp filter (empty = show all; initial value: `-H`)
`S`	Projects	Only show projects with an archive received after a time (empty = no limit; initial value: `-S`)
`L`	Projects	Toggle "only last instances": one row per host and lab, the most recently started (initial value: `-L`)
`U`	Either	Un-dismiss all
`d` / `Enter`	Alerts	Dismiss selected alert
`q` / `Ctrl-C`	Any	Quit
`?`	Any	Toggle help

Dismissals self-expire: inactivity alerts return on new archives, error alerts return when the count changes.

9.3.6 `sre preload-images [--random-delay <sec>] [--progress] <file_or_dir…>`

Scans lab `.py` files for `image=` / `'image':` patterns and `docker pull`s each unique image. `--random-delay <sec>` waits 0–N seconds before pulling (smooths thundering-herd when invoked across many hosts). `--progress` also writes the steps as JSON lines on stderr (`{"phase": "preload", "status": "start", "total": N}`, then `"status": "pull"` with `image` / `current` / `total` before each pull and `"status": "error"` with `image` after a failed one); what is printed on stdout and the exit status are unchanged. It is what the agent of the web front-end runs when the portal gives its host a turn to preload (see *Pre-loading the images* in the pool section of the web front-end).

9.3.7 `sre make-titles [-o <file> | -r] <directory>`

Generates `titles.json` sidecars so the Open project dialog of the GUI and the Open page of the web front-end show friendly labels (e.g. `static_routing.py` → "Static routing"). Labs without a `title` attribute are skipped.

Option	Description
`-o, --output-file <file>`	Write all titles to `<file>` (incompatible with `-r`).
`-r, --recursive`	One `titles.json` per directory containing labs (incompatible with `-o`).

Output keys match `sre list`: `"<name>.py"` for file labs, `"<dirname>"` for directory labs. A rerun merges into the existing file: its options and the order of its entries are kept (a manual order survives), the labs found now are updated, the entries naming nothing on disk any more are dropped, the new labs are appended by name; a fresh file lists the labs by name. The languages of a title are written sorted, the file atomically. Stale entries are also dropped at read time by `sre list --with-titles`.

Options and sub-directories (written by hand): every key starting with `@` is an option, never an entry. `"@sort"` sets the order of the entries of the directory in the lab tree, the same in the GUI and on the web: `"name"` (the default: the file names, byte-wise), `"title"` (the labels in the language of the user, case and

accents ignored, numbers compared as numbers so that "TP 2" comes before "TP 10"; a lab without title sorts by its file name) or `"manual"` (the order of the entries in the file, then the unlisted ones by name). In every mode the sub-directories come first, then the labs. A directory without the option takes the one of the nearest ancestor (so `/opt/sre/lab/titles.json` sets the whole tree); an unknown value is ignored and `sre make-titles` warns about it. A key may also name a sub-directory, with a title (shown instead of its name) or `null` (listed for its position in the manual order only); `sre make-titles` keeps such entries as they are.

```
{
  "@sort": "manual",
  "s4":                {"en": "Semester 4",      "fr": "Semestre 4"},
  "static_routing.py": {"en": "Static routing", "fr": "Routage statique"},
  "tp_ssh":            null
}
```

Typical usage: `sudo /opt/sre/sbin/sre make-titles -r /opt/sre/lab`.

9.3.8 sre update [--main | --ref <tag|branch|commit>] [--check | --force] [-y] [--venv]

Updates the installation (`params.main_sre_dir`, `/opt/sre`) from the GitHub repository `sysreseval/sysreseval` (`params.update_github_repository`). Privileged only, and root only: the tree is root-owned. By default the latest published release is installed. The installed version is the commit recorded by the previous update in `<main_sre_dir>/.sre-update.json` (or the checked-out commit of a `git clone`), so an unchanged repository means "already up to date".

Option	Description
`--main`	Follow the head of the `main` branch instead of the latest release.
`--ref <tag|branch|commi`	Install this tag, branch or commit, e.g. the previous commit printed by the last update, to go back.
`--check`	Only report the installed and the available versions; nothing is changed.
`--force`	Install again even when the requested commit is already installed.
`-y, --yes`	No question: every customised parameter of `params.py` is kept and no confirmation is asked (required when stdin is not a terminal).
`--venv`	Rebuild the Python virtual environment (`make venv`, a few minutes) as the last step.

What an update does, in order:

1. Checks: no exam configured (`sre del-exam` first), a writable tree (on a read-only NFS mount, run it on the server), one update at a time.
2. Downloads the source archive of the commit into a temporary directory of the tree and decides everything before touching anything: which files change, which are deleted, what `params.py` becomes, and that the new code compiles with the venv's Python.
3. Prints a summary and asks for a confirmation (unless `--yes`).
4. Runs `sre wipe`: every running project is stopped and removed, since the new code may not handle projects started by the old one. Without a Docker daemon on the host (`params.docker_socket_path` missing, e.g. an NFS server), the wipe is skipped with a warning: run `sre wipe` on the client hosts.
5. Replaces the files and reapplies the ownership and modes of `scripts/install.sh` (root, world-readable; the entries of `lab/` and `lib/` to the `sre` user, not world-readable), removes the stale `__pycache__` directories, then runs `make fonts sre-wrapper` and makes `sbin/sre` and `bin/sysreseval` executable again.

What is installed, kept and deleted:

- `lab/`: only `lab/sre/` (`params.update_lab_subdirs`) is refreshed, and reinstalled in full; every other entry of `lab/` is the site's own and is left alone.
- `lib/`: the files of the repository are refreshed; the site's extra files are kept.
- Files the repository dropped are deleted only when a previous update (or the git index of a cloned tree) installed them: the first update of a tree that was not cloned deletes nothing.
- Never touched: `venv/`, `build/`, `graphics/fonts/`, `bin/sre-wrapper`, `.git/`, the `params.py` backups.
- `src/SRE/params.py` is merged, not copied. The installed file is backed up as `params.py.bak.<timestamp>` first. A parameter the site never changed takes the new value; a parameter customised here that the new version does not change keeps its value; a parameter both customised here and changed upstream is asked about, the installed value being the default (kept with `--yes`). `sre_version` and `default_docker_image_version` always take the new value; new parameters are added, dropped ones removed. The pristine upstream values come from the state file (or `git show` on a cloned tree); without them, every difference is asked about. The merged file must compile and run before anything is replaced.

The state file `.sre-update.json` records the commit, the ref, the date, the previous commit, the manifest of the installed files and the pristine parameter values. Hints printed at the end: the command to go back (`sre update --ref <previous commit>`), `make venv` when the `venv` recipe of the Makefile changed, the `scripts/etc/` templates that changed (system files to reinstall by hand), and the reminder that replicated hosts need their own `sre update` and NFS clients their own `sre wipe`.

9.4 Exam management

Exam state lives in `/var/lib/sre/exam.json` — see *Exam Reference* for the field schema. All field names are exposed as `params.exam_*` constants.

9.4.1 `sre set-exam [options]`

Creates or updates `exam.json`. Only provided options are updated; existing fields are preserved.

Option	Description
`--labs <lab[:flavor]…>`	Authorised labs, optionally with a named flavor preset (e.g. `tp1:hard`). Required on first creation.
`--start-after <datetime>`	Exam opens after this moment. ISO (`2026-06-01T09:00`) or time-only (`09:00`, today).
`--end-before <datetime>`	Exam closes before this moment.
`--duration <minutes>`	Max duration; ends at `started_at + duration` or `end_before`, whichever first. Effective only once formally started.
`--eval-interval <seconds>`	Period between automatic evals (default 60).
`--record-sessions <bool>`	Record terminal sessions (`true`/`false`/`0`/`no`).

9.4.2 `sre del-exam`

Removes `exam.json` and wipes all running projects.

9.4.3 `sre save-records -d <dir> [--only-last-record]`

Archives the `records/` directories of running projects as `.tar.gz` files in `<dir>`. `--only-last-record` deletes prior archives for the same project so only the latest remains.

9.5 Post-exam management

Reads and transforms `.zst` evaluation archives — see *Archive format* for the schema.

9.5.1 `sre cat [options] <file…>`

Prints archive contents. Without a field option, all fields are shown.

Option	Shows
`--data`	`data_json` (serialized `Data`)
`--tests`	Raw test results per machine
`--errors`	Evaluation errors
`--answers`	Student answers
`--grades`	Grade list, total grade, total max
`--files`	Files saved in the archive
`--extract-files`	Extract saved files to the current directory
`--json`	Emit a single JSON dict per file on stdout

9.5.2 `sre check-eval [-s <srelab>] <file…>`

Diffs stored grades against a re-grade (same logic as `re-eval` but without writing files). Prints per-element changes plus a summary count. `-s` selects an updated `srelab.py` or directory; if omitted, uses each archive's `.private/srelab` symlink.

9.5.3 `sre re-eval -s <srelab> -p <prefix> [-d <outdir>] [-r] [--update-web] <file_or_dir…>`

Re-grades archives with an updated `srelab.py`. Useful for fixing a grading bug post-exam.

Option	Description
`-s` / `--srelab`	Updated `srelab.py` or directory.
`-p` / `--prefix`	Prepended to each output archive filename.
`-d` / `--output-dir`	Output directory (default: current).
`-r` / `--recursive`	Recurse into subdirectories.
`--update-web`	Also replace the evaluations the web portal holds for these archives (see below).

`--update-web` is for a site with the *web front-end*: the Archives page of the portal shows what it collected when each evaluation ran, and a re-graded archive does not change it by itself. With the option, the new results of every archive re-graded are queued on the host, in `/var/lib/sre/web-updates/`, under the name of the archive they come from — the name the portal knows the evaluation by, whatever the prefix and the output directory — and the web agent of the host hands them to the portal at its next collection (30 s

by default), which replaces the grades, marks, errors and elements of its row. See *Re-evaluated archives* for what the row keeps.

- Run it **as root on a pool host** (a host with `sre-agent`): the queue belongs to the `sre` user, and nothing reads it on a host without agent (a warning says so). Any other user gets an error before anything is re-graded.
- Give the archives **under their original names** (the files of `/var/lib/sre/archives`, or copies of them): the output of an earlier `re-eval` (`corrected2026…`) and a renamed archive are re-graded but not queued, with an `error:` line each.
- The portal only updates evaluations it holds. An update whose evaluation it has not collected yet waits on the host and is applied once it has; it is given up after a day.
- The command ends with the number of evaluations queued; the portal's log says when it replaced them.

```
sudo sre re-eval -s /opt/sre/lab/_EXAM_/ssh_corrected.py -p corrected -d /tmp/regraded \
                --update-web /var/lib/sre/archives/*ssh*
```

9.5.4 `sre sheet -o <output.ods> [-r] [-S <time>] [-F <time>] [--separate-instances] <file_or_dir…>`

Exports archives to a LibreOffice ODS spreadsheet. Per distinct lab name, three sheets are produced:

Sheet	Content
`{lab_nam`	One row per archive, sorted by `login`, `hostname`, `project_start`, `eval_date`: `login`, `fullname`, `email`, `hostname`, `project_start` (start of the running project instance), `eval_date`, `errors`, `total_grade`, `total_max`, `mark`, `maximum_mark`, then one column per grade element
`Question {lab_nam 0`	Per-question: `max_grade`, `maximum grade`, `average`, `number of projects`, `projects grade`
`Sessions {lab_nam`	Per-student best score: `login`, `hostname`, `max score`, `sum of maxima`, then best score per question. With `--separate-instances`, one row per running project instance instead (a student who opened the lab twice gets two rows), with a `project start` column after `hostname`

`fullname` and `email` come from the archive's `answers` (empty if absent).

9.5.5 `sre outline [-o <summary.ods>] [-d <pdf_dir>] [-r] [-S <time>] [-F <time>] [--lang <lang>] [--no-timeline] [--remaining-time] [--separate-instances] [--users-file <file>] <file_or_dir…>`

Generates per-student PDF reports plus a summary ODS — best-graded archive per student (`login` + `hostname` + lab). At least one of `-o` / `-d` is required.

When a student opened the same lab several times, the best grade is taken across every instance and the evaluation history shows one table per instance, each headed by its start time. `--separate-instances` produces one PDF and one ODS row per running project instance instead: the PDF name gains `__<start timestamp>`, its header a "Project started" line, and the ODS a `project_start` column.

The PDFs are named `<login>__<lab>__<hostname>.pdf`, `<lab>` being the file name of the lab. When two labs of one student would give the same name (a course copy and the shipped lab, `s3/dns1.py` and `sre/dns1.py`), the second one is named after its whole path (`<login>__sre-dns1__<hostname>.pdf`) instead of being written over the first.

The hostname is part of what a student is here (the workstation: the users of a shared account are told apart by it). The reports of the web front-end, built by `sre report` from the same code, leave it out: a project of the web runs on any host of the pool (see *Web front-end*).

Option	Description
`-o` / `--output-file`	Output `.ods` summary (omit to skip).
`-d` / `--pdf-directory`	Output dir for PDFs (omit to skip).
`-r` / `--recursive`	Recurse into subdirectories.
`--lang <lang>`	Force PDF language (e.g. `en`, `fr`).
`--no-timeline`	Omit the evaluation-history table.
`--remaining-time`	Include the time-remaining column in the history.
`--separate-instances`	One report and one ODS row per running project instance instead of one per student.
`--users-file <file>`	User list `LOGIN NAME EMAIL` (whitespace/CSV; `#` comments; <3-field lines skipped).

Name / email resolution: `--users-file` (if provided) → `fullname` / `email` from archive answers. Columns appear only when at least one student has a non-empty value.

9.6 Internal commands (GUI-only)

9.6.1 `sre list [--with-titles] [--include-exam-only]`

Prints a JSON array of lab names relative to `/opt/sre/lab/` (`s4/tp_ssh`, `s2/lab.py`, …). Labs whose components match `params.exam_only_affix` (`_EXAM_`, `_OLD_`, `_DRAFT_`, `_TESTS_`) are hidden, unless `--include-exam-only` is given (privileged only: the web agent lists them to an instructor programming an exam; a student can still start such a lab by its exact name, which is how an exam project is created).

With `--with-titles`, output becomes the lab tree flattened in display order: `[{"name": <path>, "title": <dict|string|null>, "kind": "dir"|"lab", "sort": <mode>}, …]`, a directory entry (`"dir"`, listed when a lab lies below it) right before its content, the sub-directories of a directory before its labs (a directory lab is a `"lab"`), each group in the order of the effective `"@sort"` of the directory's `titles.json` (see `sre make-titles`; `sort` is that mode, `"name"`, `"title"` or `"manual"`: the GUI and the browser keep this order and only sort the `"title"` mode themselves, since it depends on the language of the user). Titles come from per-directory `titles.json`; stale entries are dropped, and entries without a title get `"title": null` (the front-ends then fall back to the file name).

9.6.2 `sre export <running_lab> [--sep <N>] [--curved] [--shapes] [--reverse] [--random-seed <N>]`

Exports a running project as a Kathara zip archive, base64-encoded on stdout. The project name is resolved like the other commands (exact name or unique substring, the ownership check of user mode). Flags tune the embedded schema: `--sep` 0–9 (default 3), `--curved` for curved edges, `--shapes` for geometric nodes, `--reverse` to flip insertion order, `--random-seed` for node-order permutation. The `lab.conf` of the archive carries the type of the networks that are not hubs and the VLANs of the ports (`CD_MODE[lan]="managed"`, `pc1[0]="lan/vlan=10"`, `r1[0]="lan/trunk=10,20"`): this is the syntax of the Kathara fork SRE installs, not of the upstream Kathara.

9.6.3 sre report <sheet|outline|summary> [--lang <lang>] [--separate-instances] [--bonus-in-prefix] [--no-timeline] [--remaining-time] [--no-parts] [-o <file>]

What the web agent runs for the **Reports** of the Archives page of the portal: the spreadsheet of `sre sheet` (`sheet`: an ODS), the PDF reports of `sre outline` (`outline`: a zip holding one PDF per student, lab and host, and `outline.ods`, the summary) or that summary alone (`summary`: the ODS `sre outline -o` writes, one row per student, lab and host — per running instance with `--separate-instances` — with the best evaluation; the PDF flags `--no-timeline`, `--remaining-time` and `--no-parts` do not apply), built not from `.zst` files but from **JSON archive records read on stdin** (`{"records": [...]}`: the records of `GET /v1/archives` of the agent, what the portal keeps of every archive in its database and rebuilds for the evaluations an instructor selected), and **written on stdout** (`-o <file>`: a file instead). Each record becomes the pseudo archive the two commands read (`archive_summary.raw_from_record`: the student metadata, the time, the totals, the grade elements and parts, the number of errors; the tests and the answers were never in a record), so the files are those `sre sheet` / `sre outline` give on the same archives. The flags are those of the two commands (`--lang` applies to the PDFs; the headers of the spreadsheets follow the `LANGUAGE` of the environment). Privileged only (an admin may run it like `sheet` and `outline`); exit 1 with `no records to process` on an empty or unusable list, a record without `running_lab_name` is skipped with a warning on stderr.

9.6.4 sre pre-start-exam

Stops non-exam projects, then starts all exam labs so images are pre-pulled. Called by the GUI ~60 s before `start_after`. In user mode with `params.check_project_owner` on, the projects of the other users of the host are stopped too, whatever their lab (the GUI only counts the caller's own tabs), and an exam lab is started unless the caller, or root, already runs one.

9.6.5 sre start-exam

Stamps `started_at` in `exam.json`. Called by the GUI once `now  start_after`.

9.6.6 sre eval-exam

Evaluates every running exam project concurrently. Called by the GUI on a periodic timer (every `eval_interval`) and once at exam end.

9.6.7 sre end-exam

Stamps `ended_at` and runs a final concurrent eval on every running exam project. Called by the GUI when the exam ends.

CHAPTER

TEN

EXAM REFERENCE

10.1 `exam.json` — single source of truth

Lives at `/var/lib/sre/exam.json` (`params.sre_pub_dir + "/" + params.exam_json_name`). The same file must exist on every student PC — distribute via NFS, rsync, or any deployment mechanism. All field names are exposed as `params.exam_*` constants; never hard-code them.

Field	Constant	Type	Meaning
`labs`	`params.exam_labs`	`[[lab, flavor|null], ...]`	Authorised labs + optional flavor preset (required)
`start_afte`	`params.exam_start_after`	ISO datetime	Exam opens after this moment
`end_before`	`params.exam_end_before`	ISO datetime	Exam closes before this moment
`duration`	`params.exam_duration`	int (min)	Max duration; default `params.default_exam_duration = 90`
`eval_inter`	`params.exam_eval_interva`	int (s)	Auto-eval period; default `params.default_eval_interval_during_exams = 60`
`record_ses`	`params.exam_record_sessi`	bool	Record terminal sessions; default `true`
`pre_start_`	`params.exam_pre_start_da`	list[ISO]	Written by `pre-start-exam`; one entry per call
`started_at`	`params.exam_started_at`	ISO datetime	Written by `start-exam`
`ended_at`	`params.exam_ended_at`	ISO datetime	Written by `end-exam`

The first six are set by the instructor (via `sre set-exam`); the last three are runtime state markers.

`labs` format: each entry is a two-element list `[lab_cli_arg, flavor_or_null]`, where `lab_cli_arg` is what `sre start` would receive (e.g. `s4/tp_ssh`) and the second element is the name of a `Flavor` preset or `null`:

```
"labs": [["s4/tp_ssh", null], ["s4/tp_dhcp", "hard"]]
```

Legacy plain-string entries are still accepted on read; always unpack via `params.parse_lab_entry(entry)`.

10.2 GUI exam logic

Each student GUI reads `exam.json` every second (`_update_exam_state`) and runs the same logic — there is no coordinator. The phase is computed from `exam.json` content alone (`_compute_exam_phase`):

- **Waiting** — `start_after` set, `now < start_after`, `started_at` not set.
- **Ended** — `end_before` set and `now ≥ end_before`, **or** `started_at` set and `now ≥ started_at + duration` (duration defaults to `params.default_exam_duration = 90`). The duration check fires only when `started_at` is set — without it, the exam was never formally started.
- Otherwise: **Active**.

`real_starting_time` (drives the countdown) = `started_at` if set, else `start_after` if set, else GUI process start time.

Phas	Preconditions	Actions
Wait ing	—	Show SRE logo + countdown to `start_after`. Once `now ≥ start_after - params.max_duration_between_exam_pre_start_and_start` (60 s) **and** `pre_start_date` is absent, fire `sre pre-start-exam` once (stops the non-exam projects and, with `check_project_owner`, the projects of the other users; starts the exam labs the student does not run yet; appends to `pre_start_date`).
Ac- tive	Exam containers up — one running project per lab in `labs`, no others (`_projects_ready`)	Fire `sre start-exam` once (stamps `started_at`; calls `pre-start-exam` internally if `pre_start_date` is missing). Show tabs + countdown. Every `eval_interval` s, fire `sre eval-exam` (skipped if previous still running). If `labs` changes, re-fire `sre pre-start-exam`.
Ende	—	Fire `sre end-exam` once (stamps `ended_at`, runs a final concurrent eval with `save-records --force`). Show "That's All Folks" until the instructor runs `sre del-exam`.

10.3 Commands

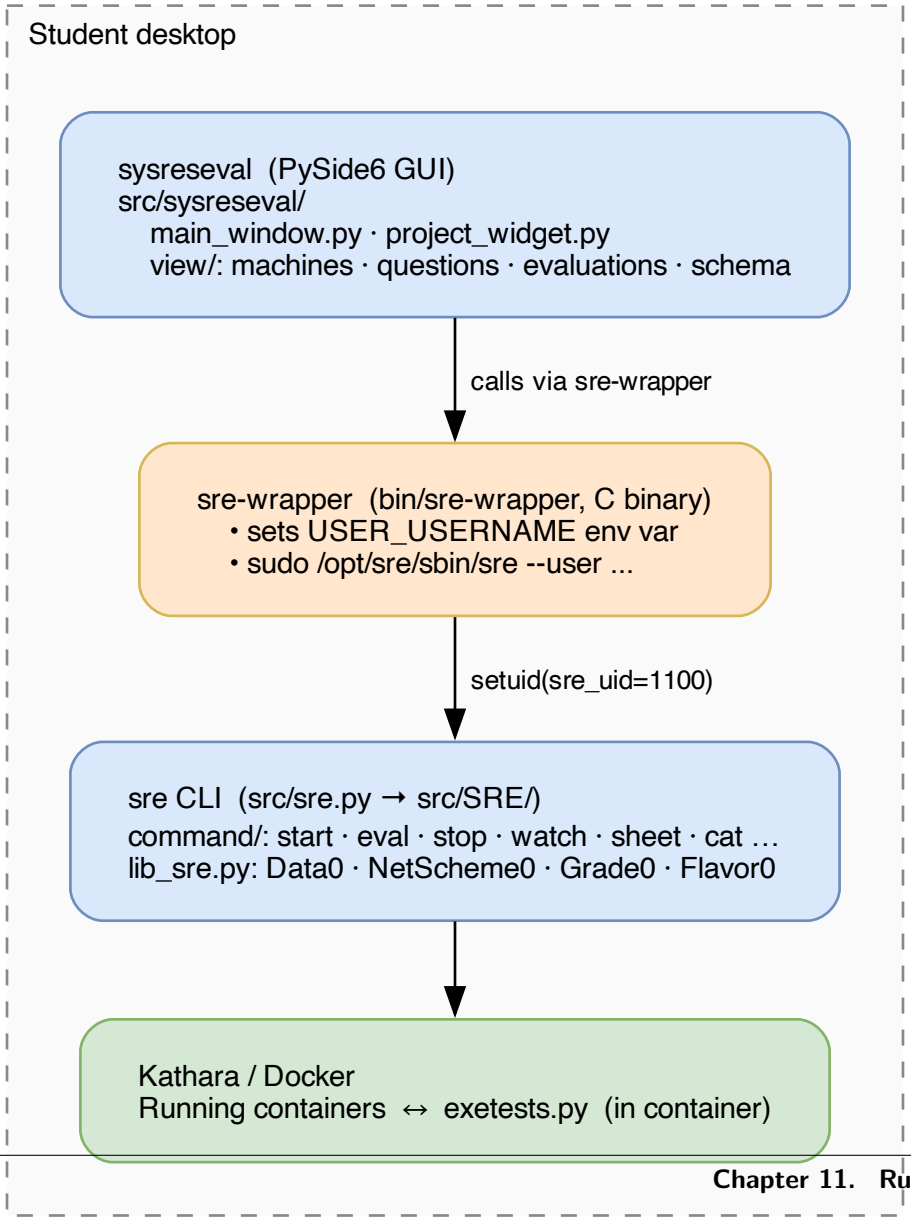
See *CLI Reference* for `set-exam`, `del-exam`, `pre-start-exam`, `start-exam`, `eval-exam`, `end-exam`, `save-records`, `watch`, `cat`, `check-eval`, `re-eval`, `sheet`, `outline`.

CHAPTER

ELEVEN

RUNTIME & INTERNALS

11.1 Architecture



Every command that touches Docker runs as user `sre` (uid `1100`): `sre-wrapper` exports `USER_USERNAME` and calls `sudo sre --user`; the CLI then drops from root to `sre_uid`. How the drop happens depends on the project:

- **Non-privileged projects** (no machine has `privileged=True`): privileges are dropped **permanently** at start via `setuid(sre_uid)` / `setgid(docker_gid)` — the process can never regain root for the rest of its life.
- **Privileged projects** (at least one machine has `privileged=True`): privileges are dropped **temporarily** via `seteuid`/`setegid` only. Kathara requires the deploy/connect/exec paths to run as genuine root (to mount cgroups, attach a TTY to `/sbin/init`, etc.), so the CLI raises the effective uid back to 0 around those operations and lowers it again afterwards. Host-side subprocesses still drop to `sre_uid` in the child via `preexec_drop_to_sre()`, so user code on the host never runs as root.

11.2 Filesystem layout

Path	Description
`/opt/sre/`	Installation root
`/opt/sre/sbin/sre`	CLI binary
`/opt/sre/bin/sre-wrapper`	C binary for student use (handles sudo)
`/opt/sre/bin/sysreseval`	GUI launcher script
`/opt/sre/lab/`	Lab files
`/opt/sre/lib/`	Shared libraries for project files (`ips.py`, `std.py`, `exetests.py`, `net_config.py`, `dhcp.py`, `ping.py`, `ssh.py`, `tls.py`, `grade_helpers.py`, `frr.py`, `state_helpers.py`, `pcap_gen.py`, `smtp.py`, `smtp_probe.py`, `utils.py`)
`/opt/sre/graphics/`	SVG icons and logos
`/opt/sre/locale/`	Compiled gettext translations for the CLI
`/opt/sre/.sre-update.json`	State of `sre update`: installed commit and ref, previous commit, manifest of the installed files, pristine upstream values of `params.py`
`/var/lib/sre/`	Runtime state root (`sre_pub_dir`)
`/var/lib/sre/exam.json`	Exam configuration (absent = no exam)
`/var/lib/sre/projects/`	One directory per running lab instance
`/var/lib/sre/archives/`	Default evaluation archive directory
`/var/lib/sre/last_self_gra`	Self-grade cooldown timestamps
`/home/sre/`	Shared directories for projects with `shared_path=True` (mode `0o777`, removed on stop/wipe)
`/var/lib/sre/tmp/`	Temporary directories of `sre save` / `sre restore` (`params.save_tmp_dir`; not `/tmp`, which may be a small tmpfs)

11.2.1 Running lab directory

```
/var/lib/sre/projects/{timestamp}@@@{lab_name}@@@{username}/
+-- .private/               mode 0o700
|   +-- data.json           serialized Data instance, mode 0o600
|   +-- srelab              symlink to the lab's srelab.py
|   +-- eval_in_progress    lock file (PID) during active eval
```

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```
|   +-- auto_eval.log       one ISO timestamp per student self-evaluation
+-- info.json               public machine/switch/question metadata (InfoLab;␣
↪`switches`: the visible networks with their type)
+-- operations.log          debug projects only: operations of every state / evaluation␣
↪(GUI Log tab), mode 0o644
+-- answers/
|   +-- answers.json        student answers (updated by GUI)
|   +-- cheat.json          instructor-provided answers (if any)
+-- shared/                 mode 0o777 (only if shared_path=True)
```

11.3 Configuration

11.3.1 Constants (`src/SRE/params.py`)

Constant	Value	Description
`sre_uid`	`1100`	UID of the `sre` system user
`docker_gid`	`988`	GID of the `docker` group
`check_project_owner`	`True`	User mode: a caller only sees and drives their own projects and those started by root or the `sre` user (`False`: every project of the host)
`max_docker_concurrency`	`16`	Max parallel Docker API calls during eval
`default_eval_interval_during_ex`	`60`	Default auto-eval period (s)
`default_exam_duration`	`90`	Default exam duration (min), used if `duration` absent from `exam.json`
`default_inactivity_threshold_in`	`90`	`sre watch` inactivity alert threshold
`max_duration_between_exam_pre_s`	`60`	Window before `start_after` during which `pre-start-exam` fires (s)
`email_in_gecos_last_field`	`True`	Extract last GECOS sub-field as student email
`terminal_cmd_prefix`	`["/usr/bin/mate-terminal", "--"]`	External terminal emulator
`terminal_font_size`	`12`	Default terminal font size (pt)
`terminal_color_scheme`	`"black_on_white"`	Default terminal colors
`exam_only_affix`	`["_EXAM_", "_OLD_", "_DRAFT_", "_TESTS_"]`	Name substrings that hide labs from `sre list`
`authorized_src_dir`	`['/opt/sre/lab', '/home/etudiant']`	Allowed lab source directories
`default_network_mode`	`"hub"`	Type of switch of a network that declares no `mode` (`network_modes`: `hub`, `switch`, `managed`)
`switch_user_commands`	`("help", "port/print", "port/setvlan", "vlan/create", …)`	Console commands a student may run on a managed switch; any other is refused in user mode
`hostname_keyword` / `login_keyword` / `fullname_keyword` / `email_keyword` / `language_keyword` / `group_keyword`	`"hostname"` / `"login"` / `"fullname"` / `"email"` / `"language"` / `"group"`	Keys used in `answers.json` and archive `answers` dict (`group`: the student group, web front-end only)

11.3.2 Environment variables

GUI / wrapper → sre CLI

Variable	Used by	Description
`USER_USERNAME`	sre CLI (with `--user`)	Student login name (set by `sre-wrapper` from the invoking `USER`)
`SRE_PUB_DIR`	sre CLI, GUI, tests	Override `/var/lib/sre`
`SRE_WRAPPER`	params.py	Override the sre-wrapper path
`LANG`	sre CLI	Loads French help strings when set to a French locale

sre CLI → containers

Injected into machines at deploy / `exec` / state-transition time.

Variable	Description
`SRE_LAB_NAI`	Running lab name (`{timestamp}@@@{lab_name}@@@{username}`) — defined by `params.sre_name_env_variable`
`SRE_XAUTH_(`	X authority cookie forwarded into privileged containers so GUI apps can reach the host X server — defined by `params.sre_xauth_cookie_env_variable`
`SRE_HOST_II`	Host IP reachable from containers (default `172.17.0.1`) — defined by `params.sre_host_ip_env_variable`

11.3.3 Locale

The CLI uses `gettext` (`locale/fr/LC_MESSAGES/sre.mo`); the GUI uses Qt `.qm` catalogs (`translations/sysreseval_fr.qm`). Both are regenerated by `make translations`.

11.4 Dynamic module loading

Each lab is loaded at runtime via `importlib.util.spec_from_file_location('srelab', ...)`. The module path must sit under `params.authorized_src_dir` (`/opt/sre/lab/` or `/home/etudiant/`), and `/opt/sre/lib/` is prepended to `sys.path` so labs can `from ips import …`, `from net_config import …`, etc.

11.5 Data serialization

`Data0` encodes to JSON/msgpack with a polymorphic envelope:

```
{
  "__type__": "srelab.Data",
  "data": {
    "secret": "changeme",
    "ips":   {"router": "10.0.0.1/24"},
    "nets":  {"lan1": "10.0.0.0/24"},
    "ips6":  {"router": "2001:db8::1/64"},
    "nets6": {"lan1": "2001:db8::/64"},
    "macs":  {}
  }
}
```

Value	Encoding
`IPv4Interface` inside `ips` container	`"10.0.0.1/24"`
`IPv4Network` inside `nets` container	`"10.0.0.0/24"`
`IPv6Interface` inside `ips6` container	`"2001:db8::1/64"`
`IPv6Network` inside `nets6` container	`"2001:db8::/64"`
`EUI` inside `macs` container	`"00-11-22-33-44-55"`
`IPv4Address` / `IPv6Address` (standalone field)	`{"__ip__": "10.0.0.1"}`
`IPv4Interface` / `IPv6Interface` (standalone field)	`{"__iface__": "10.0.0.1/24"}`
`IPv4Network` / `IPv6Network` (standalone field)	`{"__net__": "10.0.0.0/24"}`
`EUI` (standalone field)	`{"__mac__": "00-11-22-33-44-55"}`
Nested `Data0` subclass	`{"__type__": "module.ClassName", "data": {...}}`

The container keys and markers are the `params.data_json_*` constants. Files written before IPv6 support have no `ips6` / `nets6` keys: they load as empty containers.

`data.json` is saved mode `0o600` inside `.private/` (mode `0o700`).

11.6 Test execution

`Grade.run_tests()` per step:

1. Call `grade()` to *register* tests (no execution).
2. Group commands per machine and encode them into one env var `EXETESTS@@@{timeout}:{cmd}@@@{timeout}:{cmd}@@@…`.
3. Run `exetests.py` inside each container; outputs are separated by a per-run UUID.
4. Parse outputs into `self._tests[(machine, step)][(command, timeout)]`; repeat until `step > max_step`; call `grade()` a final time to compute grades.

Up to 16 machines tested concurrently (`ThreadPoolExecutor`). Exit codes: `0`–`255` actual, `-1` = timeout.

The console commands registered with `Grade.test_switch()` are stored in the same `self._tests`, under `(network, step)` and `(command, 0)`. They are not sent to `exetests.py`: after the containers of a step, `run_tests()` runs them one by one on the console of the managed switch (see *Switches*). Being ordinary entries of `tests`, they are archived and replayed by `sre re-eval` like the others.

11.7 Switches

The type of a network (`Network.mode`: hub, switch, managed switch — see *Hubs, switches and VLANs*) is the *mode* of its Kathara collision domain, a feature of the Kathara fork and of its VDE network plugin.

- **Deployment.** `NetScheme0.get_new_lab_from_scheme()` sets the mode of the Kathara link of each network that is not a hub and passes the declared VLANs of a port (`vlan=`, `tagged_vlans=`) when a machine is connected to a managed switch. Nothing is said for a hub, so a lab with hubs only makes the same Kathara calls as before and runs with the stock plugin. Kathara refuses a non-hub mode when the plugin does not advertise it (`KATHARA_SWITCH_MODES` in the plugin settings): `sre start` / `sre restore` then roll back and `start.quit_if_no_switch_modes()` reports the networks concerned.
- **Console.** A managed switch is a `vde_switch` started with a management socket, which Kathara reaches from the host (`Kathara.exec_link()`, one connection per command). `src/SRE/switch_console.py` is the only place where SRE uses it: `SwitchConsole.run(network, command)` re-

turns `(output, code)` — `0`, the error number of the switch, or `-2` — and never raises; a word `@machine` is replaced by the port found with `Kathara.get_link_ports()` (ports are labelled `<machine>:eth<N>` by the plugin). It serves `NetScheme.switch_cmd()` (applied by `sre state` with the host operations of the step), `Grade.test_switch()`, `sre exec` and `sre connect`.

- **Students.** `sre connect <project> <network>` in user mode is a prompt of SRE, not a raw access to the socket (which belongs to root and the Docker group): each line is checked against `params.switch_user_commands` before it is sent, and `connect.get_switch()` refuses a hub or a plain switch, a network of hidden machines only, and a switch closed by `allow_connection` (a debug project lifts the last two).
- **End of a session.** The shell of a machine dies with its container; nothing would end the prompt of a switch when its project is stopped. `switch_console.interactive()` therefore polls the project directory from a thread (every `params.switch_console_watch_interval` second) and, once it is gone, interrupts the prompt of the main thread with `SIGINT` — as Ctrl-C does, so that `readline` restores the terminal — and returns.
- **GUI.** `Grade0.save_lab_info()` writes `switches` in `info.json`: `{name, mode, allow_connection}` for every network a student sees. `view/switches_view.py` draws the Networks tab from it; the tab is always shown, hubs only or not.
- **Operations log.** Switch commands of states and evaluations are logged as `stepN - on switch <network> : <command>`.

11.8 Course text (`informations`)

The course of a lab and its question texts may hold the plain-text markers of `SRE.informations` (`## @@sec:tag@@ Title`, `@@tag:name@@`, `@@ref:tag@@` / `@@ref:tag:title@@`, `@@toc@@` / `@@toc:depth@@`), emitted by `info_subtitle()`, `info_tag()`, `info_ref()`, `info_toc()` (defined there, re-exported by `SRE.lib_sre` next to `tr()` and `instructor()`) or typed inside a `tr()` block. The engine is `src/SRE/informations.py` (imports `instructor_text` only):

- `Grade0.save_lab_info()` calls `resolve_informations()` on the `TranslatedText` of `informations` (language by language; the languages must declare the same sections and tags, in the same order) and `resolve_text()` on the question titles and descriptions and on the state descriptions with the resulting `Numbering`, before `strip_instructor()`. The GUI, `sre export` and the archives only ever see resolved text; `sre check` runs the same resolution and prints `outline()`.
- Resolved forms: a header becomes `## <a id="tag"></a>2.1. Title` (an untagged section gets the id `sec.2.1`, which no tag can equal), an anchor `<a id="tag"></a>`, a reference `[2.1](#tag)` in the course and the bare `2.1` in a question (the browser of a question has no anchor), the table of contents a nested markdown bullet list of such links, indented like the line of its marker so that the `dedent()` of `markdown_to_html()` still finds the common margin. Markers inside fenced code blocks are left untouched.
- The `@@sec@@`, `@@tag@@` and `@@toc@@` markers standing inside an instructor fragment are dropped (`@@ref@@` is resolved), so that a project in instructor mode is numbered like a student's one. A question hash is computed at registration from the marked title (`_tt_hash_str`), so a renumbering of the course never detaches stored answers.
- QTextBrowser knows the `id` anchors and scrolls to them on a `#tag` link without leaving the document. fpdf2 raises on an `<a>` without `href` and on a `#tag` link to a named destination it does not know: `pdf.markdown_to_html()` removes the anchors and unwraps those links (the numbers stay) before `write_html()`.
- Errors are `ValueError` with a lab-facing message (`sre check` prints them as `FAIL`).

11.9 Progress reporting

`sre start` emits JSON lines to **stderr** so the GUI can render progress:

```
{"phase": "pull",   "status": "start",    "image": "sre/base:1.10"}
{"phase": "pull",   "status": "progress", "image": "sre/base:1.10", "percent": 42}
{"phase": "pull",   "status": "end",      "image": "sre/base:1.10"}
{"phase": "deploy", "status": "start",    "total": 3}
{"phase": "deploy", "status": "progress", "current": 1, "total": 3}
{"phase": "deploy", "status": "end",      "total": 3}
```

11.10 Security model

Concern	Mechanism
Allowed UIDs	`sre.py` checks `os.geteuid()` against `sre_uid` and 0; exits otherwise
Privilege drop	Root calls `_drop_permanently()`, which `sys.exit()`s on failure
Lab path whitelist	`utils.py` checks `current_srelab_file` is under `authorized_src_dir`
Eval lock	Lock file opened with `O_CREAT | O_WRONLY | O_NOFOLLOW`; `flock(LOCK_EX)` prevents concurrent evals and symlink attacks
Host commands drop privileges	`preexec_drop_to_sre()` is `preexec_fn` for every host-side `subprocess.run()` (eval, state transitions)
Shell injection	`tls.py` quotes with `shlex.quote()`; `state_helpers.py` writes passwords to `/tmp/.sre_chpasswd` (mode `0o600`); usernames passed via env vars
`data.json` secrecy	Mode `0o600` in `.private/` (mode `0o700`)
Unknown `__type__` deserialization	`Data0.from_dict()` / `unpack()` / `Flavor0` raise `ValueError`
Single GUI instance	PID file at `/tmp/sysreseval-{uid}.pid` kills the previous instance
Student command restrictions	`user_not_allowed()` / `user_not_allowed_in_exam_mode()`
Project ownership	In user mode `utils.resolve_running_lab_name()` only resolves the projects of `common.project_accessible()` (`access.may_access_project()`: the caller's own and those of root / the `sre` user; `params.check_project_owner`); the GUI lists the same projects (`sysreseval.util.visible_projects()`); `sre wipe` is privileged only and `sre stop-all` stops the accessible projects
State access control	`@sre_state(user_allowed=False)` blocks students from re-applying protected states
Switch console	In user mode only the commands of `params.switch_user_commands` are sent to a managed switch (no port creation / removal, plugin loading, shutdown); `allow_connection` closes a console; the management socket itself is not readable by students

11.11 Archive format

Every evaluation writes a `zstandard`-compressed `msgpack` file with a `.zst` extension to `params.archive_dirs` (default `['/var/lib/sre/archives']`; labs may extend the list via a module-level `archive_dirs` attribute).

Filename: `{eval_date}_{running_lab_name}.zst` — `eval_date` is `YYYYmmddHHMMSS`, `running_lab_name` is `{timestamp}@@@{lab_name}@@@{username}`. The leading timestamp sorts chronologically with `ls`.

```
archive = {
    "running_lab_name": "{timestamp}@@@{lab_name}@@@{username}",
    "eval_date":        "20260615110042",
    "data_json":        "<JSON string>",        # serialized Data
    "tests": {
        ("router", 1): {("ping -c1 8.8.8.8", 5): ("64 bytes ...\n", 0), ...},
        ...
    },
    "errors":     ["error message", ...],
    "answers": {
        "<question_hash>":     "<student answer>",
        "hostname":            "pc-101",
        "login":               "alice",
        "fullname":            "Alice Martin",      # from GECOS, always present
        "email":               "alice@example.com", # when email_in_gecos_last_field=True
        "group":               "INFO1",             # web front-end only, when a group␣
↪source is configured
        "language":            "fr",
        "answers_updated_at":  "20260615110000",
        "auto_eval_count":     2,                   # self-evals before this one
        "exam_mode":           true,                # exam-mode only
        "exam_started_at":     "2026-06-15T09:00",  # exam-mode only
        "exam_duration":       120,                 # exam-mode only
        "exam_time_remaining": 3600,                # exam-mode only
    },
    "grade_list": [
        {"title": "Connectivity", "max_grade": 4, "grade": 4,
         "grade_letter": null, "description": ""},
        ...
    ],
    "total_grade":  14.0,
    "total_max":    20.0,
}
```

Archives are written by `sre eval`, `eval-all`, `eval-exam`, `end-exam`, `re-eval`, and consumed by `sre cat`, `sheet`, `outline`, `check-eval`, `watch` — see *CLI Reference*.

11.12 Save file format

`sre save` writes, and `sre restore` reads, a single `.sre` file (`src/SRE/save_archive.py`). The layout is sequential so that `sre restore -` can consume it from stdin:

```
SRESAVE1\n                          magic (params.save_file_magic)
{"format_version": 1, …}\n          one-line cleartext JSON header (keys =␣
```

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```
↪params.save_meta_*)
<payload>                          tar stream - encrypted when the lab defines save_key
```

Header fields: `format_version`, `sre_version`, `lab_name` (the `lab@path` form), `running_lab_name`, `srelab_file`, `username`, `saved_at`, `debug_project`, `full_images`, `shared_path`, `encrypted`, `kdf_salt`, `kdf_iterations`.

Payload members:

Member	Content
`data.json`	`.private/data.json` of the saved instance
`kathara.tar`	The patched Kathara `save_lab` archive: `manifest.json` (topology, `save_mode`, per-device `original_image`, `deletions`, saved image tag `kathara_save_<hash>:<device>`) and `images/<device>.diff.tar` (filesystem diff, default) or `images/<device>.tar` (full image, `--full-images`)
`answers`	Student answers and `cheat.json`
`files/`	`.private/files` (host-side files of `cp_to_host()` / `host_cmd()`)
`user_*/`	Contents of the user public dir (`/home/sre/<lab>[_N]/`): `shared/` and the relative-path volume directories
`mnt/`	`.private/mnt` (private volumes), when present

Not saved: `info.json` (regenerated), `records/`, the eval lock, and what was changed on the console of a managed switch after the start (the restored switches get their type and the VLANs the lab declares; the lab's `restore` state can re-apply more with `switch_cmd()`). Kathara's diff excludes `/etc/hosts`, `/etc/hostname`, `/etc/resolv.conf`, `/dev`, `/proc`, `/sys`, `/run`, `/tmp`, `/hosthome`, `/shared`, `/hostlab`; bind-mounted directories are covered by `user_public/` and `mnt/` instead.

Encryption (`save_key`): the payload tar stream is cut into `params.save_cipher_chunk_size` chunks, each sealed with AES-256-GCM (key = PBKDF2-HMAC-SHA256 of `save_key` with the header's salt). Frame: `[4-byte length][1-byte last flag][12-byte nonce][ciphertext+tag]`; the associated data is `sha256(header) + chunk index + last flag`, so header tampering, reordering and truncation are detected. The `cryptography` package is imported lazily (only needed for encrypted files).

Restore (`src/SRE/command/restore.py`): read the header → import the lab module (`allow_save_restore` required, `save_key` checked) → extract the payload into `/var/lib/sre/tmp` with `tarfile.data_filter` → recreate the project directories with the `start.py` helpers (`ProjectSetup`, `create_project_directories`), copy the saved project files back and give them to the student (answers `0o666`, `shared/` and volume dirs `0o777`) → build the Kathara lab from the restored `Data` (`get_new_lab_from_scheme()`: fresh host ports, X11 cookie, volumes, `/shared`) → `Kathara.restore_lab(kathara.tar, lab=…)` (images rebuilt from the base image + diff, deployed with the same `pull`/`deploy` progress events as `start`) → refresh `exetests.py` → `finalize_project` (lifecycle state `restore`, `data.json`, `info.json`). Any failure triggers `rollback_project` (undeploy + directory removal). Restored images (`kathara_save_<hash>:<device>`) are not garbage-collected; `docker image prune` removes the unused ones.